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A Sketch Grammar of Amharic

Field Methods, Spring 2021

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Table of Contents

Introduction

3 - Language Background (Laura Rapp & Daphne Iskos)

4 - About the Consultant - Eyerus Abebaw (Eyerusalem Abebaw)

5 - English/Amharic Phrasebook (Vivian Bauer & Melia Gelinas)

Phonetics

8 - Amharic IPA Chart (Stephanie Konadu-Acheampong)

8 - Consonants (Stephanie Konadu-Acheampong, Thomas Sasdi, & Rositsa Ivanova)

19 - Glottal Stops (Hannah Staats)

21 - Arabic-Amharic Consonant Correspondences (Matthew Wilkinson)

24 - Vowels (Stephanie Konadu-Acheampong & Thomas Sasdi)

30 - Suprasegmentals (Stephanie Konadu-Acheampong)

Phonology

31 - Phonological Processes (Hannah Staats & Thomas Sasdi)

34 - Syllable Structure (Laura Rapp & Shea Husband)

37 - Fidels (Lily Jenssen)

Morphosyntax

39 - Word Order (Maggie Kohl, Melia Gelinas, Shea Husband, & Jeongyeob Hong)

42 - Alignment (Laura Rapp, Jacky James, Hannah Staats)

47 - Copulative Sentences (Shea Husband & Jacky James)

51 - Heads and Dependents (Shea Husband & Jacky James)

54 - Noun Class (Jeongyeob Hong)

57 - Definiteness (Daphne Iskos, Laura Rapp, & Jeongyeob Hong)

64 - Case Marking (Jeongyeob Hong, Shea Husband, & Jacky James)

67 - Adjectives & Quantifiers (Rositsa Ivanova & Stephanie Konadu-Acheampong)

71 - Possession (Jane Whitley & Matthew Wilkinson)

73 - Adpositional Phrases (Rositsa Ivanova, Shea Husband, & Maggie Kohl)

77 - Tense/Aspect/Mood (Jacky James, Maggie Kohl, Jennifer Yang, Shea Husband, & Rositsa Ivanova)

85 - Verbal inflection (Matthew Wilkinson)

95 - ɪndɪ(t^h) Verbal Prefix: A Dependency Marker (Shea Husband)

97 - Non-Finite Verbs (Hannah Staats)

104 - Nonconcatenative Morphology (Matthew Wilkinson)

117 - Diminutives/Augmentatives (Jane Whiltley, Hannah Kusserow, & Jeongyeob Hong)

120 - Valency Changing Processes (Jacky James, Lily Jenssen, Laura Rapp, & Pat Vaidos)

124 - Clefts (Lily Jenssen, Shea Husband, Rositsa Ivanova)

127 - Interrogatives (Vivian Bauer, Rositsa Ivanova, & Jennifer Yang)

130 - Purpose Clauses (Ethan Shaw)

131 - Negation (Melia Gelinas & Jacky James)

Discourse & Pragmatics

133 - A Recipe in Amharic: Shiro (Vivian Bauer & Pat Vaidos)

137 - Discourse Particles (Shea Husband & Pat Vaidos)

141 - Structure of Stories (Shea Husband)

144 - Reduplication (Shea Husband)

Additional Observations

147 - Onomatopoeia/Sound Symbolism (Melia Gelinas & Hannah Kusserow)

150 - Reading vs Speaking Amharic (Stephanie Konadu-Acheampong)

153 - Numbers (Melia Gelinas, Thomas Sasdi)

157 - Dates and Time in Amharic (Stephanie Konadu-Acheampong, Thomas Sasdi, Ethan Shaw)

163 - Language Ideologies (Anni Clark)

165 - Tongue Twisters/Word Games (Maggie Kohl, Hannah Staats)

167 - Reported Speech (Lily Jenssen)

168 - Jokes & Humor (Daphne Iskos)

170 - Slang (Vivian Bauer)

171 - Memes (Anni Clark)

173 - Nicknames (Daphne Iskos & Pat Vaidos)

174 - Terms of Endearment (Daphne Iskos & Hannah Kusserow)

175 - Loanwords (Maggie Kohl)

177 - Ge'ez (Ethan Shaw)

178 - Arabic-Amharic Cognates (Matthew Wilkinson, Ethan Shaw, Hannah Kusserow, Hannah Staats)

Introduction

Amharic Language Background - Laura Rapp, Daphne Iskos



[1]Amharic is a Semitic language that is predominantly spoken in the East-African country of Ethiopia alongside Argoba, Tigrinya, Tigre, Geez, and many more. While it is one of the nation's official languages, Amharic is not only spoken in Ethiopia but also used in various regions around the world. Overall, there are around 22 million people who speak Amharic globally. Of that 22 million, about 2.4 million are Ethiopian immigrants who speak Amharic outside of Ethiopia, located most prominently in North America, Europe & Australia (Demeke).

Semitic languages were first introduced into Ethiopia by migrants from Yemen. Amharic developed during this time period and became the lingua franca of Ethiopia for trading and business in the 9th century; it then became one of the principal languages of the state in the 14th century. Major literature on the history of Amharic and Amharic linguistics, however, did not arise until the 19th century (Augustyn, et. al). Nonetheless, the language itself has grown to be the 2nd most widely spoken Semitic language in the world after Arabic. As Amharic continues to spread and grow, linguists also continue to gather more information about its characteristics. The following sketch grammar contributes to this body of ongoing research by providing and analyzing various findings on Amharic's phonetics, phonology, morphology, syntax, and other areas of interest. The entirety of the following data was collected by the Macalester College Spring 2021 Field Methods class during multiple interview and elicitation sessions with a fellow Macalester student who speaks Amharic. A self-introduction written by the consultant in question, Eyerus Abebaw, is included below.

[1] https://www.shutterstock.com/image-vector/ethiopia-political-map-capital-addis-ababa-208602655

About the Consultant - Eyerus Abebaw

Hi! My name is Eyerus Abebaw, and I'm a sophomore. I was the consultant for Field Methods, and I speak Amharic. I was born and raised in Addis Abeba, Ethiopia where Amharic is one of the main languages spoken, so it was my first language. However, I grew up in a bilingual household where I heard Oromigna spoken quite frequently as well (unfortunately can't speak or understand it fluently). Because of how ethnically diverse Addis Abeba is, I was also exposed to other common languages such as Tiginya although not to the same degree as I was to Oromigna. While living in Ethiopia for 9 years, I had constant exposure to Amharic at my school where it was the main language of instruction. My school also tried to teach us English, French, and Arabic, but most of my classmates and I only picked up English as a consistent second language. After moving to the U.S., I mainly spoke Amharic with my immediate family or at community or religious events when I was around other Amharic speakers from different areas in the Twin Cities. Upon moving to campus, it became even more challenging to find opportunities to speak Amahric, but about a year ago I started rediscovering some of the music I listened to back in Ethiopia and that became a more personal way that I was able to stay connected with my native language.

English/Amharic Phrasebook - Vivian Bauer and Melia Gelinas

English	Amharic
1. Hello	sɐˈlɐm
2. Goodbye	t͡ʰʃa͡u
3. Hi! How are you!	'ɛnde͡ɪtʰ 'notʰ
4. Greeting for female children	ɐntʃi tʰotʰɐ
5. Greeting for male children	ɐntɛʰ tʰotʰɐ
6. Greeting for Teacher	sɐ'lɐm 'ɛnde͡ɪtʰ 'nɐt͡ʃu
7. How are you (m)	'ɛnde͡ɪtʰ 'nɐkʰ
8. How are you (f)	'ɛnde͡ɪtʰ 'nɛʃ
9. Yes	ɑwo
10. No	ɪmbi
11. Maybe	mɛnɑlbatʰ
12. Please (f)	ɪbakʰɪʃ
13. Please (m)	ɪbakʰɪʰ
14. Sorry	jɪkʾɛrtʰa
15. Thank you	amɛsɛgɛˈnãla͡u
16. Congratulations	koŋgɾɑ
17. Good night (m)	dɛnɐdɛɾ
18. Good night (f)	dɛnɐdɛɾi
19. Good morning (addressing m.)	ɪn'det ɐˈdeɾk
20. Good morning (addressing f.)	ɪn'det ɐˈdeɾʃ
21. Good afternoon/evening (m.)	ɪn'det wɐlkʰ
22. Good afternoon/evening (f.)	ɪn'det wɐlʃ
23. It's nothing	mɪnɪmɐjɾɐlɛm
24. It's no problem	ˈtʰʃĩgɪɾ jɐˈla͡um, ˈtʰʃĩgɪɾ eˈla͡um
25. I am well	den ɐˈnɛŋ
26. Oh my goodness!	'we͡ɪgu:d
27. What's your problem?	mɪndɪ'no͡u t͡ʃɪgɪɾɪʃ
28. You are not gonna believe what I'm aboutta tell you!	ɛhe͡ɪ nɐgɐr βɪnɐgɾɪʃ ɐtʰɐmiɲəm

29. Dagem (Eyerus's Sister) Since I've seen you so much time has passed	dɐgɪm kʰɐjoʃ bɪzu sɐʔɐt ɐfwɐl
30. Greeting for elderly respected person that you haven't seen in a while	ɛrˈson lɐbɐˈzu ˈsɐʔɐtʰ ɐˈlɐjon
31. I understand	gabaɪn
32. I don't understand	algəbaiɲɛm
33. I know	akˈalaʊ
34. I don't know	alaʊkɛm
35. No thanks (polite rejection)	bɛkˈaɪn
36. It's okay I don't want that	ʧʌgəɾɛlm alfɛldɪgum
37. I want	ɛfɛlɛˈgallau
38. I don't want	alfɛldɪgum
39. Thanks a lot	bɛtam amɛsɛgɛˈnãla͡ũ
40. Thanks to a specific person	id mɛɪ lɛ _____
41. Nevermind (f)	taɪju
42. Nevermind (m)	taʊaʊ

Some general notes about Amharic: Keep in mind the audience you're addressing when speaking, because it has gendered forms based on if you are speaking to a female, male, or plural audience! For example take a look at these three greetings:

1. ɐntʃi tʰotʰɐ
   you.F monkey
   Greeting for female children

2. ɐntɛʰ tʰotʰɐ
   you.M monkey
   Greeting for male children

3. sɐˈlɐm ˈɛnde͡ɪtʰ ˈnɐt͡ʃu
   Hello how are you.PL
   Greeting for Teacher

The first two examples are used particularly when children are acting more wild or misbehaving. Monkey's have a sly connotation that is often applicable to children. Note that the form of "you" is changed based on whether a girl or boy is being addressed. Also note in

example (6), while this phrase is technically addressing just the teacher, it uses a plural form because of the plural atmosphere of a classroom.

When greeting an elderly and respected person like a grandmother, the pronoun changes as well to /ɛrˈson/. There is no gender distinction with this pronoun; it can be used for male or female elderly people. Below are three phrases where /ɛrˈson/ is used, always at the beginning of a sentence.

4. ɛrˈson lɐbɐˈzu ˈsɐʔɐtʰ ɐˈlɐjon
[2.FORM meet/see.1sg.PERF time long]
Greeting for elderly respected person that you haven't seen in a while

5. ɛrˈson 'ɛnde͡ɪtʰ 'notʰ
[2.FORM how are you]
"Greeting for elderly respected person"

6. ɛrso͡ʊ ɛnde͡ɪtʰa dɐro
"2.FORM how did.PAST sleep?"
"How did you sleep? (respectfully)"

Phonetics

Consonants:

Figure 1:

Amharic IPA Chart

CONSONANTS	Bilabial	Labiodental	Alveolar	Postalveolar	Palatal	Velar	Glottal
Pulmonic							
Plosive	(pʰ) b		tʰ d			kʰ g	ʔ
Nasal	m		n		ɲ	{ŋ}	
Trill			{r}				
Tap			ɾ				
Fricative		f (v)	s z	ʃ ʒ			h
Affricate				tʃ dʒ			
Approximant					j		
Lateral approximant			l				
Non-pulmonic							
Ejective plosive	(p')		t'			k'	
Ejective fricative			s'				
Ejective affricate				tʃ'			
Geminate							
Plosive						k':	
Nasal	*m:*		n:				
Tap			ɾ:				
Fricative			*s:*				
Lateral Approximant			l:				
Other							
Labio-velar approximant	ʍ w						

Sounds that appear only in loan words presented in parentheses

Allophones presented in curly brackets

Hypothesized phonemes presented in italics

Plosives:

Amharic has three bilabial plosives /pʰ/, /p'/, and /b/ (7-9)

7.	/pʰ/	[pʰarkʰ]	park
8.	/p'/	[p'agume]	13th month of the Ethiopian calendar
9.	/b/	[babur]	train

The voiceless bilabial plosives /pʰ/ and /p'/ appear to have entered Amharic from other languages, existing only in loanwords. However, they seem to have followed different routes of entry into the language. While /pʰ/ seems to be a more recent addition to Amharic, occurring exclusively in words derived from English, such as [pʰark] "park" and [eɾopʰlen] "airplane," /p'/ on the other hand is found in words not derived from English, and instead seems to have entered into Amharic from another Ethiopian language. This is evidenced by its occurrence in the word [p'agume], a word that was described as being native to Amharic, but due to its definition could possibly have originated from another Ethiopian language. This use of /p'/ as a loan sound would have continued for many years, being used in loan words such as [p'iasa] "marketplace," [p'entɛ] "Pentacostal," [t'ɛrɛp'eza] "table", and [p'awlos] "Paulos" from languages that would have had contact with Amharic many centuries ago. This use of /p'/ as the sound for loaned voiceless plosives would have continued up until very recently, after which more consistent contact with languages such as Italian and English would have led to the adoption of /pʰ/ for loans with voiceless plosives.

By comparison, the voiced bilabial /b/, I believe, is truly native to Amharic, appearing in words such as [bɛɪtʰ] "house" and "[abatʰ]" father that, while strongly related to their counterparts in other Semitic languages such as Arabic, I would expect to be cognates rather than loans.

The voiceless bilabials appear word initially and word medially, with the only word-final occurrence of voiceless plosives being a result of word-final devoicing of word-final /b/. Voiceless bilabials, however, can occur in all environments (10-12).

10.	/pʰ/ / X__X	[apʰɪl]	apple
11.	/p'/ / X__X	[t'ɛrɛp'ɛza]	table

12.	*/p’/ / X__#	/dɛbub/ → [dɛbuḇ] *[dɛbup’]	North (formal)

Unlike the bilabials, it seems that all alveolar and velar plosives, including the voiceless pulmonic plosives, are native to Amharic. We did not find examples of these sounds in all environments, specifically we were unable to find word-final occurrences of /g/ within our data. However, every other native plosive, including /b/, can occur word finally, and so it would seem unlikely that /g/ is the only native plosive not able to occur in that environment. Thus, we argue that all alveolar and velar plosives can occur in any general environment, either word initially, medially, or finally. Alveolar plosives are shown in 13-15 while velar plosives are shown in 16-18. Additional environments for the plosives that are not already demonstrated by these examples are shown in 19-26.

13.	/tʰ/	[tʰanaʃ]	younger
14.	/t’/	[t’awatʰ]	morning
15.	/d/	[dagotʰ]	hill
16.	/kʰ/	[kʰatʰɛgɛb]	by
17.	/k’/	[k’alatʰ]	sentence
18.	/g/	[ga]	at, in
19.	/t’/ / X__X	[fɪt’rɛtʰ]	nature/environment
20.	/t’/ / X__#	[rut’]	run! (masc)
21.	/d/ / X__X	[fidɛl]	letter
22.	/d/ / X__#	[bɪɽḏ]	cold
23.	/kʰ/ / X__X	[kʰokʰob]	star
24.	/kʰ/ / X__#	[mɛbrɛkʰ]	lightning
25.	/k’/ / X__X	[mak’sajɲo]	Tuesday
26.	/k’/ / X__#	[ruk’]	far

Nasals:

Amharic has three nasal phonemes as seen below:

27.	/m/	[ɛmimɛr]	sour
28.	/n/	[jɛ minɛfsau]	that blows
29.	/ɲ/	[at^{h}amiɲɛm]	you won't believe me

Similar to alveolar and velar plosives, all nasals appear to be native to Amharic. From our data, it seems that phoneme /ɲ/ is restricted to word medial and word final positions as seen here:

30.	/ɲ/ / X__#	[asrazɛt'ɛɲ]	nineteen
31.	/ɲ/ / X__X	[ɪɲɑ]	we

On the other hand, both /m/ and /n/ appear in all distributions. Word medially, as shown above, but additionally, word finally and initially.

32.	/n/ / #__X	[nɛdɛt^{h}atʃ^{h}]	down
33.	/m/ / #__X	[mɛdɛnnɛs]	to dance
34.	/n/ / X__#	[k'ɛn]	day
35.	/m/ / X__#	[dɛm]	blood

Additionally, phoneme /n/ is one of a few phonemes that is often found in consonant clusters as seen here:

36.	/n/ / V__C	[sɪˈmɪnt^{h}]	eight

Finally, an allophone of /n/, [ŋ] appears only before velar plosives due to place assimilation:

37.	/ŋ/ / #__k	[p^{h}iŋk^{h}]	pink
38.	/ŋ/ / #__g	[iŋg̬izˈɛɲa]	English

39.	/ŋ/ / #__k’	[k'waŋk'wa]	language

Rhotics: Thomas

There seems to be one rhotic consonant, the alveolar tap /ɾ/. This phoneme has two allophones, [ɾ] and [r] which, while having individual preference for some environments, can occur in free variation. Intervocalic environments seem to exclusively feature [ɾ], such as in the words [doɾo] “chicken” and [zaɾe] “today”. Meanwhile, [r] is generally found in consonant clusters such as in [art^{h}] “art” and [mebrek] “lightning.” The reason why I determine these to be allophones of tap rather than trill, is because [ɾ] has surfaced in the consonant cluster environments favored by [r], such as in the word /bɪɾd̥/ “cold” which as been realized in our elicitation session as both [bɪɾd̥] and [bɪrd̥], while [r] does not seem to have surfaced in intervocalic environments. Further, when asked directly about the trill that was produced in the word [art^{h}], our speaker noted that it should have been a tap rather than a trill. Free variation between these allophones also occurs at word boundaries, such as in the words /ɾɛdʒɪm/ “tall” and /sɛfɛɾ/ “city.”

40.	[ɾ] / V__V	[doɾo]	chicken
41.	[ɾ] / V__V	[zaɾe]	today
42.	[r] / __C	[art^{h}]	art
43.	[r] / C__	[mebrek’]	lightning
44.	[ɾ] ~ [r] / __C	[bɪɾd̥] ~ [bɪrd̥]	cold
45.	[ɾ] ~ [r] / #__	[ɾɛdʒɪm] ~ [rɛdʒɪm]	tall
46.	[ɾ] ~ [r] / __#	[sɛfeɾ] ~ [sɛfɛr]	city

Fricatives and Affricates: ~ Rosie

Amharic has two labiodental fricatives, /f/ and /v/.

47.	/f/	[k^{h}ɛˈfɪl]	room
48.	/v/	[t^{h}ɛlɛvɪˈʒen]	television

The sound /f/ seems to be native to Amharic and can appear in all environments. It is shown in a word medial position above, and shown word initially and word finally below.

49.	/f/ / #__X	[fitʰ]	face
50.	/f/ / X__#	[dof]	rainy day

The sound /v/ appears only in loanwords which exist in the English language. It appears in all environments as well, with word medial being shown above, and word initial and word final being shown below.

51.	/v/ / #__X	[ˈva͡ɪvɛr]	Viber
52.	/v/ / X__#	[pʰozeˈtʰiv]	positive

Amharic has three alveolar fricatives, /s/, /s'/, and /z/.

53.	/s/	[sɑˈmɪntʰ]	week
54.	/s'/	[s'ɑˈha͡ɪ]	sun
55.	/z/	[ˈzɑfu]	the tree

The sounds /s/ and /z/ can both occur in all environments, while the ejective /s'/ appears more rarely and only word initially (from the data that we have). The word initial environments for all three fricatives are shown above, and the word initial and word medial examples for /s/ and /z/ are shown below.

56.	/s/ / X__X	[aˈsɪr]	ten
57.	/s/ / X__#	[k'ɪrs]	shape (of the moon)
58.	/z/ / X__X	[k'ɑsk'ɑzɑ]	cold drink
59.	/z/ / X__#	[ˈʃɛmiz]	button up

The phoneme /s/ is also often found in consonant clusters, as shown below.

60. /s/ / C__V [nɛfsotʃ] spirits

Amharic has two postalveolar fricatives, /ʃ/ and /ʒ/.

61. /ʃ/ [tʰɪkʰɛʃa] shoulder
62. /ʒ/ [tʰɛrɛkeʒɑ] unknown

The sound /ʃ/ seems to be native to Amharic as it is also often used in the third person singular feminine suffixes, and can appear in all environments. It is shown in a word medial position above, and shown word initially and word finally below.

63. /ʃ/ / #__X [ˈʃɪnkʰurtʰu] onion
64. /ʃ/ / X__# [tʰɪˈnɪʃ] small

The sound /ʒ/ appears only in loanwords and can only be found word medially, as shown above. Below is another example of /ʒ/ in word medial distribution.

65. /ʒ/ / X__X [tʰɛlɛvɪˈʒen] television

Amharic has three affricates, /tʃ/, /tʃʾ/, and /dʒ/, as seen below:

66. /tʃ/ [ʧa͡ʊ] goodbye
67. /tʃʾ/ [ʧʾɑwɑ] quiet
68. /dʒ/ [endʒɑˈrɑ] flat bread

The phonemes /tʃ/ and /tʃʾ/ both appear in all distributions (word initial is shown above, word medial and final are shown below).

69. /tʃ/ / X__X [ɑjɑtʰoˈtʃʰɛ] my grandparents
70. /tʃ/ / X__# [nɛfsotʃ] spirits
71. /tʃʾ/ / X__X [tʃʾɛˈtʃʾɛbsa] a type of breakfast food

72.	/tʃʾ/ / X__#	[t'ɑˈfɑtʃʾ]	sweet

The sound /dʒ/ appears word medially, as can be seen above, and word finally, as can be seen below. It only appears word initially in one word (example 73), which is a loan word, so it probably does not occur naturally in word initial positions.

73.	/dʒ/ / #__X	[dʒɑkʰɪtʰ]	jacket
74.	/dʒ/ / X__#	[lɪdʒ]	child

Approximants:

Amharic has four approximant phonemes as seen below:

75.	/j/	[jɑlɛk'sɐl]	he cries
76.	/l/	[laj]	on
77.	/w/	[waltʰaltʃʰɪlɪm]	none of them
78.	/ʍ/	[ʍɑlɑ]	behind

Each of these approximant phonemes, aside /ʍ/ can be found in all distributions (word initially, medially, and finally). However, given their vowel like qualities, one could argue that /w/ and /j/ do not appear word finally-- only word initially and medially-- and that vowels, rather, end the following words:

79.	/w/ / X__#	[nɛw]	is
80.	/u/ / X__#	[nɛu]	is
81.	/j/ / X__#	[laj]	on
82.	/i/ / X__#	[lai]	on

On the other hand, /ʍ/ is a rare phoneme that only appeared in two forms of one word; the phoneme appears word initially and word medially.

83.	/ʍ/ / #__X	[ʍɑlɑ]	behind

84. /ʍ/ / X__X [bɛʍala] behind/after

As such, it is unclear if this is a sound native to Amharic or what other environments, if any, it can appear in. Eyerus noted that this is a quite rare sound and that not many words begin with it.

Finally, phoneme /l/ is another phoneme that is often found in consonant clusters as seen below:

85. /l/ / V__C [walt^{h}alt$\int^{h}$ılım] none of them

Glottals:

Amharic has two glottals, /ʔ/ and /h/.

86. /ʔ/ [s'ɑʔɑt] time
/h/ [s'ahaɪ͡] sun

87. /ʔ/ [sɪʔɪl] an image that's painted or drawn
[sɪl] when I say

The glottal stop appears only between vowels at morpheme boundaries. The word [sɪʔɪl] 'an image that's painted or drawn' is a minimal pair with the word [sɪl] 'when I say', as shown above, which shows that /ʔ/ is its own distinct phoneme because it occurs in the same environment as [sɪl].

The phoneme /h/ occurs in all environments, with word medially being shown above, and word initially and finally being shown below.

88. /h/ / #__X [hod] stomach
89. /h/ / X__# [t$\int$ɛwɑnɛh] you are quiet (masc.)

Additionally, in example (86), the word [s'ahaɪ͡] 'sun' is a near minimal pair with the word [s'ɑʔɑt] 'time', showing that the two phonemes /ʔ/ and /h/ exist in similar environments as distinct phonemes.

Geminates

Amharic also contains geminated consonants. Some of which are distinctive phonemes:

90.	/nː/	[gɛna]	wait
		[gɛnːa]	Christmas
91.	/kʼː/	[ɪmikʼaba]	someone who knows how to paint
		[ɪmikːʼaba]	someone who is being painted
92.	/lː/	[mɪlas]	tongue
		[bilːa]	knife

Other possible geminates include /mː/ and /sː/, however I was unable to find any minimal or near minimal pairs for these. Words where these sounds have been documented are below:

93.	[mː]	[dɪmːɛtʰ]	cat
		[gɪmːaʃ]	half
94.	[sː]	[besːo]	breakfast food containing barley

There is also a geminate tap /ɾː/ which, like its singleton counterpart, often becomes realized as trill. This allows for a minimal pair between /ɾ/ and /ɾː/, /maboɾɛʃ/ "to be brushed" vs. /maboɾːɛʃ/ "to brush (teeth)" which becomes realized as [maboɾɛʃ] vs. [maboɾɛʃ]. Initially, this minimal pair seems to show that tap and trill are individual phonemes, contradicting the free variation argument earlier. However, our speaker specifically noted that the [r] in [maboɾɛʃ] was a geminated tap. This actually solidifies the free variation argument, as it provides an explanation for the occurrence of [ɾ] and [r] in the same word, while at the same time not denying the distinctive pair below. The two rhotic processes are depicted in 95.

95.	/ɾː/	[maboɾɛʃ]	to be brushed

[maborɛʃ] to brush (teeth)

96. /ɾ/ → [ɾ] ~ [r]
/ɾː/ → [r]

Glottal Stops- Hannah Staats

Consonant Phoneme Analysis.

The glottal stop appears to be a marginal consonant phoneme in Amharic. It occurs most frequently between vowels at morpheme boundaries. Some examples are given in 97-99. These words contain vowel-final *bɛ* or *jɛ* followed by a vowel-initial morpheme.

97. [beʔɛnei] or [bɛʔɛnei]
be-ʔɛnei
by-me
'by me'

98. [jɛʔɛgɛr at'ɪntʰotʃʰ]
jɛ-ʔɛgɛr at'ɪntʰ-otʃʰ
POSS-leg bone-PL
'ankles'

99. [jɛʔɛgəre at'ɪntʰ]
jɛ-ʔɛgəre at'ɪntʰ
POSS-arm bone
'shoulder'

The glottal stop occurs less frequently in words that do not appear to contain multiple (cocatenative) morphemes. Some of these, shown in 100-102, are possibly loans or cognates with Arabic, as discussed above.

100. [saʔat] 'hour', 'time'

101. [mɛʔɛɾaf] 'paragraph'

102. [mɪʔɪɾab] ‘west’ (infrequent, the version the consultant’s mom learned in middle school but rarely uses)

The glottal stop also occurs in a few words that seem to contain only one morpheme and might not be loanwords, shown in 103-105.

103. [bɛheʔɛ] ‘sheep’

104. [gɨʔɪz] ‘Ge’ez’

105. [sɪʔɪl] ‘painted or drawn image’

Vowel Property Analysis.

Note that in the examples given in 103-105, the glottal stop always occurs intervocalically. This is representative of its distribution in the data we elicited. Furthermore, in many of these words, the vowels directly before and after the glottal stop are the same. The similarity of these vowels is consistent with an analysis of the glottal stop as a property of some vowels in Amharic. Consider, for example, *sɪʔɪl* in 105. If the glottal stop is a consonant phoneme, the structure of this word would be CVCVC. If the glottal stop is a property of the vowel, the structure would be CVC, with a medial glottalized vowel. In this analysis, *sɪʔɪl* in 105 and *sɪl* in 106 would form a minimal pair.

106. [sɪl] ‘when I say’

This analysis is compatible with the words in 100-102 being borrowings or cognates. It is possible the glottal stop was at one point a less marginal consonant phoneme in Amharic, used in place of other back consonants in loans from languages such as Arabic. Over time, the glottal stop may have evolved from a consonant phoneme to a property of vowels. An alternative explanation for the similarity of the vowels before and after the glottal stops would be that one vowel is partially or fully assimilating to the other. Further analysis of vowel assimilation is necessary to better understand the status of the glottal stop in Amharic.

Arabic-Amharic Consonant Correspondences- Matthew Wilkinson

A corresponding set of 'Emphatic Consonants' are realized as uvular and pharyngealized stops in Arabic and as ejectives in Amharic.

Figure 2 summarizes the evident correspondence.

Figure 2:

Amharic	Arabic
k'	q
s'	sˤ
t'	tˤ

The clearest evidence for this is in the numerous cognate words which are realized with a velar ejective in Amharic and a uvular stop in. (X-X) compare such cognate pairs.

107. [suk'] 'shop' (Amharic)
108. [suq] 'market' (Arabic)

109. [dɛk'ik'a] 'minute' (Amharic)
110. [daqiqa] 'minute' (Arabic)

Correspondence between pharyngealized consonants in Arabic and ejective consonants in Amharic is less common, often occurring in words that share the same structure, but have diverged somewhat in meaning.

111. [mɛs'af] 'book, writing' (Amharic)
112. [mɛsˤaf:] 'row, line, composing stick[2]' (Arabic)

113. [mɛt'ɛb] 'cleaning, washing' (Amharic)

[2] A tool used in typesetting to arrange letters in a row, forming the words that will be printed on a book or newspaper. This meaning has the clearest lexical correspondence with 'book'

114. [tˤɪb] ‘medicine, to treat medically’ (Arabic)

Not all Amharic Ejectives correspond to sounds that exist Arabic. The Postalveolar ejective affricate is most likely borrowed from Oromo, rather than corresponding to another emphatic Arabic consonant. Our consultant provided Oromo data that included this sound.

115. [ʧ'alla], Name of Oromo origin

This limited Oromo data confirms that the sound, which is absent in Arabic, is present in Oromo. Our consultant often emphasized that phonetic influence from Oromo is prevalent in Amharic and is a major difference between Amharic and other Ethiopian Semitic languages.

In addition, the bilabial ejective is the Amharic realization of foreign words with aspirated [pʰ] sounds. Example (116) shows a word with clear European origin[3] (therefore originally without ejectives) that has been nativized with two ejectives, most likely both on formerly aspirated consonants.

116. [t'ɛrɛp'ɛza] ‘table’

This suggests that aspiration in foreign loanwords is nativized as ejection. In contrast to these nativized loanwords, however, our consultant, who is fluent in English, pronounced some recent loanwords from English into Amharic with aspiration.

117. [ɛrpʰortʰ] ‘airport’

While pharyngeal and uvular stops in Arabic have ejective counterparts in Amharic, pharyngeal and uvular fricatives and approximants have been lost in Amharic. Our consultant tells us that many ‘glottal’ fricatives and approximants are shared between Arabic and the classical Ge’ez

[3] ‘Trapeza’ is a common word for ‘table’ in European languages. It is originally Greek, but has passed into Slavic languages such as Bulgarian, as well as Italian, which is the likely point of entry from this word into Amharic

language[4], but no longer exist in Amharic. Her understanding of these sounds as ‘glottal’ reflects the fact that these lost pharyngeals and uvulars are realized as glottal sounds in modern Amharic, or dropped altogether.

Figure 3 summarizes the loss/debuccalization of these sounds

Figure 3:

Amharic	Arabic
ʔ, h, ∅	ʕ, ʁ, ħ, x, ɣ

Examples (118-125) demonstrate this change using a few cognate terms.

118. [mɪʔɪrab] ‘West’ (Amharic)
119. [maɣrɪb] ‘West’ (Arabic)

120. [amɛt] ‘Year’ (Amharic)
121. [ʕa:m] ‘Year’ (Arabic)

122. [tawahɪdo] ‘Christianity’ (Amharic)
123. [tawħid] ‘Monotheism’ (Arabic)

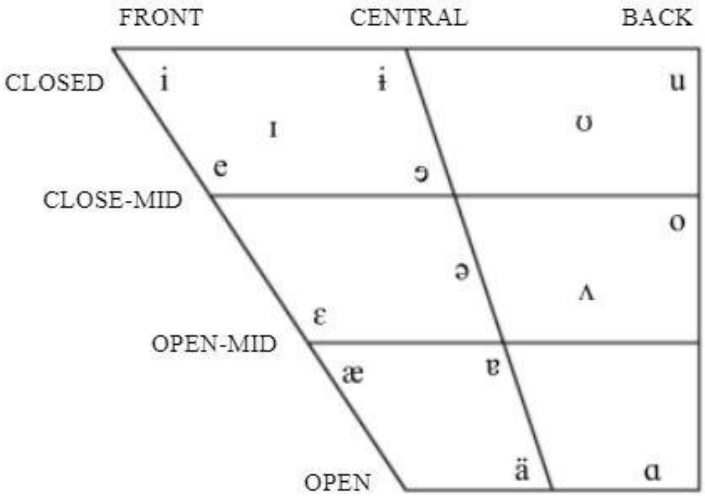
124. [tawahɪdo] ‘Christianity’ (Amharic)
125. [tawħid] ‘Monotheism’ (Arabic

[4] As discussed in a later section

Vowels:

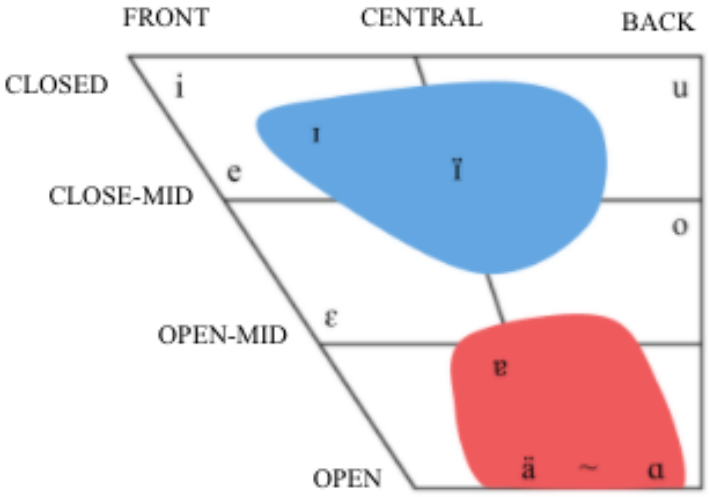
Amharic's vowel space was quite difficult to parse. Initially, when looking through the class's transcriptions, you would find a myriad of potential vowel phonemes as seen here:

Figure 4:



After much consideration, however, we've managed to narrow the vowel space down to the following which we'll cover below:

Figure 5:



High Front Vowels

Amharic has two main high vowel concentrations. The first is /i/, and the second is the vowel cluster /ɪ/. These two vowels are contrastive as you can see from these two words:

126.	/ɪ/	[bɪla]	from [kʰi kʰi bɪla] “what’s so funny?”
127.	/i/	[bilːa]	knife

Cardinal vowel, /i/ appears quite often in Amharic in the word medial and final positions as can be seen here:

128.	/i/ / X__X	[-witʰ]	diminutive affix
129.	/i/ / X__#	[ʃi]	thousand (casual)
130.	/i/ / X__X	[bira]	beer

Although less common, the vowel can also be found word initially:

131.	/i/ / #__X	[iˈtʰi̯op'iə]	Ethiopia

Vowel cluster /ɪ/ is one of two vowel clusters we propose for Amharic. For the sounds in this cluster, /ɪ/ is the underlying phoneme, occurring word initially and word medially as seen below:

132.	/ɪ/ / #__	[ɪne]	my
133.	/ɪ/ / X__X	[tʰɪnɪʃ]	small

The /ɪ/-cluster is the largest cluster in terms of how much of the vowel space it covers, with allophones falling within the blue-shaded region of figure 5. Some of these allophones are provided below:

134.	[ʊ]	/wɪha/	[wʊha]	water
135.	[ɨ]	/ʃɪntʰɪbɛjtʰ/	[ʃɨntʰɨbɛjtʰ]	bathroom

The syllables these allophones appear in are shorter than other syllables, presumably resulting in a vowel reduction that pushes the primary vowel [ɪ] through processes of mid-centralization and shortening. The [ʊ] vowel in [wʊha], is likely further influenced by the preceding [w], resulting in more rounded vowel, and a slightly higher and more back vowel than the [ï] or [ĭ] that may otherwise be expected.

Mid Front Vowels

Amharic has one mid front vowel, /ɛ/. This vowel is oft occurring and can be found in all word distributions as shown below:

136.	/ɛ/ / #__X	[ɛnɐtʰ]	mother
137.	/ɛ/ / X__X	[dɛm]	blood
138.	/ɛ/ / X__#	[nɛgɛ]	tomorrow

Additionally, at times, /ɛ/ surfaces as lower, resulting in an [a] like vowel. For example, the words for “sun” and “hello” were transcribed with [æ] and [a] respectively:

139.	[æ]	[s'æha͡ɪ]	sun
140.	[a]	[salɐm]	hello

However, when asked, Eyerus described them as having a vowel more similar to “blood” as illustrated here:

141.	/ɛ/	[dɛm]	blood
142.	/ɛ/	[s'ɛha͡ɪ]	sun
143.	/ɛ/	[sɛlɐm]	hello

As such, we determined that /ɛ/ is the underlying vowel in this small cluster.

Low Vowels

The second vowel cluster and only low vowel in Amharic is /ɑ/. Similar to vowel cluster /ɪ/, this vowel was transcribed a myriad of ways throughout this module, from, [a] to [ɑ] to [ɐ] to [æ] to [ʌ]. To determine if there was a single /a/ vowel or two, we asked our speaker whether or not vowels in two similar words were the same or different. Eyerus noted that they were, in fact, different and additionally, described how they contrasted. She described the following vowels as being "longer vowels":

144.	[ɐ]	[snɐːkʰ]	snack
145.	[ɐ]	[bilɐ]	knife

On the other hand, Eyerus described the following vowels as being "lower" than the other "longer" vowels:

146.	[ɑ]	[bɑl]	husband
147.	[ɑ]	[mɑnbɛb]	to read

We noticed that the darker [ɑ] vowel tended to occur preceding nasals /m/ and /n/ as well as liquids /ɾ/ and /l/, so its surfacing and lengthening that Eyerus described may have been due to phonological processes. Additionally, we found that [ɐ] was a vowel too centralized to fit the language. As such, we determined that a vowel closest to /ä/ is likely the underlying center of this vowel cluster.

Back Vowels

Amharic has two back vowels, /o/ and /u/. The two back vowels are contrastive as is shown by this near minimal pair:

148.	/u/ / X__#	[wu]	boo
149.	/o/ / X__#	[awo]	yes

In addition to word finally (as shown above), the two vowels can appear word medially; they are not, however, found word initially.

150.	/u/ / X__X	[wuf]	dog sound
151.	/o/ / X__X	[sawotʃʰ]	people.DEF

One exception to this may be loan words. There were three instances of word initial /o/ in loan words from two different languages-- English and Oromo. They are found below:

152.	/o/ / #__X	[ofiːs]	office
153.	/o/ / #__X	[ˈoven]	oven
154.	/o/ / #__X	[oromɪŋa]	Oromo (language)

As such, we propose /o/ only occurs word initially in loan words.

Diphthongs

Diphthongs in Amharic seem to act more like vowels transitioning into glides rather than two vowels. This is supported by the fact that when asked for the roots of words with diphthong-like sounds, Eyrus consistently included the glide as part of the root, rather than as one of the vowels, and when she said the sound out loud, she provided a glide rather than a vowel.

155.	/ɛj/	[zɛjt]	oil
156.	ej	[sejt]	woman

[ej] and [e] seem to be allophones with [ej] occurring word medially as in [rejsa] “corpse” and [e] occurring word finally, as in [zaɾe] “today.” However, I am not quite sure which is underlying. This is supported by the fact that when I said these words with [ej] and [e] in both environments, Eyerus indicated that both constructions worked and would be understood.

157.	[ej]	[rejsa]	corpse

	[ej]	[zaɾej]	today
158.	[e]	[zaɾe]	today
	[e]	[resa]	corpse

159.	/aj/	[s’æhaj]	sun
160.	/oj/	[abahoj]	father (respectful)
161.	/aw/	[tʃʰaw]	goodbye
162.	/ɛw/	[tʃ̓ɛw]	salt

Suprasegmentals

In our short time working on this language, we weren't able to uncover a huge amount about suprasegmentals, but have a few ideas of what may be going on. From what we've heard from our speaker, it seems as though most syllables tend to have about equal prominence in words and that there aren't any significantly reduced vowels or syllables in the language. As such, Amharic is likely a syllable-timed rather than stress-timed language.

Additionally, we haven't been able to uncover all that much in the way of stress patterns. It doesn't seem as though Amharic has fixed or regular lexical stress patterns and it's unclear if words in the language can also have secondary lexical stress. When we had Eyerus "call" names of family members, it did appear there was some kind of lexical stress; but it felt quite subtle.

163.	[s'ɛˈ**dɑ**lu]	Eyerus' mom's name
164.	[ˈ**dɑ**gɪm]	Eyerus' sister's name
165.	[fɪˈ**k'ɑ**du]	Eyerus' dad's name
166.	[ɛˈ**jɛ**rus]	Eyerus

Coincidentally, all of these names ended up having penultimate stress, but this doesn't seem to be the case for all words. For example, the following word has final syllable stress:

167.	[mɛt'foˈ**u**]	worse/worst

Perhaps word stress has less to do with vowel lengthening and more to do with a higher or lower pitch for the stressed syllable.

Phonology

Phonological Processes- Thomas Sasdi, Hannah Staats

Debuccalization of word-final [k]

The consultant shared that 2nd person masculine suffixes end in a /k/ that is often "not pronounced." There is evidence of these suffixes surfacing with a final [k], [h], or breathiness on the preceding vowel. For example, the consultant has produced /ɪbak-ɪk/ 'please' with a final [h], as in 168, and with a breathy vowel [ɪ̤], as in 169.

168. [ɪbakʰɪh] 'please' (addressing second person singular masculine)
169. [ɪbakʰɪ̤] 'please' (addressing second person singular masculine)

Replacement of velar ejectives with glottal stops

There is at least one example in our data of an underlying /k'/ surfacing as [ʔ]. This occurs in the word *mɛk'orɛs* 'cut,' which the consultant pronounced two ways: with a medial [k'], as in 170, and a medial [ʔ], as in 171.

170. [mɛk'oɾɛs] 'cut'
171. [mɛʔoɾɛs] 'cut'

Since the glottis is already engaged in the articulation of ejectives, replacement with [ʔ] would be a natural phonological process.

Another word, *dek'ik'a* 'minute,' is interesting to consider in light of this potential process. The consultant shared that in careful speech, this is pronounced with two medial velar ejectives, as in 172. She further commented that typically, the word would be pronounced as in 173, with an omitted medial vowel and ejective. If replacement of velar ejectives with glottal stops is a common process, it is possible that either of the forms presented in 174 was at one point another possible pronunciation of the word. After one of the medial ejectives surfaced as a glottal stop, the medial [ʔi] or [iʔ] may have been deleted, giving rise to the [dek'a] form.

172. [dek'ik'a] 'minute'
173 [dek'a] 'minute'

174. [deʔik’a] or [dek’iʔa] (hypothetical)

Postvocalic ejectival voicing

One common phonological process is the voicing of ejectives in post vocalic environments. This is demonstrated in examples 175-176:

175.	/**tʃ’ɛw**/	salt
	[zɛjtʰ na **t͡ʃ’aw**]	oil and salt
176.	/nɛtʃ’/ → [nɛt͡ʃ’]	white

Examples 175 and 176 show that this process is postvocalic rather than intervocalic, as /tʃ’aw/ had has never been realized as [dʒaw] in isolation or when preceded by a vowel in non-fast speech, meanwhile /nɛtʃ’/ does get realized as [nɛt͡ʃ’] in some utterances.

This process is likely a product of having an ejective sound where the glottis is engaged following a vowel which is by definition voiced and therefore also using the glottis. Because the sounds are in such quick succession, the voicing carries over to the ejective. In some cases, this can even result in a glottalized voiced consonant in the place of the underlying ejective (177)

177.	/mɛs’af/	book; to write
	[mɛsˀ̬af]	book; to write

Word-final devoicing

Our data show a tendency to devoice segments in the word-final position. Some examples are given below. In 178 and 180, a word-final /d/ is devoiced. In instances such as 179, /d/ even surfaces as an aspirated voiceless stop. Further evidence for this process comes from the consultant’s corrections when the word ‘some’ was repeated back to her with a final [t], as in [andant]. She commented that the final consonant was [d] rather than [t].

178. [bɛɾd̥] ‘cold’

179. [bɛɾtʰ] ‘cold’

180. [andand̥] ‘some’

Vowels are also sometimes devoiced word-finally. Most of the examples of this process in the data elicited so far involve a word-final /u/ surfacing as [u̥]. Some examples are given in 181-182.

181. [dɛrrɛskʰu̥] ‘I arrived’
182. [wɛdɛk’u̥] ‘I fell’

Manner assimilation

There are also processes of manner assimilation where consonant clusters reduce to form a geminate of the second consonant in the cluster. Examples of this with the consonant cluster /dl/ are described below:

183. /tʰɪdlɪk’/ → [tʰɪlːɪk’] big
184. /tʰadlak’/ → [tʰalːak’] older

This process aims for simplification of the cluster. However, the total length of the unit must be preserved, and so rather than deletion of the first consonant, it instead undergoes leniton to match the second consonant. Then, rather than involve rearticulation of the sound, the consonant becomes lengthened to form a geminate.

Occasionally, these words were occasionally said with the cluster as [dl], most likely because of the isolated nature of elicitation. However, in some non-isolated examples, and even in some isolated examples of longer words or sentences the cluster was realized as [lː]

185. [tʰalːak’ ɪhɪtʰ] older sister
186. [ɪne ʧ’awa ajdɛdlɛhon] I am not quiet
[antʰɛh ʧ’awa ajdɛlːɛhɪm] you are not quiet (f/m)

Syllable Structure - Shea Husband and Laura Rapp

General Structure and Patterns

Amharic syllable structure is maxiamally CCVCC, where the cluster in the onset typically ascends in sonority, linearly. For example, two obstruents may not occur in succession in the onset, while an obstruent and a the tap, or a sibilant and a nasal, may. In addition, most clusters found in the onset occur in loan words. Among native words, clusters occur most frequently syllable-medially and in the coda. These clusters typically decrease in sonority, although two obstruents may occur together. Despite relatively frequent clustering, Amharic words do seem to pattern in CV or VC patterns, with clusters sometimes having underlying vowels re-expressed periphrastically. The general syllable structure patterns are expressed through the following examples (with consonants represented as "C" and vowels represented as "V"):

187. (C) (C) V (C) (C)

188. [ɛ-hɪtʰ]
V-CVC
'sister'

189. [ak'-ɪst]
VC-**VCC**
'Aunt'

190. [k'ɛn]
CVC
'Day'

191. [sostʰ]
CVCC
'Three'

192. [kʰɾɛmtʰ]

CCVCC

‘Rainy season’

Examples 188 through 192 show the different types of syllable patterns that can occur under the greater CCVCC structure. Each word corresponds or contains a syllable pattern, and it is important to note that throughout the language, the syllable structure does not tend to deviate from these patterns. It is also important to point out that while not all of the Amharic words with consonant clusters in the onset are loanwords, a vast amount of them are adopted from outside languages.

193. [snak]
‘Snack’

194. [gɾe͡ɪ]
‘Gray’

195. [spʰortʰ]
“sports”

In connected speech, underlying vowels contained in the fidels get re-expressed to ensure that clusters in the coda don’t form a CCC cluster with the following word’s onset. This can be seen in the sentence ‘we made our son eat vegetables’. In isolation, shown in example 196, the underlying [ɪ] in the word for ‘man’, [wɛnd] is not expressed. However, in the context of the larger sentence, this vowel is once more expressed, both to break up the cluster, and to maintain prosodic flow, shown in example 197. In addition, example 198 with the asterisk shows the first word without the vowel [ə] and shows the various ways in which the syllable structure would be compromised.

196. wɛnd lɪdʒ
man child
‘son; boy’

197.	wɛn.d(ə)-lɪdʒ-atʃunɪ-n	at^{h}ɪkɪlt^{h}	ɛndibela	arɪg-n͡-ou
	CVC - C**V**- CV			
	boy-child-1PL.POSS-ACC	vegetables	APL-eat	make-be-3SG.M

198. *wɛ**nd-l**ɪdʒ-atʃunɪ-n
*CV**C-CCV-**C
*CV-**CCC**-V
boy-child-1PL.POSS-ACC

Fidels - Lily Jenssen

Fidels are like syllables in Amharic that have some really cool features. They are composed of a consonant and then a vowel, though sometimes just a vowel. Mostly, it's usually just the word broken up into syllables with vowels that are either the same or in addition to the words without the fidels as you can see in the examples below.

One thing that I've noticed about fidels is that certain vowels such as [ɪ] and [ɛ] often disappear. For example, in the first word below for child, which is [lɪdʒ], the small cap ɪ at the end of the word gets omitted. Small cap ɪ also disappears in consonant clusters such as in the word for lake [wenz]. The small cap ɪ here is both omitted after the [n] and after the [z]. Additionally, phonemes like [w] and [j] seem to blend in with other vowels because they are the most sonorous. They seem to just kind of function as vowels themselves at the ends of words regardless of what vowels are attached. [w] is also followed by [u] in the fidels.

In the word for 'flatbread' the epsilon is omitted due to a consonant cluster, whereas in the word for 'aisle' the fidels are exactly the same as the word following a CV, CV structure. In the example for 'to clean', it appears more vowels disappear, in this case schwa.

It is possible that there a vowel hierarchy in Amharic where [ɪ] is the weakest vowel and [a] is one of the stronger vowels.

199. [lɪdʒ ɛ-jal-lɛw ɛmmuwɛdɛw-u-n wɛnz-ga heid-ɛtʃʰ]
child IMPV-3SG.SUBJ like-DEF-ACC lake-DEF to go-3SG.FEM
'She went to the beach (lake/river) that I liked as a kid'
[lɪ dʒɪ ɪ ja lɛ wu ɪ mɪ wɛ dɛ wu nɪ wɛ nɪ zɪ ga he dɛ tʃʰɪ]
'She went to the beach (lake/river) that I liked as a kid (fidels)'

200. [wɪʃa-ei jɛ mɛllɛsawun k'was wɛrɛwɛrɛw]
dog-1POSS POSS fetch ball throw
'He threw the ball that my dog fetched'
[wɪ ʃa je jɪ jɛ mɛ lɛ sɛ wu nɪ k'wa sɪ wɛ rɛ wɛ rɛ wu]
'He threw the ball that my dog fetched (fidels)'

201. [mɛtʰɛlalɛfija]
'aisle'
[mɛ tʰɛ la lɛ fɪ ja]
'aisle (fidels)'

202. [t'ɛrasɛŋa atʰballɛw]

REFL-POSS wash-1PFV-1SG.SUBJ

‘I wash myself’

[t'ɛ ra sɛi ja nɛ a t'ə ba lɛ wɛ]

‘I wash myself (fidels)’

203. [endʒaˈra]

‘Flatbread’

[ɛ nɛ dʒɛ ra]

‘Flatbread (fidels)’

204. [masdatʰ]

‘To clean’

[ma s'ə da tʰə]

‘To clean (fidels)’

Morphosyntax

Word Order- Shea Husband, Melia Gelinas, Jeongyeob Hong, Maggie Kohl

The basic word order of Amharic is Subject Object Verb (SOV). This can be seen in the following examples:

205. abatu jibɛlal
Father eats
SUBJ VERB
Father eats

206. abatu apɛl.un bɛl.a
Father apple.the eats
SUBJ OBJ VERB
Father eats the apple

The verb follows the subject, such as in example 205 above, and if there is an object it goes after both the subject and object example 206. When creating slightly more complex sentences the general word order is: subject NP, object NP, adpositional phrase, adverbial phrase, verb. This is demonstrated below in example 207.

207. abbat^{h}-u k'aj ap'ɪl-u-n wɛnbɛr-u laj k'ɛsbɪlo ji-bɛll-al
father-DEF red apple-DEF-OBJ chair-DEF on slowly 3SG.M-eat-3SG.IPVF
'Father eats the red apple slowly on the chair.'

In this example, we can see the most natural word order; however, our consultant noted that some limited variation is acceptable. Example 208 is an acceptable word order according to our consultant. In this example the object comes before the subject. If a speaker used a OSV word order in Amharic, it would be acceptable to an extent, but uncommon. However, the SOV word order is the natural order of native Amharic speakers.

208. apɛl.un abatu bɛl.a
apple.the father eats
OBJ SUBJ VERB

‘Father eats the apple’

209. *jibɛlal abatu

eats father

VERB SUBJ.

Father eats

Our consultant told us that example 209 would be grammatically incorrect, however since Amharic has some flexibility, the sentence would still be understood as intended. The allowance for flexibility in word order most likely stems from the case marking and verbal inflection of both the subject and object. However, due to case marking often being limited, so is the amount of acceptable variation.

Word Order in the Noun Phrase

The order of the noun phrase in Amharic is similar to that of English. The head of the phrase, the noun, comes at the end of the phrase, and any modifying dependents come before. These dependents can be adjectives or entire clauses in the form of relative clauses. In addition, these adjectives seem to follow a specific order, which is also similar to that of English: number, size, color. This can be seen in Example 210 below.

210. aːsɛr gɪbəda netʃ' dɪmmɛtʰ-oʧʰ

ten big white cat-PL

‘ten big white cats

As this example shows, the adjectives follow a similar order to English, at least with these three adjectives. More data would be required to see the full extent of adjective ordering in Amharic. In addition, the positioning of adjectives before the word is fixed.

Word Order in Questions

Word order in interrogative clauses generally retains the same order as their indicative counterparts. Polar questions are usually indicated phonologically, with a rising intonation through the phrase. Wh-questions are usually in-situ, meaning the word order doesn’t shift here either. The examples below demonstrate questions in Amharic:

211. mɛk'k'abatʰ ɪ-mitʃʰ-ɪl saw all-ɛ

can.paint 3-know-3SG.M.IPFV person exist-3SG.M

'Is there someone who knows how to paint?'

212. wɛf-u jɛtʰ n-ɛw ↗

bird-DEF.M where to.be-3SG.M.PRES

'Where is the bird?'

And while this is the general order of interrogative phrases in Amharic, wh-questions can be clefted. This means that the wh-phrase is moved to the front, along with the principal verb, and the rest of the sentence follows. Both clefting and interrogative phrases will be discussed in more detail in other sections.

Word Order in Relative Clauses

Relative clauses are a place where word order shifts slightly from the norm. Like many typologically similar languages, relative clauses in Amharic function more as long adjectival phrases. And due to their adjectival function, they also go in front of the thing they are modifying. As will be demonstrated in the examples below, to make a relative clause, the thing being modified shifts to the final position of the phrase, becoming the head. The rest of the clause then precedes this noun in the same order as described above in the general word order section, with the addition of [jɛ-], loosely translating to 'of' or a possessive -s suffix in English.

213. tʰɪlantʰ jɛ heid-kʼu̯-bɛtʰ bahɛr mɪ-hon-allɛbɛtʰ

beach that go-1SG.PERF-should beach INF-to.be-must.have

'It must have been the beach that I went to yesterday.'

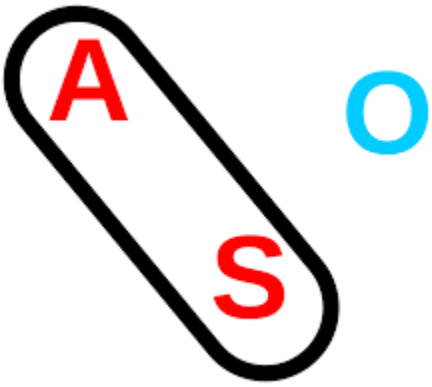
214. wɪʃa-e jɛ mɛllɛs-aw-u-n kʼwas wɛrɛwɛr-ɛw

dog-1SG.POSS that fetch-3SG.M.PRF-DEF.M-OBJ ball throw-3SG.M.PRF

'He threw the ball that my dog fetched.'

As demonstrated through these examples, while it might seem like the word order has shifted, it has overall remained the same. The clause preceding the modified noun is indicated with the relativizer *je*, which shows that it is modifying and not an unrelated clause.

Alignment - Jacky James, Laura Rapp, and Hannah Staats



[5]Amharic uses a nominative-accusative alignment system with a split ergativity. A nominative-accusative alignment system refers to a system where the single argument of an intransitive verb and the agent of a transitive verb are coded and categorized in the same way, whereas the patient of the transitive verb is distinguished or separated from the single arguments and agents. Nominative-accusative alignment can be shown using case marking, usually in the form of prefixes or suffixes, word order, and/or verbal agreement. In case marking and verbal agreement, Amharic utilizes a Nominative-Accusative alignment system. There is no case marking on single arguments of intransitive verbs and agents of transitive verbs. This is shown below.

215. **wɛnd-u** jɪ- ʧɐwɛt-al
S
boy- DEF AGR- play- 3SG.M.IPFV
"The boy plays"

216. **wɛnd-u** kʰwɐs-u- n jɪ- jɛz- al
A
boy- DEF ball- DEF-ACC AGR-catch-3SG.M.NPST
"The boy catches the ball'

217. **ɛne** erot'adalb-a͡ʊ
S
1SG.SBJ run-1SG
'I run'

218. **ɛne** eŋk'ulal ebulal-a͡ʊ
A
1SG.SBJ egg eat-1SG
'I eat eggs'

[5] https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Nominative%E2%80%93accusative_alignment

As you can see in the above examples, the word for “the boy” is the same in both examples and does not change despite having different syntactic functions. Similarly, examples 217 and 218 show that both the single argument (S) of the intransitive verb and the agent argument (A) of the transitive verb are the same and they both contain the conjugated verb representing the first person singular subject. Therefore, both single arguments and agents are marked the same: with a null morpheme, making the alignment of Amharic nominative-accusative.

Conversely, the patients of transitive verbs are marked with the accusative case with the suffix /-n/. In example 216 above, the word for “ball” ends with the suffix /-n/. This marks the accusative case. Example 220 below also illustrates how the /-n/ suffix attaches to the patient, in this case “apples,” in the transitive sentence. Both examples also demonstrate, once again, that the single argument of the intransitive verb and the agent argument of the transitive verb are the same for each statement.

219. eɲa enanɛbadal-ɛn
S
1PL.SBJ read-1PL
‘We read’

220. eɲa apɛl-otʃ-u-**n** enbelal-ɛn
A **P**
1PL.SBJ apple-PL-DEF-**ACC** eat-1PL
‘We eat apples’

Amharic also uses verbal agreement in its alignment system. As the examples below illustrate, a suffix, and sometimes also a prefix, is added to the verb to agree in person and number with the S or the A. A second suffix is added that agrees in person and number with the patient of the transitive verb.

221. mɛs’ɐf-u- n sɛt- **ɐw-** **ɐ-t^{h}**
S **P**
book- DEF-ACC give-1SG.PST-**F-3SG.O**
‘I gave her the book’

222. mɛs'ɐf-u- n sɛt- **a͡ʊ-** **ut^{h}**

S **P**

book- DEF-ACC give-1SG.PST-**3SG.M.O**

'I gave him the book'

223. mɛs'ɐf-u- n sɛt- ɐw- **ʊʧa͡ʊ**

S **P**

book- DEF-ACC give-1SG.PST-**3PL.O**

'I gave them the book'

224. ɪswɐ ɐp^{h}ɪl- u- n sɛt'- ɛ- ʧ-**eŋ**

S **P**

3.F.SG apple-DEF-ACC give-3.SG-F- **1SG.O**

'She gave me the apple'

225. ɪne dɛmɛt^{h} set- a- **u-ʃ**

S **P**

1SG cat give-1SG-2SG.OBJ-F

'I give you (f) a cat'

226. ɪne dɛmɛt^{h} set- a- **wu**

S **P**

1SG cat give-1SG-2SG.OBJ.M

'I give you (m) a cat'

227. t^{h}ɪ- bɐrka-**ʧu-** ad-lɛʧ

P **S**

3SG.F-bless- 2PL.OBJ-IPFV- 3SG.F

'She is blessing y'all'

228. tʰɪ- bɐrɐk-**ən**- ad- lɛʧ

P **S**

3SG.F-bless- 1PL.O-IPFV-3SG.F

'She is blessing us'

As seen in the examples above, the order of these suffixes can change. It appears that changing the order can indicate tense. For indirect objects with the verb 'to give', the dative case can also be used, as will be discussed in the section on case marking. Below is a paradigm for all of the verbal agreement suffixes for patients that are shown in throughout the examples.

Figure 6:

1SG	-eŋ	**1PL**	-nɛ
2SG.F	-uʃ	**2PL**	-t͡ʃun
2SG.M	-wuh(k)		
F-3SG	-ɐ-tʰ	**3PL**	-ʊʧa͡ʊ
M-3SG	-u-tʰ		

Ergative split

While Amharic has a predominately nominative-accusative alignment system, there appears to be an ergative split in stative verbs. As examples 229 and 230 show, the same suffixes that mark patients of transitive verbs are used below to mark subjects of stative verbs.

229. se͡ɪtijɐwɐl dɛsbɪlo-**ɐt-** ɐl

woman happy- **3SG.F**-IPFV

'The woman is happy'

230. se͡ɪt- oʧ- u dɛsbɪlo-**ɐʧa͡ʊ**-ɐl

woman-PL-DEF happy- **3PL**- IPFV

'The women are happy'

In the examples above, the suffixes /-ɐt/ and /-ɐʧa͡ʊ/ are used to agree with the subjects 'the woman' and 'the women', respectively. These are the same suffixes used for third person singular feminine and third person plural patients of transitive verbs.

231. k'urs- u k'omdata-n- **a͡ʊ**
breakfast-DEF bitter- be-**3SG.M**
'The breakfast is bitter'

232. ɾɛʤɛm-n- **ɛʧ**
tall- be-**3SG.F**
She is tall

The above examples, 231 and 232, contrast the use of different suffixes when the copula verb is descriptive rather than stative. In example 231, the suffix /-a͡ʊ/ is used to agree with the inanimate subject 'breakfast.' This is a different suffix from the one used for a third person singular masculine object, shown in the table above. Similarly, example 232 shows another use of a descriptive rather than stative copula. In this example too, the suffix /-ɛʧ/ does not match the suffix used for a feminine third person singular patient of a transitive verb.

Another use of ergative alignment appears in sentences containing *nɛbɛɾɛb*, corresponding approximately to 'should have' in English. Examples 233-235 illustrate this. Note that the semantic object of the reading action, 'it,' is not marked anywhere in the sentence, making the semantic subject the only marked argument of the verb. The suffixes *-ɛɲ*, *-ɪʃ*, and *-ɪk* typically mark the first person singular, second person feminine, and second person masculine patients of a transitive verb. Here, they attach to *nɛbɛɾɛb* and mark the single argument of the verb.

233. [manbɛb nɛbɛɾɛbɛɲ]
manbɛb nɛbɛɾ-ɛb-**ɛɲ**
read.VERBN be.PST-should-**1S.OBJ**
'I should have read it'

234. [manbɛb nɛbɛɾɛbɪʃ]
manbɛb nɛbɛɾ-ɛb-**ɪʃ**
read.VERBN be.PST-should-**2S.F.OBJ**
'You (f.) should have read it'

235. [manbɛb nɛbɛɾɛbɪkʰ]
manbɛb nɛbɛɾ-ɛb-**ɪk**
read.VERBN be.PST-should-**2S.M.OBJ**
'You (m.) should have read it

Copulative Sentences - Shea Husband, Jacky James

To express adjectival and nominal copulative sentences in Amharic, you first say the adjective or noun, and then follow it with the root for the verb 'to be' /n/, and finally add the appropriate ending for person and number as shown below.

236. ɾɛʤɛm-n- **eɪŋ**
tall- be-**1SG**
'I am tall'

237. ɾɛʤɛm-n- **ɛʧ**
tall- be-**3SG.F**
'She is tall'

238. ɾɛʤɛm-n- **ɛkʰ**
tall- be-**2SG.M**
'You (m) are tall'

239. ɾɛʤɛm-n- **ɛn**
tall- be-**1PL**
'We are tall'

240. ɾɛʤɛm-n-**ɛʃ**
tall- be-**2SG.F**
'You (f) are tall'

241. ɾɛʤɛm-n- **ɐʧu**
tall- be-**2PL**
'Y'all are tall'

242. ɾɛʤɛm-n- **a͡ʊ**
tall- be-**3SG.M**
'He is tall'

243. ɾɛʤɛm-n- **ɐʧa͡ʊ**
tall- be-**3PL**
'They are tall'

To express a predicate nominative copulative sentence, a similar strategy is used. The predicate noun is followed by /n-/ and then the appropriate morpheme for person and number. Below are some examples.

244. gwɐdeɲa-e- n- **ɛʧ**
friend- 1SG.POSS-be-**3SG.F**
'She is my friend'

245. gwɐdeɲa-e- n- **a͡ʊ**
friend- 1SG.POSS-be-**3SG.M**
'He is my friend'

246. jɐ- j- ɛne-wɪʃɐ- n- **a͡ʊ**

that-GEN-1SG- dog- be-**3SG.M**

'That is my dog'

Below is a paradigm that shows all of the endings for person and number.

Figure 7:

1SG	neɪŋ	1PL	nɛn
2SG.F	nɛʃ	2PL	nɐʧu
2SG.M	nɛkʰ		
3SG.F	nɛʧ	3PL	nɐʧa͡ʊ
3SG.M	na͡ʊ		

In the past tense, a word meaning 'was' is used in predicate copulative sentences. Take the following examples:

247. lɪps- u j- ɛswɐ **nɛbɛɾ**

clothing-DEF GEN-3SG.F **be.PST**

'The clothing was hers.'

248. jə- jɛrus mɛkʰinɐ jə- morgɐn **nɛbɛɾ**

GEN-Eyerus car GEN-Morgan **be.PST**

Eyerus' car was Morgan's

249. ɪnɛsu ʃɛrɛritʰ-otʃʰ **nɛbɛru** beitʰ- atʃʰɪn-ɪn jɛ moll-u-tʰ

3PL bug- PL **was.PL** house-1PL- POSS REL fill-1PL.SUB.3SG.M.OBJ

'Those were the beetles that infested our house'

As examples 247 through 249 demonstrate, the word /nɛbɛɾ/ is used for the past tense of 'to be'. Based on the above examples, the verb agrees in person and number with the subject. Unfortunately we did not elicit more copula sentences in the past tense with different subjects so we cannot construct a paradigm.

Stative Copula

In sentences that express a stative copula, the verb root /n-/ is not present. In sentences such as, 'the woman is happy' or 'I am cold', the adjective is stated followed by a suffix that agrees in person and number with the subject. The suffixes used are very similar to the suffixes

shown in the table above, but have some differences. The suffixes are most similar to the object suffixes used for patients of transitive verbs. As such, a more detailed description of stative copulas can be found in the Alignment section, under 'Ergative Split.'

Distribution with mɛhon

In addition to the copulaic verb discussed above, there also seems to be another verb that functions as to be, *mɛhon*. While not as commonly occurring as it's aforementioned counterpart, this verb often shows up when 'being' is not so simple, namely in: negative statements, imperative statements, irrealis statements (might, must, could), as well as in more complex clauses. In addition, it is difficult to say with certainty whether the various morphs of *mɛhon* are, in fact, separate to those mentioned above, as they do sometimes occur in the same environments in certain situations. Here are some examples that illustrate some of the cases that *mɛhon* and its morphs occur in.

250. ɛnɛi tʃʼɛwa aɪdɛllɛ-hun
1SG quiet NEG-to.be
'I'm not quiet'

251. tʃʼɛwa-hun-u
quiet-be.IMP-PL
'Be quiet! (plural)'

252. jɛ nɛdɛf-ɛ-ʃ bimbi li-honni-tʃʰɛllal
that sting-3SG.M.SUB.PERF-2SG.F.OBJ bee might<be>might
'It might have been the bee that stung you (fem)'

253. tʰɪlantʰ jɛ-heid-kˈu̯-bɛtʰ bahɛr mɪ-hon-allɛ-bɛtʰ
yesterday that-go-1SG.PERF-should beach INF-to.be-says-should
'It must have been the beach that I went to yesterday.'

254. wɛnbɛr-u laj honno
chair-DEF.M on being
'him being on the chair'

Each of the above examples expresses some form of being, some in differing tense/aspect combinations, but in each one, a form of *mɛhon* is used instead of *nɛw*/*nɛbɛr*. For most of these, it would seem that *nɛw/nɛbɛr* are simply allomorphs of *mɛhon*, where the other morphs take certain affixes, like negative or speculative markers that *nɛw/nɛbɛr* cannot. However, in our last example, 254, it seems odd that a morph of *mɛhon*, *honno* in this case was used instead of *nɛw*. Based on data we've seen so far, it would seem like *nɛw* or *nɛbɛr* would have been the best choice for this. But seeing this, it would seem that *nɛw* and *nɛbɛr* are used for simple equative statements in the past and present, while other morphs of *mɛhon* are used in other cases where expressing being becomes more complicated.

Heads and Dependents - Shea Husband, Jacky James

Head-Initial or Head-Final?

Amharic is predominantly head-final. The word order is SOV, so the head of the phrase, the verb, comes at the end of the phrase. Furthermore, in adpositional phrases, the head of the phrase, the adposition, also occurs at the end of the phrase. Finally, in possessive noun phrases, the head of the phrase, the possessed object, appears phrase-finally. Examples 255 through 258 demonstrate.

255. mɛs'ɐf-u- n l- ɛnɛsu **sɛt- ɛn**
book- DEF-ACC DAT-3PL.PRO **give-1PL.SU**
'We gave them the book'

256. ʃənkʰuɾt-u [kʰɛ- tɛɾɛbezaʊ̯ **filɛfit**] n- aʊ̯
onion- DEF LOC-table.DEF **in.front.of** be-3SG.M.SU
'The onion is on the table'

257. jə- ʔɪjeɾus **mɛkʰinɐ**
POSS-Eyerus **car**
'Eyerus' car'

258. [[lɪdʒ ɛ-jallɛw ɛ-mmuwɛd-ɛw-u-n **wɛnz]** ga **heid-ɛtʃʰ]**
child 1SG-as 1SG-like-1SG.PERF-DEF-OBJ **lake** LOC **go-3SG.FEM.PERF**
'She went to the lake I liked as a child'

In example 255, the main verb of the sentence 'to give' comes at the end. Similarly, in example 256 the adposition 'in front of' occurs at the end of the adpositional phrase. In example 257, the possessed noun, 'car', occurs phrase-finally. And finally, as we see in example 258, the head of the relative clause, lake, as well as the head of the main clause, 'she went', both go at the end of the phrase.

Head- or Dependent-Marking?

Amharic uses both head- and dependent-marking to mark the relationship between heads and their dependents. For example, in possessive noun phrases, possession is marked on the dependent, the possessor, rather than on the head of the phrase, the possessed noun. Example 259 below demonstrates:

259. **jə-** ʔɪjɾus mɛkʰinɐ

POSS-Eyerus car

‘Eyerus’ car’

As the above example illustrates, the dependent is marked rather than the head. In example 259, the dependent, Eyerus, is marked as the possessor while the head of the phrase, the car, does not show any marking. There is, however, another way to show possession in Amharic which uses head-marking. This is shown below.

260. wɪʃɐ-**e**

dog-**1SG.POSS**

‘My dog’

261. **jə**-gwɐdɛɲɐ-**e** ɪnɐtʰ wɪʃɐ

POSS-friend-**1SG.POSS** mom dog

‘My friend’s mom’s dog’

In example 260, the possessed object, the head of the phrase, is marked to show the relationship between the head and the dependent. It has a suffix /-e/ that marks a first person singular possessor. In the other example, 261, the head of one possessive noun phrase, friend in ‘my friend’, is marked with both a prefix and a suffix which indicate a first person singular possessor. The second possessor, ‘mom’ and the head of the possessive noun phrase as a whole, ‘dog’, are unmarked. This would suggest that the order of the constituents also plays a role in the determination of the relationship of the constituents in example 261, with the head of the phrase being put in the final position.

In addition to possessive markers, the definite marker also exemplifies this relationship. It seems that definiteness can be marked on either the head or dependent; however, the connotations of each marking differs. Examples 262 and 263 will show how this marking can appear both on the head and dependent:

262. t'ɨk'ur dɪmmɛtʰ**-u**

black cat**-DEF**

‘the black cat’

263. t'ɨk'ur**-u** dɪmmɛtʰ

black**-DEF** cat

‘the black cat’

As shown above, the agreement for definiteness can be marked on either the head or the dependent. Our consultant noted that each held their own connotations. When marked on the head, you are emphasising the definiteness of the thing being described, in essence, saying that it is *the* cat. In comparison, when definiteness is marked on the dependent, there doesn't seem to be a special emphasis. This may suggest that Amharic's underlying practice in this regard is to mark the dependent. However, more data would be needed to get a better clearer picture of the distribution.

Amharic relies on case-marking to show the relationship between the constituents of a sentence.

264. mɛs'ɐf-u- **n** **l-** ɛnɛsu sɛt- ɛn
book- DEF-**ACC** **DAT**-3PL.PRO give-1PL.SU
'We gave them the book'

In the above example, the noun 'book' is marked for the accusative case with the suffix /-n/ and the third person plural pronoun is marked for the dative case with the prefix /l-/. This example also demonstrates that the head of the clause, the main verb 'to give' agrees with the first person singular subject 'we.' Eyerus has said that it is redundant to state a pronominal subject because the suffixes on the verb already indicate the pronominal subject. In a similar vein, pronominal affixes can be used to indicate a pronominal object. The above example 264 can also be stated in the following way:

265. mɛs'ɐf-u- n sɛt- ɛn- **wɐʧa͡ʊ**
book- DEF-ACC give-1PL.SU-**3PL.OBJ**
'We gave them the book'

Eyerus explained that you would use verbal agreement, as shown above, when the people who you gave the book to were close by. Just as with possessive noun phrases, it appears that one can use head-marking and dependent-marking to show the relationship between constituents. In contrast with much of the nominal morphology, it seems the verbs are mainly head-marked. For a detailed description of the head marking please refer to the section on verbal inflectional morphology.

Noun Class - Jeongyeob Hong

In Amharic, nouns are mostly classified by gender and animacy.

Gender

Amharic distinguishes genders in two categories: masculine and feminine. To express this, Amharic uses affixes; however, some words can stand by themselves. The latter category is words that follow the natural gender as shown in following examples.

266.	abbat^{h}-u	ennat^{h}-u
	father-DEF	mother-DEF
	'the father'	'the mother'

In the above example, both words received the definitive article [-u]. There are different definitive articles depending on the gender and [-u] means the masculine. Nonetheless, these two words received identical articles. This suggests that there are words following the natural gender. Note that there are no words for a 'parent' or a 'person who gave birth'. Instead of having a common noun and conjugate with suffixes, some Amharic words have its predefined genders.

The other way of expressing gender is attaching a suffix. Depending on the word-final sounds, different suffixes are attached. For words ending in the consonant, [-u] is added to represent the masculine while [-wa] is added for the feminine.

267.	hak^{h}im-u	hak^{h}im-wa
	doctor-DEF.MAS	doctor-DEF.FEM
	'the male doctor'	'the female doctor'

For words ending in vowels, [-wu] and [-wa] is attached for the gender reference.

268.	t^{h}ɛmari-wu	t^{h}ɛmari-wa
	student-DEF.MAS	student-DEF.FEM
	'the male student'	'the female student'

For these nouns, the root of a word is the same while attached suffixes change the meaning. Whether nouns are naturally gendered or not is somewhat unclear. In general, words that

represent a mass or concept would be artificially annotated and considered as masculine. Yet, whether or not certain naturally gendered nouns are masculine or not is still ambiguous.

269. dɪmmɛtʰ-wa mɪn-allɛtʃʰ
cat-DEF what-say-3SG.F.PROG
'What sound does the cat make?'

270. wɪʃa-wu mɪn-nallɛ
dog-DEF what-say-3SG.M.PROG
'What sound does the dog make?'

The example with cat is used in feminine[-wa] while dog is used in masculine[-wu]. According to the consultant, a cat is usually considered as feminine while a dog is considered as the opposite. Further data is needed to draw concrete hypotheses on what differentiate the genders for naturally gendered nouns.

Another interesting phenomenon in Amharic is that in some nouns, [-itʰ] is attached to represent feminine. We will provide an explanation for this in the Diminutive section.

271. lidʒ-itʰ lidʒ
child-FEM 'child'
'girl' 'child (male)'

272. sɛw sew-itʰ-wa
person person-FEM-DEF
'person' 'female person (woman)'

Animacy

So far, the examples are animate nouns. In this subsection, we will discuss whether previous analysis also applies to the inanimate nouns. To begin with, similar to the animate subjects, the inanimate tend to be masculine as a default form.

273. dɪŋgaɪ-u dɪŋgaɪ
child-DEF 'rock'

‘the rock (MAS)’

274. kʰɛfil-u kʰɛfil
room-DEF ‘room’
‘the room (MAS)’

Especially, when the consultant was asked to create the female form of a room, she was not able to create one. Instead she described that the same suffix is used to represent the possession. The analysis on possession will further explain this part. However, the message we have to take is that there is not a female version of ‘room’

275. kʰɛfil-wa
room-POSS.F
‘her room ’

This example shows that inanimate nouns also have a natural gender. Certain words are predefined in specific gender and it tends to be masculine.

The use of [-itʰ] is limited in the inanimate object. When the consultant was asked to make a feminine version of ‘food’, ‘room’, ‘rock’ with [-itʰ], she clearly mentioned that it usually attaches to the human object. The way of making feminine inanimate nouns will further be explained in the Diminutive section.

Definiteness - Daphne Iskos, Jeongyeob Hong, and Laura Rapp

Marking

In Amharic, definiteness is marked on nouns as a suffix. This suffix can change based on the gender of the object to which it attaches. The ending for definite male nouns is [-u] or [-wu] while the ending for definite female nouns is [-wa].

276. tɪdɪlɪk'-u
big-DEF.MAS
'The biggest'

277. tɪdɪlɪk'-wa
big-DEF.FEM
'The biggest'

278. tɛmari-wu
student-DEF.MAS
'The male student'

279. hak^{h}im-wa
doctor-DEF.FEM
'The female doctor'

Animacy

Definiteness is not marked differently based on animacy, as "she gave me <u>the dog</u> (animate)" and "she gave me <u>the apple</u> (inanimate)" both utilize the same suffix[-u].

280. ɛswɐ wɪ'ʃɐ-**u**-n 'sɐt̪ɐt͡ʃin
she dog-**masc.DEF**-ACC gave.me
'She gave me the dog'

281. ɛswɐ ɐp^{h}ɛl-**u**-n sɐt̪ɐt͡ʃin

she apple-**masc.DEF**-ACC gave.me
'She gave me the apple'

Case

Definiteness is marked differently for the accusative and nominative cases. Examples 282 and 283 demonstrate the suffix [-wu] which is sometimes reduced to [-u], and it marks masculine definite nouns in the subject position. Meanwhile, while 284 and 285 show the ending [-un], which is for masculine definite nouns that are direct objects.

282. ɐpʰɛl-**u** lɛ-nei tʰɛsɛt'wal
apple-masc-**DEF** DAT-1SG given.to.me
'The apple was given to me'

283. wɪʃɐ-**wu** idɛnɛsɐl
dog-masc-**DEF** dancing
'The dog is dancing'

284. wɪʃɐ-**un** ɪndɪ̄-setʰain ɐɾɐkʰu̯
dog-masc-**DEF**-ACC CAUS-give make.1SG.SBJ
'I made her give me the dog'

285. wɪʃɐ-**un** bɛ-ɛgɪr ɐswɐsɛlkʰu̯
dog-masc-**DEF**-ACC by-foot walk.1SG.PFV
'I walk the dog'

The masculine, nominative, definite suffix [-wu] is sometimes reduced to [u] in fast speech especially in words that end in [u]. The consultant reported that this happens because the sequence [u-wu] is difficult to pronounce quickly. This phenomenon can be observed in the phrase "the kazoo" (example 287-288). Example 287 is how it would sound in slow speech, whereas example 288 is how it would be pronounced in fast/natural speech. Note that example

286 and 288 sound identical; an listener would have to determine which meaning of the word was applicable based on situational context.

286.	kʰɐzu	287. 'kʰɐzu-wu	288. 'kʰɐzu
	Kazoo	kazoo-MAS.DEF.NOM	kazoo.MAS.DEF.NOM
	‘(a) kazoo’	‘the (subject) kazoo’	‘the (subject) kazoo’

In Amharic, differential object marking appears in possessive constructions. Specifically, it seems that when denoting possessiveness on a male definite object, the [n] from the [-un] definiteness marker goes on the possessive pronoun instead of the noun itself, as in example (?).

289.	ɛswɐ	jɛswa-**n**	ɐpʰɛl	sɐ̄tɐ̄t͡ʃin	
	she	her-**masc.DEF.ACC**	apple	gave.me	
	‘She gave me her apple’				

Indefiniteness

Marking in Relation to Word Order and Case

In Amharic, indefinite nouns seem to be unmarked. This is to say, ['ɐpʰɛl] can mean "apple" or "an apple" depending on context. The case of indefinite objects appears to be implied from word order. For indefinite direct objects, the relevant noun directly precedes the corresponding verb. Examples are included below in 290 and 291, and example 292, shows how indefinite direct objects can take the accusative suffix [-n] that separates it from the subject or agent argument of the sentence.

290. ɛswɐ **wɪʃɐ** sɐ̄tɐ̄t͡ʃin
she **dog.INDEF** gave.me
'She gave me a dog'

291. ɛswɐ **ɐpʰɛl** sɐ̄tɐ̄t͡ʃin
she **apple.INDEF** gave.me
'She gave me an apple'

292. anʧi zɛfre-n ts'afɪʃ
you.FEM song-INDEF.**ACC** write.2FEM.SBJ
You (F) wrote a song

Definiteness and Indefiniteness: Crossover

Noun Modification/Relative Clauses

In Amharic noun phrases that are modified by verbs, the verb comes directly before the noun that it modifies. With this in mind, please consider what Eyerus told me when I elicited "the dog that she gave me" and "a dog that she gave me":

293. ja sɐ̄tɐ̄'t͡ʃin wɪ'ʃɐ
that gave.me dog.**INDEF**
'**The** dog that she gave me'

294. ja sɐ̄tɐ̄'t͡ʃin wɪ'ʃɐ
that gave.me dog.**INDEF**
'**A** dog that she gave me'

Despite the fact that the first English phrase calls for a definite object, the phrases are exactly the same with 'dog' unmarked (and thus indefinite) in both constructions. Eyerus then went on to say that if she were to "say the two phrases one after another" and needed to distinguish between them she would add the (masculine nominative suffix) [-u] to the end of 'dog'. This modified utterance is transcribed below in (295):

295. ja sɐt̄ɐ't͡ʃin wɪ'ʃɐ-**u**
that gave.me dog.**DEF**
'The dog that she gave me'

The above phenomenon seems to indicate that marking definiteness is optional when clarifying if something is definite or indefinite is irrelevant and/or obvious based on context cues. This theory is further bolstered by the translation Eyerus offered for "the apple that she gave me", in which "the apple" is not marked for definiteness in the Amharic equivalent:

296. ja sɐt̄ɐ't͡ʃin ɐpʰɛl
that gave.me apple.INDEF
'The apple that she gave me'

Given the isolated context of our elicitation session, Eyerus likely did not see it necessary to specify the definiteness of the apple. Further analysis on the relevance of context in Amharic is provided in one of the subsequent sub-sections entitled "The Importance of Context"

Mass Nouns

Mass nouns--also known as noncount nouns--describe a noun that cannot be counted. Mass nouns normally do not have a plural form or indefinite form. An example in English would be 'clothing'. Note the ungrammaticality of "a clothing" and "clothings"; these examples would respectively require the addition of the pronominal qualifying phrase "piece of" and "pieces of" in order to form grammatical utterances.

Similarly, Amharic has nouns that cannot be counted. However, different from English, they cannot be marked as definite, **only** indefinite. Nouns that fit this description include "sky"

or ['sɛmai]. Upon asking Eyerus why this is, she explained that the sky is "too expansive" to be quantified with a definiteness marker. She added that she personally wouldn't mark "airport" with definiteness for the same reason. Following this logic, she concluded that she *would* use definite marking with the word "house" because it's a smaller space.

That being said, there *are* expansive nouns that are sometimes countable (but sometimes not) like "ocean". This makes sense given that even though the ocean is a huge body of water, someone could feasibly need to refer to a specific ocean using definite marking. There are also smaller nouns that have limitations on definiteness marking. One such word is "water". It *can* be counted when referring to water in the context of units of water (such as "pass me one of those **waters**"), but not when the water in question is in one amorphous chunk/body.

The Importance of Context

Mass nouns and definite markers in general are very much related to context. Returning to one of the examples introduced above, we found it odd that Eyerus doesn't typically use "the" with "airport" in Amharic. Considering the fact that an airport isn't that "expensive" of a space and that thousands of airports exist worldwide, it would seem logical that using marking the term with definiteness would be common. A possible explanation might be the fact that Amharic seems to be a high context language. This is to say, maybe it would seem redundant or overly-obvious to designate "airport" as a definite object: the listener would automatically assume you're talking about the nearest airport, anyways. Examples 297 and 298 show this theory in use; example 297 reveals how “the airport” is not marked for definiteness whereas “the dog” in the sentence has the definite suffix.

297. wɪʃɐ-**wu** **ɛrpʰortʰ** wɪstʰ n-a͡ʊ
dog-masc.**DEF** **airport** in be.3SG.MAS
‘The dog is in the airport’

298. ˈʃɪnkʰurtʰ-u t’ɑrɑpʰe͡ɪˈzɑ la͡ɪ n-a͡ʊ
onion-**DEF** table.**INDEF** on be-3.SG.MAS
The onion is on the table.

Meanwhile, example 298 shows how a smaller item, “the table,” is not marked for definiteness. We think that this example is also context dependent, as it could be similar to the airport in the sense that the speaker could be referring to the table that is nearest or the one table that is in the hypothetical room. We failed, however, to check if it's possible to elicit "the table" and "the airport" on their own, so it's possible that it could be an entirely different class of nouns. With that being said, Amharic does have a tendency to be a context based language with intricate methods and procedures.

Definiteness and Articles

Adding numerals to definite nouns doesn't alter the corresponding ending that is used. Note that the suffix [-ʧu] attaches after the reduced nominative masculine definite marker [-u] to signify plurality (see 299). Interestingly, there was an outlier that stood apart from this plurality rule that appeared in one of our elicitation sessions, and it was for the word “eggs.” This outlier is shown below in example 300.

299. sostʰ wɪ'ʃa͡-u-ʧu
three dog-masc.DEF.PL
‘the three dogs’

300. eŋk’ulo bʰedəla͡ʊ
Egg eat.PST.1SG.SBJ
‘I ate the eggs’

In the second example above, one can see that “the eggs” is neither pluralized or marked for definiteness even though it appears in the sentence as ‘I eat the eggs.’ Eyerus mentioned that the plural version of “eggs” is only used when the eggs are not cooked or in a scenario where one can see multiple eggs in a basket. The eggs are not marked with the accusative or the definite article suffix and do not fit with either category. This sentence relates to the importance of context and is another example of how the grammar in Amharic is situation-dependent and can change based on context.

Case Marking- Jeongyeob Hong, Shea Husband, Jacky James

As mentioned above in the section on Heads and Dependents, Amharic uses case marking to denote the relationship between constituents in sentences. In our research, we have discovered accusative, dative, genitive, and locative cases.

Direct objects of transitive verbs are mostly marked for the accusative case using the suffix /-n/.

301. k'was-u-n ɪ-ez-allau
ball-DEF-ACC catch-1sg.SUB.FUT
I catch the ball

302. ɛnnatʰ-u kʰeikʰ-u-n le-wɛnd-u set'-ɛtʃʰ
mother-3SG.M.POS cake-DEF-ACC DAT-boy-DEF give-3SG.F.SUB.PRF
His mom gives the cake to the boy

However, in some phrases, the accusative marker is attached to the indirect object.

303. wɛndɪm-e doro-wu-n mɪgɪb set'-aw
brother-1SG.POSS chicken-DEF-ACC food give-3SG.M.SUB.PER
My brother gives the chicken food

304. sɛitʰijɛ-wa sɛwɛjɛ-wu-n andand mɪgɪb sɛt'-ɛtʃʰ-u
woman-DEF man-DEF-ACC one.one food give-3SG.F.SUB-3SG.M.OBJ
'The woman gives the man some food'

In these examples, the recipient is receiving a marking that one would expect to be placed on the thing being given, 'the food'. While this is something that requires much more data to draw a concrete conclusion about, we suspect that the shift in marking is due to the animacy of the two objects in question. 'The chicken' and 'the man' are animate nouns, while 'food' is inanimate. Typologically, animacy often plays a large role in hierarchies of words, and due to this marking pattern, we suggest that this may be happening here as well.

Another unexpected marking of accusative [-n] is its attachment to adjectives. The head and dependent section already discussed that the accusative marker technically marks for the noun phrase.

Amharic marks indirect objects with the dative case using the prefix /lɛ-/. This can be seen in examples 305 through 309. As explained in the section on Heads and Dependents, both verbal agreement and case marking can be used to describe pronominal indirect objects, but the two strategies have different connotations.

305. mɛs'ɐf-u-n **lɛ-ɛnɛsu** sɛt-ɛn
book-DEF-ACC **DAT-3PL** give-1PL.PST
'We gave them the book'

306. mɛs'ɐf-u-n **lɛ-eɲɐ** sɛt-u
book-DEF-ACC **DAT-1PL** give-3PL.PST
They gave us the book'

307. mɛs'ɐf-u-n **lɛ-ɛne** sɛt-u
book-DEF-ACC **DAT-1SG** give-3PL.PST
'They gave me the book'

308. mɛs'ɐf-u-n **lɛ-ɛne** sɛt-eŋ
book-DEF-ACC **DAT-1SG** give-3SG.M.PST
'He gave me the book'

309. **lɛ-ɛnɐtʰ-**e mɛs'ɐf-u-n sɛt-a͡ʊ
DAT-mom-POSS.1SG book-DEF-ACC give-1SG.PST
'I gave my mom the book'

Examples 305 through 309 have pronominal indirect objects. To indicate this relationship, the prefix /lɛ-/ is added to the respective personal pronouns. Example 309 has a noun, 'mom' as an indirect object. In this example, the prefix /lɛ-/ is added in front of /ɛnɐtʰ/ to mark 'mom' as an object.

Another way the dative is used in Amharic is to show a benefactive relationship.

310. kʰartʰon-u lɛ-neɪ n-ɛw
box-DEF DAT-1SG be-3SG.MAS
The box is for me

In the above example, dative case marker indicates that the benefactor of the box is the subject itself.

The genitive case is used to mark possessed objects. The genitive case marker is [jɛ-]. Its usage is already well explained in the Possession section. Therefore, we will move further into the locative case.

Amharic marks the objects of prepositions with the locative case and its marker is suffix [-ga].

311.	wɪʃa	p'ark^{h}-u-ga	n-ɛw
	dog	park-DEF-LOC	be-3SG.MAS
	A dog is at the park		

To express the location of a dog in the sentence, [-ga] is attached after the definite article. While [-ga] being the only locative marker, there are many words in Amharic that serve a similar role. For more detailed analysis of adpositional words, please refer to the adpositional phrase section.

Adjectives and Quantifiers -- Rositsa Ivanova and Stephanie Konadu-Acheampong

Adjectives

Adjectives in Amharic are fairly straightforward. Adjectives precede the words that they modify. For example:

312. t'ɪk'ur wɪʃa
black dog

313. bɪzu ʃɛmizotʃʰ
many shirts

This order holds in adjectival copular sentences as well due to Amharic's SOV word order:

314. rɛʤɪm neɪ͡ŋ
tall to be.PRES.1sg
I am tall

Additionally, adjectives do not seem to change to match the noun which they modify. Rather, the adjectives remain the same in all forms regardless of the plurality or gender.

Figure 8:

I am tall	rɛʤɪm neɪ͡ŋ
You are tall (f)	rɛʤɪm nɛʃ
You are tall (m)	rɛʤɪm nɛk'
She is tall	rɛʤɪm neʧ
He is tall	rɛʤɪm neu
We are tall	rɛʤɪm nen
You all are tall	rɛʤɪm natʃʰu
They are tall	rɛʤɪm natʃʰɛw
Tall hill	reʤɪm da:gotʰ

Furthermore, definiteness can be inflected on adjectives as well, as shown below.

315. ɪhe͡ɪ ˈk'ɑj-u ɑˈpʰɪl na͡ʊ
this red-DEF.MAS apple be-3SG.M
This is the red apple.

Definiteness does not always need to be marked on the adjective, as the example below shows, where it is marked on the subject 'onion'.

316. ˈbɛrtʰukʰan ˈʃɪnkʰurtʰ-u t'ɑrɑpʰe͡ɪˈzɑ la͡ɪ n-a͡ʊ
orange onion-DEF.MAS table POST be-3.SG.M
The orange onion is on the table.

Adjective Order

Similar to English, Amharic seems to have a canonic order that adjectives go in.

317. aːsɛr gɪbəˈda netʃ' dɪmːɛtʰ-otʃʰ
10 big white cat.PL
Ten big white cats

318. amːɪstʰ nɛtʃ' dɪmːɛt-otʃʰ
5 white cat.PL
Five white cats

319. bɪˈzu ˈtʰɪrɪlɪk' kʰɑtʰɑmaˈ-oʧ
many big city.PL
Many big cities

320. jɑ tʰɪrɪlɪk' wɪˈʃɑ
this big dog
This big dog

Numbers, quantities, quantifiers, and demonstratives appear first, followed by size related adjectives, and then other descriptors like color and shape.

Demonstratives

Below is a paradigm for some demonstratives in Amharic.

Figure 9:

this (close by)	ɪheɪ͡
this (further away)	jɑ
that	jɑ
those	ɪnɛsu
these	ɪnɛzi

The following is an example for the demonstrative ‘this’ *ɪheɪ͡*.

321. ɪheɪ͡ ˈk'ɑj-u ɑˈpʰɪl naʊ͡
this red-DEF.MAS apple be-3SG.M
This is the red apple.

In this example, the demonstrative ‘this’ *ɪheɪ͡* precedes the color adjective ‘red’ *k'aju*, showing that demonstratives come before color adjectives in the word order.

The demonstrative ‘this’ can also be expressed by the word *ja,* as shown below, although our consultant explained that this form is used when describing something that is farther away.

322. jɑ tʰɪɾɪlɪk’ wɪˈʃɑ
this big dog
This big dog

In this case, the demonstrative *ja* precedes the size adjective *tʰɪɾɪlɪk’*, meaning that demonstratives come before size adjectives as well.

Interestingly enough, the word for ‘that’ is also *ja*, which could be because if this’ is far away, then it becomes ‘that’. The word order remains the same.

323. jɑ tʰɪɾɪlɪk’ wɪˈʃɑ
that big dog
That big dog

When referring to ‘those’, there is no specific demonstrative that is used, and instead the third person plural form ‘they’ *ɪnɛsu* is used, as can be seen below.

324. ɪnɛsu ʃɛrɛritʰ-otʃʰ nɛbɛru beitʰ-atʃʰɪn-ɪn jɛ moll-u-tʰ

3PL bug-PL was.PL house-1PL-POSS REL fill-1PL.SUB.3SG.M.OBJ

Those were the beetles that infested our house

Because *ɪmɛsu* ‘they’ is used to mean ‘those’ sentence more directly translates to ‘they were the beetles that infested our house’. The demonstrative is located before the subject, keeping with the typical word order.

When referring to the demonstrative ‘these’, the word *ɪmɛzi* is used, as demonstrated below.

325. ɪmɛzi tɛlɛvʒɪˈnotʃ

these television.PL

These televisions.

This is the only sentence that we elicited with this word, so further elicitations would be necessary to figure out its exact function. Its root could be *ɪmɛsu* ‘they’ + an added suffix of -i (which usually marks the imperative feminine, but *tɛlɛvʒɪˈnotʃ* is masculine), which would cause the /s/ to become voiced into a /z/ intervocalically, creating *ɪmɛzi*, but it could also be unrelated to *ɪmɛsu* ‘they’.

Possession- Jane Whitley, Matthew Wilkinson

There exist two morphosyntactic ways to mark the possessive: a suffix and possessive pronoun prefix attached to pronouns. When the possessive prefix *jɛ* is attached to a pronoun, the vowel often assimilates to the place of the following vowel. In 326 the vowel does not assimilate to [ɪ] because of how close [ɛ] and [ɪ] are phonetically. However in 328 and 329, the *jɛ* assimilates to *ja* to match the first vowel in *akɪstʰ* "aunt." The two possessive affixes can be used interchangeably, as demonstrated in 326-327 and vary only be speaker preference. A complete list of each of these possessive markers inflected for person and number is shown in figure 10 below, with possessive marking underlined.

326. [jɛne͡ɪ wɪʃa]
jɛ-ne͡ɪ wɪʃa
POSS-1SG dog
"My dog"

327. [wɪʃae]
wɪʃa-e
dog-POSS.1SG
"My dog"

Figure 10

Pronoun Gloss	Separate pronoun	Suffixed pronoun	English Translation
1SG.POSS	jɛne͡ɪ be͡ɪt	be͡ɪtɪ	My house
1PL.POSS	jɛŋja be͡ɪt	be͡ɪtʧɪ	Our house
2SG.M.POSS	janta be͡ɪt	be͡ɪtɪh[6]	Your (M) house
2SG.F.POSS	jantʃi be͡ɪt	be͡ɪtɪʃ	Your (F) house
2PL.POSS	jɛn:anta be͡ɪt	be͡ɪtate͡ʃɛw	Your (PL) house
3SG.M.POSS	jɛsu be͡ɪt	be͡ɪtwu	His house
3SG.F.POSS	jɛswa be͡ɪt	be͡ɪtwa	Her house
3PL.POSS	jɛn:ɛsu be͡ɪt	be͡ɪtate͡ʃa͡u	Their house

[6] The 2SG.M possessive suffix ends with an underlying /k/ that is commonly realized as [h]

Both of the possessive markers can be used in the same sentence. In fact, when two subjects possess different objects in the same sentence, for example 328-331, it is most common for both to be used rather than one of the two multiple times. However, when three subjects are introduced, possession is not explicitly indicated for each of them, as seen in examples 330-331. Instead, the third subject's possession is merely implied. It is likely that this trend would continue as more subjects are added.

328. [jakʰɪstʰe wɪʃa]
j-akʰɪstʰ-e wɪʃa
POSS.3SG-aunt-POSS.1SG dog
"My aunt's dog"

329. [jakʰɪstʰe hulɛtʰ wɪʃaoo͡ʊt͡ʃ]
j-akʰɪstʰ-e hulɛtʰ wɪʃa-oo͡ʊt͡ʃ
POSS.3SG-aunt-POSS.1SG two dog-PL
"My aunt's two dogs"

330. [jɛgʷadɪŋae ɪnatʰ wɪʃa]
jɛ-gʷadɪŋa-e ɪnatʰ wɪʃa
POSS.3SG-friend-POSS.1SG mom dog
"My friend's mom's dog"

331. [jɛgʷadɪŋae ɪnatʰ hulɛtʰ wɪʃaoo͡ʊt͡ʃ]
jɛ-gʷadɪŋa-e ɪnatʰ hulɛtʰ wɪʃa-oo͡ʊt͡ʃ
POSS.3SG-friend-POSS.1SG mom two dog-PL
"My friend's mom's two dogs"

When a plural noun is also marked by the possessive suffix, the plural suffix precedes the possessive. See 332 below.

332. [wɪʃaot͡ʃe]
wɪʃa-ot͡ʃ-e
dog-PL-POSS.1SG
"My dogs"

Adpositional Phrases- Shea, Rosie, Maggie

Adpositional phrases in Amharic tend to be postpositional; however, there are several cases where positional words come before. In addition, many adpositional phrases contain both pre- and post-positions which surround the object they're modifying. Amharic also seems to make a distinction in marking between more general locative phrases and more relational locative relationships, which will be discussed later. Figure 11 shows the adpositions of Amharic.

Figure 11: Adpositions in Amharic

Amharic	English Approximation	Position
sɪlɛ-	about	preposition
(kʰɛ-) bəʍala	after	postposition (alone); requires kʰɛ-
ga	at, to, LOC	postposition
(kʰɛ-) bɛfit	before	postposition; requires kʰɛ-
(kʰɛ-) ʍala	behind	postposition; requires kʰɛ-
sɪɾ	below, under	postposition
(kʰɛ-) at'agɛb	next to	postposition; requires kʰɛ-
bɛ-	by, through	preposition
lɛ-	for, to (a person, thing), DAT	preposition
kʰɛ	from, with, since	preposition
wɪstʰ, often -ustʰ	in	postposition
(kʰɛ-) fɪllɛfitʰ	in front of	postposition
jɛ-	of, 's, that	preposition
(wɛ)laj	above, on	postposition
wak'ababi	near	postposition
wɪtʃʼi	outside	postposition
wɛdɛ	to, towards, over (to)	preposition
jalɛ	without	preposition

(kʰɛ-) ga	with	postposition; requires kʰɛ-

Simple Adpositional Phrases

Simple adpositional phrases in Amharic are those in which the adpositional phrase contains only one adposition. As discussed above, these can take the form of either prepositions or postpositions. In addition, these adpositional phrases tend to me more general locative phrases, showing where something is. These can be seen in the examples below:

333. **kʰɛ** ɪngəˈland jɛ mɛtˈa sɛw
from England that come.3SG.MASC.PERF person
'a person from England (an English person)'

334. ʃɛnkʰurtʰ-u t'ɛrɛp'eza-w **laj** n-ɛw
onion-DEF.MASC table-DEF.MASC **on** to.be-3SG.MASC.PRES
'The onion is on the table'

335. **sɪlɛ**-ma-nbɛb ɪj-awɛrr-aw nɛbɛɾ
about-INF-read 1SG-talk-PERF was
'I was talking about reading'

336. ʃɛnkʰurtʰ-u t'ɛrɛp'eza-w **sɪɾ** n-ɛw
onion-DEF.MASC table-DEF.MASC **under** to.be-3SG.MASC.PRES
'The onion is under the table'

As these above examples show, the phrases contain one pre- or post position, which can either be a separate word, or affix themselves onto the word they modify.

Complex Adpositional Phrases

In addition to the simple adpositions we saw demonstrated above, Amharic also contains complex adpositional phrases, consisting of of the preposition *kʰɛ* meaning 'from' and a postposition. In addition to discerning a spatial relationship between two objects, these complex phrases also seem to dictate an order in the relationship, like 'before' or 'in front of', as well as 'after' or 'behind'. And if we analyze these phrases literally, we can begin to see how this order

is created. By using *kʰɛ-*, you create a point in the mind of the speaker, from which this spatial relationship is based. This relationship is then made clear by the postposition. Let's look at some examples below:

337. ʃɛnkʰurtʰ-u **kʰɛ**-t'ɛrɛp'ɛza **ʍala** n-ɛw
onion-DEF **from**-table **behind** to.be-3SG.M.PRES
'The onion is behind the table'

338. wɛnd-u **kʰɛ**-seitʰ-wa **bɛʍuala** bɛlla
boy-DEF.M **from**-girl-DEF.F **after** eat.3SG.M.PERF
'The boy ate after the girl'

339. ʃɛntʰurtʰ-u **kʰɛ**-t'ɛrɛp'ɛza-u **filɛfitʰ** n-ɛw
onion-DEF **from**-table-DEF.M **in.front.of** to.be-3SG.M.PRES
'The onion is in front of the table'

340. wɛnd-u **kʰɛ**-seitʰ-wa **bɛfitʰ** bɛlla
boy-DEF.M **from**-girl-DEF.F **before** eat.3SG.M.PERF
'The boy ate before the girl'

For each of these examples, the phrase begins with 'from' and ends with the postposition that clarifies the relationship between the two parties. Interestingly enough, the words for 'in front of' and 'before' both contain the word for face, *fitʰ*, which would show that these words have something to do with 'facing' a certain direction. However, that would need more data to say for certain. In addition to this, both sets of words seem quite similar to each other, showing that this spatial relationship extends to time as well.

Adpositional Phrases in the Sentence

Amharic has a somewhat flexible word order in which the adpositional phrase can take the sentence-initial position or the sentence-final position. The natural word order for a sentence with an adpositional phrase would be for the adpositional phrase in the sentence-final position. Our consultant said example X would be an acceptable use of an adpositional phrase at the beginning of a sentence, although less common. Since the verb contains the subject, the subject is not needed. However, the example below would directly translate to "he is on the table," so if

the speaker wants to be explicit about the subject, they would need to include it before the adpositional phrase.

341. ˈʃɪnkʰurtʰ-u t’ɑrɑpʰe͡rˈzɑ la͡ɪ n-a͡ʊ
onion-DEF table POST be-3.SG.M
The onion is on the table

Tense/Aspect/Mood- Jacky James, Rositsa Ivanova. Shea Husband, Maggie Kohl, Jennifer Yang

Amharic marks tense, aspect, and mood on the verb through affixes.

Tense

_____Amharic distinguishes between the past, present and future tenses largely through context, but there are some distinctions conveyed through aspect. Throughout our elicitation sessions, Eyerus mainly gave verbs inflected for the perfective aspect when we asked for verbs in the past tense. However, she also explained that verbs with a perfective aspect feel more 'present' than verbs inflected for an imperfective aspect. On the other hand, when we elicited verbs in the present tense, she would frequently inflect the verbs for an imperfective aspect. She gave the same forms for the future tense. Furthermore, she explained that verbs in the 'present tense' can be used for the past tense as well. Therefore, it seems that verbs are inflected for aspect and the tense of the verb is mainly conveyed through context. To see paradigms of verbal inflection for tense and aspect see the section on Verbal Inflection.

Aspect

_____Amharic distinguishes between a perfective and an imperfective aspect. Eyerus has explained that the perfective aspect is used for actions that have been completed in their totality and has a more 'present' connotation than verbs with an imperfective aspect. On the other hand, the imperfective aspect is used for actions that are ongoing or that have not been completed, as in future actions. Verbs in the perfective aspect can be used for the present tense and the past tense, as shown below.

342. ɪne͡ɪ andand mɛgɪb gɛz-**a͡ʊ**
1SG.SBJ some food buy-1SG.PFV
'I **buy** some food'

343. ɪne͡ɪ andand mɛgɪb gɛz-**a͡ʊ**
1SG.SBJ some food buy-1SG.PFV.PST
'I **bought** some food'

As examples 342 and 343 demonstrate, the same suffix /-a͡ʊ/ can be used for the present and the past tense. Meanwhile, the imperfective suffix /-ɐl/ is used for the present and the future tenses.

344. ɪ- ɾotʰ- kʰu̯
1SG-run- 1SG.PFV
‘I ran’

345. ɪ- ɾotʰ-**ɐl**- la͡ʊ
1SG-run-**IPFV**-1SG
‘I run’

346. ɪ- ɾotʰ-**ɐl**- la͡ʊ
1SG-run-**IPFV**-1SG
‘I will run’

As you can see, example 344 uses a different suffix for a 1SG subject with a perfective aspect than is used above in example 342 with the verb ‘to buy.’ In example 343 the suffix /-a͡ʊ/ is used while in example 344, the suffix /- kʰu̯/ is used. If we had more time, we would have asked Eyerus why certain verbs use different suffixes that seemingly have the same function. It could indicate the existence of different conjugation patterns or it could represent separate tenses or aspects.

A full paradigm using the imperfective suffix can be seen below:
To dance- [mɐdɛnnɛs]

Figure 12:

ɪ-dɛnɛs-ɐd-**la͡ʊ**	1SG	ɪɲɐ ɪn-dɛnɛs-ɐd-**lɛn**	1PL
tɪ-dɛnɛʃ- ɐd-**lɛʃ**	2SG.F	ɪnɐntʌ tɪ-dɛnɛs-ɐd-**lɐʧu**	2PL
tɪ-dɛnɛs- ɐd-**lɛ**	2SG.M		
ɪswɐ tɪ-dɛnɛs-ɐd-**lɪʧ**	3SG.F	ɪnɛsu jɪ-dɛnɛs-ɐd-**lu**	3PL
ɪsu jɪdɛnɛs-ɐl-∅	3SG.M		

The construction for a progressive aspect uses periphrasis and subordination, rather than an aspectual marker. The example below demonstrates.

347. ɪ- jɛ- ɾotʰ-kʰu n- a͡ʊ
1SG-REL-run- 1SG.PFV be-3SG.M
‘I am running’ / ‘It is that I run’

In the example above, the verb ‘to be’ is conjugated for a third person singular masculine subject. Then, the relativizer /-jɛ-/ is placed between the agreement marker /ɪ-/ and the root of the verb ‘to run.’ Finally, the perfective aspect, which indicates something is more ‘present’, is used. The periphrastic construction as a whole indicates a progressive aspect. More examples can be seen in the table below.

Figure 13:

ɪjɛ-ʧɐwɛtʰ-kʰu n-a͡ʊ	I am playing
ɪj-ɛɾotʰ-kʰu n-a͡ʊ	I am running
ɐj-ɐnɐbɛb-kʰu n-a͡ʊ	I am reading

Mood

Indicative

The indicative mood is shown through inflection on the verb. The subject is denoted by pronominal markers preceding the verb. These can include a pronominal noun or a pronominal prefix. Indicative verbs are formed by the verb root, in this example /dɛnɛs/, with a prefix and a suffix indicating person and number, and an infix indicating aspect.

Figure 14:

ɪ-dɛnɛs-ɐd-la͡ʊ	I dance	ɪɲɐ ɪn-dɛnɛs-ɐd-lɛn	We dance
tɪ-dɛnɛ-**ʃ-** ɐd-lɛ-**ʃ**	You dance (f.)	ɪnɐntʌ tɪ-dɛnɛs-ɐd-lɐʧu	Y’all dance
tɪ-dɛnɛs- ɐd-lɛ	You dance (m.)		
ɪswɐ tɪ-dɛnɛs-ɐd-lɪʧ	She dances	ɪnɛsu jɪ-dɛnɛs-ɐd-lu	They dance
ɪsu jɪdɛnɛs-ɐl	He dances		

Imperative

The imperative mood is shown through inflection on the verb. Second-person imperatives are formed either by using a null morpheme or with the suffix /-i/. The examples below demonstrate the use of both morphemes.

Figure 15:

dɛnɪs-∅	Dance! (m.)	ta-tɛf-∅	Turn! (m.)	hid-∅	Go! (m.)
dɛnɛʃ-**i**	Dance! (f.)	ta-tɛf-**i**	Turn! (f.)	hidʒ-**i**	Go! (f.)

The second-person femenine form uses the suffix /-i/ while the second-person masculine form uses a null morpheme /-∅/. Interestingly, consonant mutation, specifically palatalization, is also used to inflect for a command directed at a female. In the form for 'Dance! (m.)', the alveolar consonant [s] is at the end of the root, but in the form for 'Dance! (f.)', the palatal consonant [ʃ] is at the end of the root. This also occurs with the forms of 'Go!.' For a masculine recipient, the alveolar consonant [d] is used, but for a femenine recipient the affricate consonant [dʒ] is used.

Furthermore, in some cases, the vowel in the root of the verb changes to a cardinal vowel. Take the following examples:

348. ɪ-ɾ**o**tʰ-ɐd-la͡ʊ
AGR-run-ʔ-1SG
'I run'

349. ɾ**u**t
run.IMP.2SG.M
'Run! (m.)'

350. ɾ**u**-ʧi
run-2SG.F.IMP
'Run! (f.)'

In the first example the root of the verb uses the vowel [o]. However, in the imperative forms of the verb, the cardinal vowel [u] appears.

For negative commands, the vowel remains the same as it would in the indicative mood. The word [ɪndɐtʰ], meaning 'don't' is added before the verb, as shown in the examples below.

351. ɪndɐtʰ ɾotʰ
do.not run.2SG.M.IMP
'Don't run! (m.)'

352. ɪndɐtʰ ɾo-ʧi

do.not run-2SG.F.IMP

'Don't run! (f.)'

Subjunctive

Amharic does not seem to have a distinctive subjunctive pattern, but does have several constructions for expressing hopes and desires that would be considered subjunctive. Although the constructions vary, almost all of them have an imperative marker. One of the forms is triggered by the construction 'if…it would be better ' which is more directly translated as 'one should…', and varies by person and is inflected on the verb. This construction is created through the addition of the prefix 'if' *b-* to a special form of the verb that can only be used with this prefix, and through the addition of an imperative suffix. The verb is then followed by the word for 'it would be better', whose infix varies for person and has an imperfective suffix.

353. ˈb-ɑnɛb jɛ-ʃall-e͡ɪŋ-al

if-read.1SG GEN-better-1SG-IPFV

I should read it.

354. bɪ-ˈtʰa-nɛb-∅ jɛ-ʃall-ɛh-al

if-2SG-read.2SG.M-2SG.M.IMP GEN-better-3SG.M-IPFV

You (masc.) should read it.

355. bɪ-tʰa-nɛb-i jɛ-ʃall-ɛʃ-al

if-2SG-read.2SG.F-2SG.F.IMP GEN-better-3SG.F-IPFV

You (fem.) should read it.

As can be seen in these examples, the *b-* 'if' prefix precedes the special forms of the verb 'to read' *ˈmanbɛb*. The special forms for each person are: 'I read' *-anɛb*, 'you (m) read' *-tʰanɛb*∅, and 'you (f) read' *ˈtʰanɛbi*, where the null morpheme (for the masculine) and the *-i* suffix (for the feminine) are the imperative suffixes. The null morpheme is known to be there even if it doesn't appear because the feminine counterpart has the imperative suffix *-i*, so therefore the masculine is most likely also marked for imperative through the null morpheme.

This construction does not get triggered in the past tense, as can be seen in the following examples.

356. ˈmanbɛb nɛbbɛr-ɛˈb-ɪkʰ
read be.PST-should-3SG.M
You (masc.) should have read it.

357. ˈmanbɛb nɛbbɛr-ɛˈb-ɪʃ
read be.PST-should-3SG.F
You (fem.) should have read it.

The verb ‘to read’ does not have the /b-/ prefix or imperfective suffix as it remains in its infinitive form *ˈmanbɛb* and is combined with the past tense form of should, which is marked for person.

Another construction that resembles the subjunctive appears when the subject expresses a desire about themselves. There is a different construction for when the subject expresses a desire about someone else, and that will be explained in the next section.

When expressing a desire about one’s self, the construction is created through the use of the verb ‘to wish/to hope’ *mɛˈmɛŋŋɛtʰ,* in combination with the more complicated ‘to be’ verb *mɛˈhon*. To show the contrast between this construction and an adjectival copulative sentence, below is an example that shows a copulative sentence that is formed with the more common ‘to be’ root /n/. In the example that follows after, because of the use of ‘I hope’ *ɛn ˈmɛŋallɛu,* that verb is replaced by the unconjugated *mɛˈhon.*

358. ˈrɛʤɪm n-e͡ɪŋ
tall be-1SG
I am tall

359. ˈkɑ-swa ˈrɛʤɪm mɛˈhon ɛ-nmɪˈŋɑl-lɛu
than-3SG.F tall be 1SG-hope-PERF
I wish I were taller than her.

In example 358, the ‘to be’ verb is conjugated for the first person singular with the suffix *-e͡ɪŋ*, while example 359 shows how the ‘to wish/to hope’ construction causes the *mɛˈhon* verb to surface in its unconjugated form.

Another construction that can occur is when *mɛˈhon* is combined with the ‘if’ prefix *b-* to mean ‘If I were’.

360. ʧˀɑwɑ bɪ-ˈhoːn
quiet if-be.IMP.M
If I were quiet

361. hon
be.IMP.M
‘Be! (commanding a single masculine subject)’

In this example, *mɛˈhon* has the prefix *b-* and is conjugated in its imperative form (which is seen in example 360) . In examples 353, 354, and 355, the prefix *b-* is attached to the verb along with an imperative suffix. In this example, the -ˈhoːn is elongated for emphasis and in an imperative construction, retaining the b- + verb + imperative construction, even if the imperative morpheme is not present.

Another construction that can occur is the aforementioned one when the subject expresses a desire about someone else. This is done by combining the verb for ‘to want/to hope’ *mɛˈfɛllɛg* with the *ɪndɪtʰ-* construction. According to our speaker, the *ɪndɪtʰ-* construction is used when you want an action to occur, so it makes sense that it is being used here in combination with the verb ‘to like’ *mɛwdɛd* as the subject wants who this is directed to to like the cake.

362. ˈkʰeikʰ-u-n ɪndɪtʰˈ-wɛd-∅ ɛffɛlɪˈgal-lɛu
cake-DEF-ACC APP-like-2SG.M.IMP 1SG-want-PERF
I hope you (masc.) like the cake

363. ˈkʰeikʰ-u-n ɪndɪtʰˈ-wɛdʒ-i ɛffɛlɪˈgal-lɛu
cake-DEF-ACC APP-like-2SG.F.IMP 1SG-want-PERF
I hope you (fem.) like the cake

In these examples, *ɪndɪtʰ-* is combined with the verb ‘to like’ in the second person singular, and the imperative suffix, which both vary by gender. When combined with *mɛˈfɛllɛg* in the first person *ɛffɛlɪˈgallɛu*, it more directly translates to ‘I want you to like the cake’.

The final “subjunctive” construction that will be covered is one that also expresses a desire, but more directly translates to ‘it is important that…’. In this construction, when the

variation *jasˈfɛllɪgal* of ‘to want/to hope’ *mɛˈfɛllɛg* is used, the verb in the relative clause is left in the infinitive form with a definite suffix attached to it (which matches the gender of the subject of the relative clause). This can be seen in the example below.

364. mɛkʼɑˈbɑtʰ-wɑ jɑsˈfɛllɪgɑl
paint-DEF.FEM want
It is important that she paints

This construction of infinitive verb + definite marker + ‘to want/to hope’ can be seen in this example with the feminine definite suffix *-wa* that is attached to the infinitive of the verb ‘to paint’ *mɛkʼaˈbatʰ* and is followed by *jasˈfɛllɪgal*, an unknown variation of *mɛˈfɛllɛg.* This construction is different because it does not have any imperative markings or the prefix *b-* ‘if’, yet it resembles the subjunctive mood because it expresses a desire and triggers the infinitive verb + definite marker form, which is a form that has not appeared elsewhere and seems to be unique to this construction.

Verbal Inflection - Matthew Wilkinson

Pronominal Subject Inflection

Amharic verbs take pronominal suffixes to indicate the person, number, and gender of the verb's subject.

365. sar- a͡ʊ

work.PERF-1SG.SUB

'I worked'

These suffixes function as a sentence's grammatical subject, and the inclusion of an independent pronoun subject is grammatical, but not equivalent, since doing so focalizes the subject.

366. ɪne͡ɪ sar- a͡ʊ

1SG.SUB work.PERF-1SG.SUB

'As for me, I worked'

The table below shows the independent pronouns of Amharic, along with their corresponding pronominal subject suffixes.

Figure 16:

Pronoun Gloss	Independent Subject	Subject Suffix
1SG.SUB	ɪne͡ɪ	-a͡u
1PL.SUB	ɪŋja	-an
2SG.M.SUB	anta	-ɪh[7]
2SG.F.SUB	ant͡ʃi	-ʃ
2PL.SUB	ɪn:anta	-t͡ʃu
3SGM.SUB	ɪsu	-a
3SGF.SUB	ɪswa	-at͡ʃ
3PL.SUB	ɪn:ɛsu	-u

[7] Our consultant informed us that the underlying form of this pronoun is /ɪk/, but that in "easier," informal speech, it is realized as [ɪh]

Figure 17 elaborates by including an example verb, whose verbal noun citation form is [mɛbarak], “to be blessed.” This verb is in a passive form, as reflected in the English translations, but the pronominal suffixes remain grammatical subjects in these examples. The suffixes are underlined for clarity.

Figure 17:

Amharic	Gloss	English
barak͡aʊ	bless.PASS.PERF-1SG.SUB	‘I was blessed’
barakɪn	bless.PASS.PERF-1PL.SUB	‘We were blessed’
barakɪh	bless.PASS.PERF-2SGF.SUB	‘You (M) were blessed’
barakɛʃ	bless.PASS.PERF-2SGM.SUB	‘You (F) were blessed’
barakat͡ʃu	bless.PASS.PERF-2PL.SUB	‘You (PL) were blessed’
baraka	bless.PASS.PERF-3SG.M.SUB	‘He was blessed’
barakɛt͡ʃ	bless.PASS.PERF-3SG.F.SUB	‘She was blessed’
baraku	bless.PASS.PERF-3PL.SUB	‘They were blessed’

As is clear when comparing tables (16) and (17), the vowels in these suffixes have some variation depending on phonological environment, but the above summary holds generally true across the data, with one major exception: the first person pronominal suffix has an irregular variant that appears to be related to the third person object pronoun, [kut]

367. at'ɛb- kʰʉ̥

wash.PERF-1SG.SUB.3SG.OBJ

‘I washed (it)’

This variant suffix appears with considerable frequency, and is observable on both transitive (367) and intransitive (368) verbs, which is highly interesting and calls for further research.

368. rot'- kʰu̯

run.PERF-1SG.SUB.3SG.OBJ

'I ran (it)'

Pronominal Object Inflection

Within Amharic verbs, a verb's object is marked with an object suffix that follows the subject suffix[8].

369. astamɛr- ɪʧ- ɪŋ

learn.CAUS.PERF- 3SG.F.SUB- 3SG.OBJ

'She taught me'

Amharic's pronominal object suffixes are laid out in Figure 18 below.

Figure 18:

Pronoun Gloss	Object Suffix
1SG.OBJ	-ɪŋ
1PL.OBJ	-nɛ
2SG.M.OBJ	-uh[9]
2SG.F.OBJ	-uʃ
2PL.OBJ	-t͡ʃun
3SG.M.OBJ	-kut
3SG.F.OBJ	-kwat
3PL.OBJ	-u

In Figure 19, we return to our example verb, [mɛbarak]. While this verb is in a passive-marked form[10], it takes an active meaning when given an object suffix. The subject in all of these examples is third person, singular, and feminine.

[8] Except in future/progressive verbs

[9] Just as with the subject suffix, the 2SG.M object suffix ends with an underlying /k/ that is commonly realized as [h]

[10] Discussed further in section X

Figure 19:

Amharic	Gloss	English
barakɛt͡ʃɨn	bless.PASS.PERF-3SG.F.SUB-1SG.OBJ	'She blessed me'
barakɛt͡ʃan	bless.PASS.PERF-3SG.F.SUB-1PL.OBJ	'She blessed us'
barakɛt͡ʃih	bless.PASS.PERF-3SG.F.SUB-2SG.M.OBJ	'She blessed you (M)'
barakɛt͡ʃɪʃ	bless.PASS.PERF-3SG.F.SUB-2SG.F.OBJ	'She blessed you (F)'
barakɛt͡ʃɨt͡ʃ	bless.PASS.PERF-3SG.F.SUB2PL.OBJ	'She blessed you (PL)'
barakɛt͡ʃkut	bless.PASS.PERF-3SG.F.SUB-3SG.M.OBJ	'She blessed him'
barakɛt͡ʃkwat	bless.PASS.PERF-3SG.F.SUB-3SG.F.OBJ	'She blessed her'
barakɛt͡ʃu	bless.PASS.PERF-3SG.F.SUB-3PL.OBJ	'She blessed them'

Verbal Aspect:

In Amharic, the default aspect of a verb is perfective. Verbs without any aspect-marking carry perfective meaning. In contrast, an imperfective prefix is necessary to mark any imperfective verb as such. This imperfective prefix changes to agree with the subject pronoun.

Perfective verbs are most often used to refer to events that happened in the past, and imperfective verbs are most likely to be used when referring to the present. I have written the English translations in this section accordingly. However, our consultant has emphasized to us throughout our research that past and present tense are not grammatically denoted on verbs, but rather conveyed through connotation. Below are perfective and imperfective versions of [mɛbarak].

370. barak- ɛt͡ʃ
bless.PASS.PERF- 3SG.F.SUB
'She was blessed (perfective[11])'

371. tʰɪ-_____barak- ɛt͡ʃ
IMPERF.3SG.F- bless.PASS- 3SG.F.SUB

[11] It's difficult to convey perfective aspect in English on a passive verb, but unfortunately this is the only clear minimal pair between these two kinds of verbs which I have transcribed

‘She is blessed (imperfective)’

Figure 20 below demonstrates the forms taken by the imperfective prefix in agreement with each subject pronoun.

Figure 20:

Pronoun Gloss	Imperfective Prefix
IMPERF.1SG	ɪ-/a-
IMPERF.1PL	ɪn-
IMPERF.2SG.M	tʰɪ-
IMPERF.2SG.F	tʰɪ-
IMPERF.2PL	t͡ʃ- -
IMPERF.3SGM	jɪ-
IMPERF.3SGF	tʰɪ-
IMPERF.3PL	jɪ-

Figure 21 includes examples of these each of these prefixes applied to [mɛbarak].

Figure 21:

Amharic	Gloss	English[12]
ɪbarɛ[13]kau	IMPERF.1SG- bless.PASS-1SG.SUB	‘I am blessed’
ɪnbarɛkan	IMPERF.1PL- bless.PASS-1PL.SUB	‘We are blessed’
tʰɪbarɛkɪh	IMPERF.2SG.M- bless.PASS-2SG.M.SUB	‘You (M) are blessed’
tʰɪbarɛkʃ	IMPERF.2SG.F- bless.PASS-2SG.F.SUB	‘You (F) are blessed’
tʰɪberɛkat͡ʃu	IMPERF.2PL- bless.PASS-2PL.SUB	‘You (PL) are blessed’
jɪbarɛka	IMPERF.3SG.M- bless.PASS-3SG.M.SUB	‘He is blessed’
tʰɪbarɛkɛt͡ʃ	IMPERF.3SG.F- bless.PASS-3SG.F.SUB	‘She is blessed’

[12] No single English word corresponds to the underlined section of the first two columns, so none are underlined in the translation

[13] The realization of this vowel as [ɛ] rather than [a] in these examples is conditioned by stress and not morphologically meaningful

jɪbarɛku	IMPERF.3PL- bless.PASS-3PL.SUB	'They are blessed'

Verbal Aspect: Future/Progressive Imperfective

Verbs resembling [tɪbarakɛt͡ʃ] exist in Amharic, but they are surprisingly rare. The majority of imperfective verbs are not in this standard imperfective form, but instead are inflected by an additional affix, [-all], which appears between the verbal root and the subject pronominal suffix. Our consultant tells us that this affix is prescriptively considered to mark the future tense. This grammatical future marker is often found on verbs that semantically take place in the present, based on context and the particular verb involved. When used in past or present tense, [-all] indicates progressive aspect.

Examples (372-374) contrast the three verbal aspects of Amharic. Note that the imperfective prefix remains when the future/progressive suffix is added.

372. barak- ɛt͡ʃ
bless.PASS.PERF-3SG.F.SUB
'She was blessed (perfective)'

373. tʰɪ-_____barak- ɛt͡ʃ

IMPERF.3SG.F- bless.PASS- 3SG.F.SUB
'She is blessed (imperfective)'

374. tʰɪ- barak- all-_____ɛt͡ʃ

IMPERF.3SG.F- bless.PASS- FUT 3SG.F.SUB
'She will be blessed' OR 'She is being blessed'

[all] does not agree with the subject of the verb it modifies. However, in two instances, it presents with slight variation. These variant forms are not grammatically different from the ordinary suffix [all]. They are laid out in Figure 22below for comparison.

Figure: 22

Pronoun Gloss	Future Suffix

all others	-all-
2SG.F.SUB	-jall-
3SGM.SUB	-l

The [jall] variant does not lend itself to easy phonological explanation, as it fails to appear in a nearly identical environment, as demonstrated by examples (375) and (376).

375. tʰɪ- barak- jall- ɛʃ

IMPERF.2SG.F- bless.PASS- FUT- 2SG.F.SUB

'You (F) will be blessed' OR 'You (F) is being blessed'

376. tʰɪ- barak- all- ɛt͡ʃ

IMPERF.3SG.F- bless.PASS- FUT- 3SG.F.SUB

'She will be blessed' OR 'She is being blessed'

In addition, this variant occurs across our data, regardless of which verb is being modified.

377. tʰɪ- tʃɪ- jall- ɛʃ

IMPERF.2SG.F- know- FUT- 2SG.F.SUB

'She will know' OR 'She is knowing'

This suggests that the variant is either a vestige of a defunct system of agreement that once applied to this affix, or perhaps the result of a more subtle or inconsistently applied phonological process. In contrast, there appears to be a simpler phonological explanation for the variant impacting future suffixes on verbs with third person singular masculine subjects. This becomes clear when comparing such a verb (X) to a verb with a non-variant future suffix (X).

378. jɪ- barak- a- l

IMPERF.3SG.M- bless.PASS- 3SG.M.SUB- FUT

'He will be blessed' OR 'He is being blessed'

379. ɪ- barak- all- a͡ʊ

IMPERF.1SG- bless.PASS- FUT 1SG.SUB-

‘I will be blessed’ OR ‘I am being blessed’

In the context of this comparison, it seems that the underlying form of [jɪ-barak-a-l] is actually /jɪ-barak-all-a/. The surface realization breaks down the nearly duplicated pair of syllables /all-a/ and retains the meaning of both syllables with [a-l]. This might be described as near-degemination.

The largest morphological impact of the future/progressive suffix is that it inverts the subject and object suffixes, thus shifting the morphological constituent order from VSO to VOS. Examples (380-382) demonstrate this.

380. barak- ɛt͡ʃ- ɪŋ

bless.PASS.PERF-V 3SG.F.SUB-S 1SG.OBJ O

‘She blessed me’

381. tʰɪ- barak- ɛt͡ʃ- ɪŋ

IMPERF.3SG.F- bless.PASS-V 3SG.F.SUB-S 1SG.OBJ O

‘She blesses me’

382. tʰɪ- barak- ɪŋ- all- ɛt͡ʃ

IMPERF.3SG.F- bless.PASS-V 1SG.OBJ -O FUT- 3SG.F.SUB S

‘She will bless me’ OR ‘She is blessing me ’

In addition, third person plural objects suffixes cannot be used in future/progressive verbs, as in (383). Instead a workaround expression is used, as in (384). This is likely because the third person object suffix is the same as the third person subject suffix, which would make (383) a potentially confusing expression.

383. *tʰɪ- barak- u- all- ɛt͡ʃ

IMPERF.3SG.F- bless.PASS- 1SG.OBJ - FUT- 3SG.F.SUB

*‘She will bless them’ OR ‘She is blessing them’

384. ɪnɛsu- n tʰɪ- barak- all- ɛʧ

3SG.PL- OBJ IMPERF.2SG.F- bless.PASS- FUT- 3SG.F

‘Them, she will bless’ OR ‘Them, she is blessing’

Imperative Mood

The imperative mood is primarily achieved in Amharic, like in English, by truncating the verb stem to its bare form. As in Arabic, inflectional imperative suffixes are then added to verbs commanding subjects other than the masculine singular default. Examples (385-388) demonstrate this. While we weren’t able to collect any explicitly imperfective, future, or progressive imperative data for contrast, these words are most likely of the perfective default aspect.

385. mɛhon

VN.be

‘being, to be’

386. hon

be.PERF.IMP.2SG.M

‘Be! (commanding a singular masculine subject)’

387. hon- i

be.PERF.IMP- 2SG.F

‘Be! (commanding a singular feminine subject)’

388. hon- u

be.PERF.IMP- 2PL

‘Be! (commanding a plural subject)’

Verbal Inflection: Summary

_____Figure 23 summarizes subject and object pronominal inflection of verbs, the three major verbal aspects of Amharic, and the imperative, using the example verb [mɛbarak], which means "to be blessed." The verbal root is colored red in order to distinguish the verb from its inflection.

Figure 23:

Verbal noun citation form	mɛbarak				
			Imperfective		
	Pronoun Gloss	Perfective	Standard Imperfective	Future/Progressive	Imperative
Subject	1SG	baraku	ɪbarɛkau	ɪbarakallau	
	1PL	barakɪn	ɪnbarɛkan	ɪnɛbarakallɛn	
	2SG.M	barakɪh	tɪbarɛkɪh	tɪbarakallɪh	bark
	2SG.F	barakɛʃ	tɪbarɛkʃ	tɪbarakjallɛʃ	bɛrɛki
	2PL	barakat͡ʃu	tɪberɛkat͡ʃu	tɪbarakallat͡ʃu	bɛrɛku
	3SG.M	baraka	jɪbarɛka	jɪbarrakal	
	3SG.F	barakɛt͡ʃ	tɪbarɛkɛt͡ʃ	tɪbarakallɛt͡ʃ	
	3PL	baraku	jɪbarɛku	jɪbarakallu	
Object (with 3SGF Subject)	1SG	barakɛt͡ʃɪŋ	tɪbarɛkɛt͡ʃɪŋ	tɪbarkɪŋallɛt͡ʃ	
	1PL	barakɛt͡ʃan	tɪbarɛkɛt͡ʃnɛ	tɪbarknallɛt͡ʃ	
	2SG.M	barakɛt͡ʃɪh	tɪbarɛkɛt͡ʃuh	tɪbarkahallɛt͡ʃ	
	2SG.F	barakɛt͡ʃɪʃ	tɪbarɛkɛt͡ʃuʃ	tɪbarkaʃallɛt͡ʃ	
	2PL	barakɛt͡ʃɪt͡ʃ	tɪbarɛkɛt͡ʃut͡ʃ	tɪbarkat͡ʃwallɛt͡ʃ	
	3SG.M	barakɛt͡ʃku	tɪbarɛkɛt͡ʃkut	tɪbarkkutallɛt͡ʃ	
	3SGF	barakɛt͡ʃkwat	tɪbarɛkɛt͡ʃkwat	tɪbarkkwatallɛt͡ʃ	
	3PL	barakɛt͡ʃu	tɪbarɛkɛt͡ʃu		

ɪndɪ(tʰ)- Verbal Prefix: A Dependency Marker- Shea Husband

The prefix ɪndɪ- is an incredibly interesting and versatile prefix in Amharic. Although mostly used in causative constructions with the verb *marɛg*, meaning 'to make' or 'to do', this prefix appears with many verbs, and is not restricted to purely causative constructions. When asked explicitly what this prefix meant, our consultant said that it was used to show when you want an action to occur or 'for it to be [action]'. One might say that this marker is marking volition, and while most of the examples will line up with that, some specific ones do not. However, I will attempt to show that this marker is, in fact, a subordination marker for clauses with multiple conjugated verbs. Let's look at some examples of this marker used with various verbs.

389. antʃʰi ɪnd-wɛtʰ-kʼɻ arɛg-ʃ-ɪŋ
2SG.F SUB-fall-1SG.PRF make-2SG.F.SUB-1SG.OBJ
'You made me fall (fem)

390. wɪʃa-wu-n ɪndɪtʰ-sɛtʼ-eŋ arɛb-kʼu̟
dog-DEF-ACC SUB-give.3SG-1SG.OBJ let-1SG.PRF
'I let her give me the dog'

391. jɛ wɛnd gwadɛŋa-ei ɛratʰ ɪndɪ-sɛra rɛd-ɛŋ
GEN man friend-POSS.1SG dinner SUB-make.PRF help.3SG.PRF-1SG.OBJ
'My boyfriend helped me cook dinner'

392. kʰeikʰ-u-n ɪndɪtʰ-əwɛd ɛ-ffɛlɪg-allɛw
cake-DEF-ACC SUB-like.2SG.M 1SG-want-FUT
'I hope (want) you like the cake (masc)'

393. ɪndi-dɛnnɪss-ɛ ɛ-fɛlɛg-allɛw
SUB-dance-3SG.M 1SG-want-FUT
'I want him to dance'

394. ɪnna kʰɛdn-ɛʃ ɪndɪn-tʰɛkatʰɛkʰ tʰ-adɛg-jallɛʃ
and close-2SG.F.PROG SUB-bubble.3SG.PRF 2SG-do-2SG.F.FUT
'And then close it until it simmers'

395. jɛ-ras-u-n ɪndɛ-honn-u awekʼ-ɛ
GEN-head-POSS.3SG.M-OBJ SUB-to.be-3PL.PERF know-3SG.M.PERF
'And then he realized that those were his (pears)'

As these examples show, this prefix has an interesting distribution. Not only does it appear on the secondary verb in the causative construction (example 389), but it also appears with the permissive 'let' (example 390), with 'want' and 'hope' (examples 392 and 393), as well as with 'to know or realize' (example 395). Now, while each of these *ɪndɪ-* prefixes tend to serve slightly different semantic functions, I argue that they all fit underneath the the umbrella of subordination.

So what does this mean for our examples? What this marker is showing is that there are two actions occurring in one clause, and that the action marked with *ɪndɪ-* is dependent or subordinate to the main verb of the clause. In addition, the subordinate verb is also conjugated. In terms of an example, let's take a look at our first example from above:

396. antʃʰi ɪnd-wɛtʰ-kˈɻ̥ arɛg-ʃ-ɪŋ
2SG.F SUB-fall-1SG.PRF make-2SG.F.SUB-1SG.OBJ
'You made me fall (fem)

In this example, we have two actions here, 'you (fem) made me' and 'I fell'. 'You made me' is the superior verb in the hierarchy, so it is marked normally, while 'I fell' is the subordinate action, so it is therefore marked with *ɪndɪ*.

In the last example (397), we see this same thing with the verb 'to know/'to realize'. The fact that this person 'realized' was the most important action. The pears belonging to him was secondary to the action of realizing or knowing. Let's take a look at another example using the same verb from example (395):

397. dɛfar-wa mɪn ɪnd-arɛg-ɛʃ tʰ-akˈ-jallɛʃ
sly.person-DEF.F what SUB-do-3SG.F.PERF 2SG-know-2SG.F.PROG
'Do you (fem) know what this *dɛfar* did to me?"

In this example, you (fem) knowing is the superior action to 'what this *dɛfar* did.' To make it clear who was performing the action of the subordinate verb, it is still conjugated like it would be if it were functioning as the main verb with the addition of the ɪndɪ(tʰ) to ensure that you know that there is another action occurring higher in a hierarchy that is acting on the subordinate action. In this example, the relationship is that 'you (fem)' another person is *knowing* about the action that '*this defar*' committed.

Non-finite Verbs- Hannah Staats

There is at least one type of non-finite verb in Amharic. Whether it is the citation form of the verb is unknown, but it is the form the consultant frequently provided for English infinitives and gerunds. These non-finite verbs are typically marked with *mɛ-* or *ma-*. Verbs with two consonants in the root end in *-at* in the non-finite form, as shown in 398-399. Verbs with three consonants (or more) in the root, such as the example in 400, do not have this ending.

398. [mɛblatʰ]
eat.VERBN
'to eat'

399. [mɛsɾatʰ]
work.VERBN
'to work'

400. [manbɛb]
read.VERBN
'to read'

Word Class of Non-finite Verbs

mɛ- or *ma-* is seen at the beginning of many of the non-finite verb forms elicited so far, but also at the beginning of many nouns, such as those shown in (401-403). At least one word, *mɛs'af*, can refer to both a verb and a related noun, as shown in (403).

401. [mɛgɪb]
'meal'

402. [mɛɾkɛb]
'boat'

403. [mɛs'af]
'book' or 'to write'

This similarity led us to investigate the syntactic function and word class of these non-finite verb forms.

Possession of Non-finite Verbs. There is evidence that at least some of these non-finite verbs can take personal possessive suffixes. In (404-406), we see possessive suffixes for 3rd

person singular masculine and feminine, as well as 1st person singular, attach to *madɛnnɛs* 'to dance' or 'dancing.' The consultant shared that these words would not constitute a complete sentence or thought, consistent with an analysis of these forms as noun phrases. Another example is shown in (407), in which the 3rd person singular feminine suffix attaches to *mahon* 'to be.' Note that the 3rd person singular possessive suffixes can also mark definiteness on nouns, but the consultant offered possessive rather than definite translations.

404. [madɛnnɛsu]
madɛnnɛs-u
dance.VERBN-3SG.M.POSS
'his dancing' or 'him dancing'

405. [madɛnnɛswa]
madɛnnɛs-wa
dance.VERBN-3SG.F.POSS
'her dancing'

406. [madɛnnɛse]
madɛnnɛs-e
dance.VERBN-1SG.POSS
'my dancing'

407. [mahonwa][14]
mahon-wa
be.VERBN-3SG.F.POSS
'her being'

The consultant affirmed that the same suffixes could attach to *manbɛb* 'to read.' Previously, she had judged the construction [jɛneɪ manbɛb] as not quite grammatically incorrect, but not something that Amharic speakers would say. Her comments suggested an interpretation of 'reading' in [jɛneɪ manbɛb] as the object of the action, such as a book or packet, rather than a nominalization of the action itself. More data is needed to clarify whether possession of some or all non-finite verbs is typically expressed with suffixes rather than separate possessive pronouns, such as *jɛneɪ*, or if this distinction was related to the different meanings of the English word 'reading' as an object or an action.

[14] From The North Wind and the Sun

Plural Suffixation of Non-finite Verbs. The consultant judged the non-finite verb forms with the plural suffix *-otʃ* shown in (408-409) as ungrammatical.

408. *[manbɛb-otʃ]
read.VERBN-PL

409. *[mɛtʰamɛm-otʃ]
have pain.VERBN-PL

Non-finite Verbs in Adpositional Phrases. This same form of non-finite verb can appear in adpositional phrases headed by *sɪlɪ-* 'about,' as shown in (410-411), and *bɛfit* 'before,' as shown in (412-413). In (414), *seit-wa* 'the girl' appears following the prefix *kɛ-* and preceding *bɛfit*. The non-finite verbs in (412) and (413) appear in this same position.

410. [sɪlɪmanbɛb ɪjaʊɾaʊ nɛbɛɾ]
sɪlɪ-manbɛb ɪ-jaʊɾ-aʊ nɛbɛɾ
about-read.VERBN 1S.SBJ.IMPERF-talk-1S.SBJ.IMPERF be.PST
'I was talking about reading'

411. [sɪlɪmadɛnnɛs ɪjaʊɾaʊ nɛbɛɾ]
sɪlɪ-madɛnnɛs ɪ-jaʊɾ-aʊ nɛbɛɾ
about-dance.VERBN 1S.SBJ.IMPERF-talk-1S.SBJ.IMPERF be.PST
'I was talking about dancing'

412. [kʰɛmanbɛb bɛfitʰ]
kʰɛ-manbɛb bɛfitʰ
from-read.VERBN before
'before reading'

413. [kʰɛmɛdɛnnɛs bɛfitʰ]
kʰɛ-mɛdɛnnɛs bɛfitʰ
from-dance.VERBN before
'before dancing'

414. [wɛndu kʰɛseitʰwa bɛfitʰ bɛlla]
wɛnd-u kʰɛ-seitʰ-wa bɛfitʰ bɛlla
boy-DEF.M from-girl-DEF.F before eat.3S.M.PERF
'The boy ate before the girl'

Verbal Noun Classification.

The sections above illustrate that this form of non-finite verb can take possessive suffixes and can appear in adpositional phrases. Calling these forms 'verbal nouns' can best account for their treatment like nouns in these contexts. The sections below outline additional uses of the verbal noun.

Use with Finite Verbs

The verbal noun can be used in subordinate clauses of higher finite verbs. One example is given in (415). The verb *ɪfɛlɪgallɛʊ* 'I want' is finite, marked for future tense, imperfect aspect, and a first person singular subject. *mɛk'ojɛt* 'to wait' or 'waiting,' shares the same subject as *ɪfɛlɪgallɛʊ*, but this is not marked on the verbal noun. Nor is the verbal noun marked for tense. Note the use of the *-ɛt* suffix, which will be discussed further below.

415. [ɪne mɛk'ojɛt ɪfɛlɪgallɛʊ]
ɪne mɛk'oj-ɛt ɪ-fɛlɪg-allɛʊ
1S wait.VERBN-? 1S.SBJ.IMPERF-want-1S.SBJ.IMPERF.FUT
'I want to wait'

The verbal noun can also be used when the subject of the finite verb does not match what would be the subject of the nonfinite verb. In the example in (416), the verb *ɐstɐrɪʧiŋ* 'she taught me' is marked for the third person singular subject and the first person singular object. 'Ride' would have a first person singular subject, but the non-finite form *mɛndɐt* is used.

416. [biʃkʰɛˈlɛtʰun mɛnˈdɐtʰ ɐstɐrɪˈʧiŋ]
biʃkɛlɛt-u-n mɛndat astar-ɪʧ-iŋ
skateboard-DEF-ACC ride.VERBN teach-3S.F.SBJ.PERF-1S.OBJ
'She taught me to ride the skateboard'

Another example is given in (417). Here, passive verbal noun *mɛsɛɾat* 'to be worked' is used. Since *mɛsɛɾat* is passive, *s'agɾɛɲ* 'my hair' would be the subject of the verb if it were finite. A more literal translation might be 'I want my hair to be worked/done.'

417. [s'agɾɛɲ mɛsɛɾat ɪfalɪgall͡ɛʊ]
s'agɾ-ɛɲ mɛsɛɾat ɪ-falɪg-all͡ɛʊ
hair-1S.POSS work.PASS.VERBN 1S.SBJ.IMPERF-want-1S.SBJ.IMPERF.FUT

‘I want to get my hair done’

***Use with* nɛbɛrɛb**

The verbal noun is used in sentences which in English contain ‘should have.’ It is used alongside the verb *nɛbɛr*, which used to convey ‘being’ in the past. This verb takes a suffix *-ɛb*, which conveys a ‘should’ meaning, followed by another suffix marking the semantic subject. Examples with active verbal nouns are given in (418-421).

418. [manbɛb nɛbɛrɛbɛɲ]
manbɛb nɛbɛr-ɛb-ɛɲ
read.VERBN be.PST-should-1S.OBJ
‘I should have read it’

419. [manbɛb nɛbɛrɛbɪʃ]
manbɛb nɛbɛr-ɛb-ɪʃ
read.VERBN be.PST-should-2S.F.OBJ
‘You (f.) should have read it’

420. [manbɛb nɛbɛrɛbɪkʰ]
manbɛb nɛbɛr-ɛb-ɪkʰ
read.VERBN be.PST-should-2S.M.OBJ
‘You (m.) should have read it’

421. [mɛtɛŋɐtʰ nɛbɛrɛbɛtʰ]
mɛtɛŋɐtʰ nɛbɛr-ɛb-ɛt
sleep.VERBN be.PST-should-3S.F.OBJ
‘She should have gone to sleep’

In (422-423), the same structure is used with passive verbal nouns. The syntactic subject precedes the passive verbal noun, followed by *nɛbɛrɛbɛt*. Note that in the sentences in (421-423), which all have 3rd-person subjects, the *-ɛt* suffix in the same place as the marker of the semantic subject in sentences X-X.

422. [mɛs’afu mɛnabɛb nɛbɛrɛbɛt]
mɛs’af-u mɛnabɛb nɛbɛr-ɛb-ɛt
book-DEF read.PASS.VERBN be.PST-should-?
‘The book should have been read’

423. [keku mɛbɛlat nɛbɛɾɛbɛt]

kek-u	mɛbɛlat	nɛbɛɾ-ɛb-ɛt
cake-DEF	eat.PASS.VERBN	be.PST-should-?

‘The cake should have been eaten’

Example (424) shows *nɛbɛr* used in a sentence with a nominal predicate. Just as in the sentences above, the predicate *jɛ morgɛn* ‘Morgan’s’ precedes *nɛbɛr*. Here, *nɛbɛr* is not marked for the subject, *jɛjɛrus mɛkʰina* ‘Eyerus’s car.’

424. [jɛjɛrus mɛkʰina jɛ morgɛn nɛbɛr]

j-ɛjɛrus	mɛkʰina	jɛ	morgɛn	nɛbɛr
POSS-Eyerus	car	POSS	Morgan	be.PST

‘Eyerus' car was Morgan's’

In contrast to the sentences presented above, the verbal noun has not been elicited in passive sentences in the simple past. Another construction, containing a passive finite verb and *nɛbɛr*, is used. An example is given in (425).

425. [kʰe͡ɪkʰˈu tɛbɛlˈto ˈnɛbɛɾ]

ke͡ɪk-u	tɛ-bɛlto	nɛbɛɾ
cake-DEF	IMPERF-eat.PASS	be.PST

‘The cake was eaten’

-ɛt *suffix*

The sentences in (418-421) support an interpretation of *-ɛt* as a third person singular marker. However, consider the sentences in (426-427). The verbal noun *mɛk’oj* can optionally take the *-ɛt* suffix, with the plain version being less common. Furthermore, it is unclear what a 3rd person marker would correspond to in this sentence. It is possible it could mark the object of the verb, for which the subject would be waiting. In that case, the optional nature of the suffix may arise from the ability to use *mɛk’oj* as either a transitive or intransitive verb. The consultant described suffixed *mɛk’ojɛt* as more strict about the ‘to’ part of the verb, and more connected to the person doing the action. She described *mɛk’oj* as a more vague action, detached from the actor. One interpretation of these comments could be that *-ɛt* derives the true infinitive form of the verb from the verbal noun. This would suggest that ‘I want to wait’ is a literal translation of

the sentence in (426), and 'I want waiting' is a literal translation of the sentence in (427). Another possibility is that *-ɛt* creates a verb form that refers to a specific instance or occurrence of an action, with the plain form referring to the action in a more general, abstract sense.

426. [ɪne mɛk'ojɛt ɪfɛlɪgalɛʊ]
ɪne mɛk'oj-ɛt ɪ-fɛlɪga-lɛʊ
1S wait.VERBN-? 1S.SBJ.IMPERF-want-1S.SBJ.IMPERF.FUT
'I want to wait' (more common)

427. [ɪne mɛk'oj ɪfɛlɪgalɛʊ]
ɪne mɛk'oj ɪ-fɛlɪga-lɛʊ
1S wait.VERBN 1S.SBJ.IMPERF-want-1S.SBJ.IMPERF.FUT
'I want to wait' (less common)

By contrast, the *-ɛt* attached to *nɛbɛɾ* in (422-423) seems to be required, as the consultant judged the sentence in (428) as ungrammatical.

428. [mɛs'afu mɛnabɛb nɛbɛɾɛb]
*mɛs'af-u mɛnabɛb nɛbɛɾ-ɛb
book-DEF read.PASS.VERBN be.PST-should
'The book should have been read'

She further commented that *-ɛt* contributed to the 'should' meaning of this sentence. It is unclear whether a 3rd person marker would correspond to the syntactic subject, in this case *mɛs'afu* 'the book,' or the unnamed actor reading the book.

Nonconcatenative Morphology- Matthew Wilkinson

Roots and Patterns

_____Amharic morphology shares a system of roots and patterns with the other Semitic languages, although it is seemingly devolved or less developed. This nonconcatenative morphological system is typologically unusual outside of the Semitic languages because a root and its pattern are expressed concurrently as opposed to following one another sequentially as distinct concatenative morphemes.

In Semitic languages, a root is an abstract series of consonants associated with a broad lexical meaning, while a pattern, or form, is an empty 'skeleton' of consonants and vowels that occur before, after, and between root letters, deriving from them a meaningful word. Noun and adjective patterns exist, but nonconcatenative morphology is most productive in verbs. To demonstrate this in Amharic, we can take [s, ɾ], the consonants of the two-letter root which relates to work and working. Written in the Ge'ez syllabary, the two-letter root is pronounced:

429. sɪɾ

work

'Work (lemma/citation form)"

[sɪɾ] is not a meaningful word but rather a useful abstraction by which native speakers cite this root. For consistency, this section will cite all roots by listing their consonants separated by commas. In order to represent each pattern, which structurally consists of all the sounds outside of the root that give it specific meaning, this section uses numerals in place of root letters. The numbers [1, 2] will represent the consonants of two-letter roots, and the numbers [1, 2, 3] will serve the same purpose for three-letter roots.

Nonconcatenative Word Formation: Nouns and Adjectives

Many different words can be formed from a single root. For a simple example, one can assign the root [s, ɾ] to a nominal pattern.

430. sɪr[15]a

work.NOUN

'Job'

The pattern applied in (430) can be abstracted as [1ɪ2a], with 1 and 2 representing the first and second letters of a two-letter root, in this case [s] and [ɾ]. This pattern's morphological role is simple, it derives a noun. Not much data collection was focused on noun-deriving patterns, but we have recorded several nouns following the pattern [1ɪ2a]. Figure 24 compares three such instances, in order to elaborate on the derivational process. It is important to note that this pattern is not the only pattern used to form nouns, and, as discussed later in this section, not all Amharic nouns show evidence of root-pattern word formation.

Figure 24:

Root		Pattern		Derived word		
Lexical meaning	Consonants	Derivational meaning	Structure	Amharic	Gloss	English
work	s, ɾ	NOUN	1ɪ2a	sɪra	work.NOUN	job
water	w, h			wɪha	water.NOUN	water
dog	w, ʃ			wɪʃa	dog.NOUN	dog

In the table above, neither the root's consonants nor the pattern's skeletal structure can stand on their own as meaningful language. The consonants [w, ʃ] are associated with the lexeme 'dog,' but cannot be used in a sentence without being layered onto the [1ɪ2a] noun structure. These two elements of the word [wɪʃa] cannot be sequentially delineated. One does not precede or follow the other, instead they intersperse one another to form the indivisible verb stem.

This word's gloss, 'dog.NOUN', may seem redundant, since there doesn't seem to be a more intuitive word class for this root's associated lexeme. Outside of this section, the word would

[15] The realization of this underlying alveolar tap as an alveolar trill is conditioned by stress and not morphologically meaningful

simply be glossed as ‘dog,’ but here I have retained the redundant gloss in order to emphasize that the vowels between these consonants mark these words as nouns. This semantic impact is most clear on the word [sɪra], which has obvious verbal alternatives.

Another simple pattern, this one adjectival, is arranged in Figure 25. It is important to note that all[16] patterns can be applied to either two-letter or three letter roots, so both alternatives are presented here.

Figure 25:

Root		Pattern		Derived word		
Lexical meaning	Consonants	Derivational meaning	Structure	Amharic	Gloss	English
learning	m, m, ɾ	ADJ	$t^hɪ12ɪ3$	$t^hɪm:ɪɾ$	learn.ADJ	educational
small	d, l, k’			$t^hɪdlɪk'$	large.ADJ	large
large	n, ʃ		$t^hɪ1ɪ2$	$t^hɪnɪʃ$	small.ADJ	small

Just as with the example of ‘dog’ above, the derivation of adjectives from roots associated with meanings such as ‘large’ and ‘small’ may seem unremarkable. However, root-pattern analysis becomes useful when observing this pattern’s application to less obviously adjectival roots such as [m, m, r].

Nonconcatenative Word Formation: Verbs

Between all word classes in Amharic, root-pattern morphology appears to be most productive in verbs. Multiple different verbs can be derived from a single root, and in this analysis I use the term ‘verb forms’ to refer to the different patterns of verb derivation. As with all other patterns in a root-pattern system, verb forms are derived from roots by the distribution of vowels and consonants surrounding root letters. Four examples of verbs using the simplest, ‘unmarked’ verb form can be found in Figure 26.

[16] As far as our limited data can attest

Figure 26:

Root		Pattern		Derived word		
Lexical meaning	Consonants	Derivational meaning	Structure	Amharic	Gloss	English
falling	w, d, k’	VERB	1ɛ23	wɛdk’	fall.VERB.PERF.IMP.2SG.M	fall!
reading	n, b, b			nɛb:	read.VERB.PERF.IMP.2SG.M	read!
work	s, ɾ		1a[17]2	sar	work.VERB.PERF.IMP.2SG.M	work!
eating	b, l			bal	eat.VERB.PERF.IMP.2SG.M	eat!

Note that verbs are formed without any inflectional affixes. In Amharic, uninflected, ‘bare,’ verbs are by default perfective and imperative to a masculine second person subject. Inflectional suffixes attach to these derived verbs in order to inflect beyond these defaults. (431-432) illustrate this.

431. ji- sar- a- l
IMPERF.3SG.M work.VERB- 3SG.M.SUB FUT
‘He will be working’ OR ‘He is working’

432. sar- a͡ʊ
work.VERB.PERF[18]- 1SG.SUB
‘I worked’

Each verb-deriving pattern has an associated verbal noun. Figure 27 below demonstrates the verbal noun pattern that corresponds to the unmarked verb form introduced in Figure 26 above.

Figure 27:

[17] The particular character of this vowel seems to be flexible between [a] and [ɛ], a common phonological alternation in Amharic, likely conditioned in this case by the phonological features of the root letters on either side.
[18] This verb is perfective because it is not marked as imperfective. Perfective aspect is the default on Amharic verbs, not an element particular to this verb pattern.

Root		Pattern		Derived word		
Lexical meaning	Consonants	Derivational meaning	Structure	Amharic	Gloss	English
falling	w, d, k’	VN	mɛ12a3	mɛwdak'	fall.VN	falling
reading	n, b, b			mɛnbab	read.VN	reading
work	s, ɾ		mɛ12at	mɛsɾat	work.VN	working
eating	b, l			mɛblat	eat.VN	eating

The majority of words using this pattern are indeed verbal nouns, but, as discussed in the section on verbal nouns, some words that fit this pattern are ordinary nouns, referring to objects rather than actions. This seems to depend on the meanings and origins of particular words. Further research is needed into these outliers. Nonetheless, the classification presented in Figure 27 is still useful because, while some words sharing this pattern are not verbal nouns, all verbal nouns observed in the course of our research adhere to this pattern.

Marked Verb Forms

The most common verb form is the unmarked form introduced above, but most roots can also be derived into marked verb forms that convey differences of valency. However, it must be noted that not all roots can be derived to all verb forms. In this brief study we have found robust evidence for three marked verb forms, but it is typologically likely that more forms exist, since Arabic has ten common verb forms and even more uncommon ones. The evident Amharic verb forms are: unmarked, passive, causative, and reflexive. Just as explained regarding the unmarked verb form in Figures (26) and (27), each of the marked verb forms has a corresponding verbal noun pattern. For this reason, this section will deal with verb forms primarily through verbal nouns, since they can be glossed more simply.

Figure 28, below introduces the passive verb form.

Figure 28:

Root		Pattern		Derived word		
Lexical meaning	Consonants	Derivational meaning	Structure	Amharic	Gloss	English
blessing	b, ɾ, k	PASS.VN	mɛ1ɛ2a3	mɛbaɾa[19]k	bless.PASS.VN	being blessed
reading	n, b, b			mɛnɛbab	read.PASS.VN	being read
work	s, ɾ		mɛ1ɛ2at	mɛsɛɾat	work.PASS.VN	being worked
eating	b, l			mɛbɛlat	eat.PASS.VN	being eaten

In order to form a passive verb, one assigns root letters into a slightly altered skeletal pattern. As a result, passive verb stems have a distinct two-syllable rhythm. Figure 29 compares unmarked and passive verbal nouns.

Figure 29:

Unmarked vs Passive form			
Form	Amharic	Gloss	English Translation
Unmarked	mɛsɾat	work.VN	working
	mɛblat	eat.VN	eating
Passive	mɛsɛrat	work.PASS.VN	being worked
	mɛbɛlat	eat.PASS.VN	being eaten

Passive expressions can be accomplished in more than one way in Amharic, and the passive verb form is used less frequently than the passive inflection discussed in a previous

[19] As is true throughout Amharic realization of this vowel varies between [a] and [ɛ], seemingly based on stress

section. Unlike passively inflected verbs, verbs in the passive verb form are inflected with normal pronominal affixes. A subject affix added to a passive verb represents the semantic patient but the grammatical agent of the verb. This is illustrated by example (433)

433. barak- ɛt͡ʃ
bless.PASS.VERB.PERF- 3SG.F.SUB
'She was blessed (perfective[20])'

Note that the verb [barak] belongs to the passive verb pattern [1a2a3] as opposed to the passive verbal noun pattern [mɛ1ɛ2a3]. These are parallel in structure and derivational meaning, but one does not directly derive from the other. Moving on the the causative verb form, the formation of such verbs can be seen in Figure 30

Figure 30:

Root		Pattern		Derived word		
Lexical meaning	Consonants	Derivational meaning	Structure	Amharic	Gloss	English
learning	m, m, r	PASS.VN	mast1a2a3	mastamar[21]	learn.CAUS.VN	teaching
reading	n, b, b			mas:nɛbab	read.CAUS.VN	making someone read
work	s, ɾ		mast12at	mas:ɛrat	work.CAUS.VN	making someone work
eating	b, l			mas:bɛlat	eat.CAUS.VN	making someone eat

[20] It's difficult to convey perfective aspect in English on a passive verb, but this verb is perfective by default like all Amharic verbs

[21] Three-letter roots with two repeating letters often assimilate these letters in patterns that are difficult to predict. In this case, it seems that the

Verbs in this form are pronounced with some variation, mainly between [st] and [sː]. With limited data, the exact reason for this difference in realization is difficult to parse, but our consultant understands them as the same grammatical entity, so the difference appears to be purely phonological. Given its presence in the corresponding causative verb form in Arabic, it is highly likely that /st/ underlying. For example, the Arabic word [xadama], which means "serve" in the unmarked verb form, becomes [ɪstaxdama], "employ," (or serve.CAUS) in the causative verb form. Figure 31 compares some instances of the same roots in the unmarked and causative verb forms.

Figure 31:

Unmarked vs Causative form			
Form	Amharic	Gloss	English Translation
Unmarked	mɛsrat	work.VN	working
	mɛblat	eat.VN	eating
	mɛmːar	learn.VN	learning
Causative	masːɛrat	work.CAUS.VN	making someone work
	masːbɛlat	eat.CAUS.VN	making someone eat
	mastamar	learn.CAUS.VN	teaching (making someone learn)

The final evident marked verb form in Amharic is the reflexive. The distribution and application of the reflexive form requires further research, because it occurs quite rarely in our data. This is likely due to displacement by the alternative method for reflexive formation discussed in another section.

Figure 32 compares different verbs in the reflexive form.

Figure 32:

Root		Pattern		Derived word		
Lexical meaning	Consonants	Derivational meaning	Structure	Amharic	Gloss	English
soul	n, f, s	REFL.VN	mɛtɛnɛf:ɛs	soul.REFL.VN	breathing	
blessing	b, ɾ, k		mɛtɛbaɾ:ɛk	bless.REFL.VN	blessing someone	
bed	n, j		mɛtɛnjat	bed.REFL.VN	going to bed	
lifting	n, s		mɛtɛnɛs:at	lift.REFL.VN	Waking oneself up	

Strangely, while this form is rarely used, its use remains commonly applied to a certain group of roots: those that cannot be derived to the unmarked verb form. For some such words, attempting to derive a verb in the unmarked verb form results in a noun without verbal meaning. For others, derivation into the unmarked verb pattern is impossible.

Figure 33 demonstrates this by applying all same roots from Figure 32 to the unmarked verbal noun form.

Figure 33:

Root		Pattern		Derived word		
Lexical meaning	Consonants	Derivational meaning	Structure	Amharic	Gloss	English
soul	n, f, s	VN	mɛ12a3	mɛnfas	soul	soul
blessing	b, ɾ, k			*mɛbrak	*bless.VN	*blessing
bed	n, j		mɛ12at	mɛnjɛta[22]	bed	bed
lifting	n, s			mɛnsat	lift.VN	lifting

[mɛnjɛta] and [mɛnfas] refer to objects, not actions, and [*mɛbrak] doesn't exist at all. This can explain the seemingly unrelated English translations observed in Figure 32.

Figure 34 repeats the 'derived word' section of Figure 33, this time with an added column for an explanation

Figure 34:

Derived word			
Amharic	Gloss	Consultant's English translation	Explanation
mɛtɛnɛf:ɛs	soul.REFL.VN	breathing	This can be understood as 'soul-ing oneself', or doing upon oneself the action that defines a soul[23].
mɛtɛbar:ɛk	bless.REFL.VN	blessing someone	This word is grammatically marked as reflexive, but, because no transitive form of the verb exists, it defaults

[22] The realization of underlying /jat/ as [jɛta] appears to be phonologically conditioned, since our consultant considers this word to share the same structural form as the others in its column

[23] The lexical overlap between 'soul' and 'breath' is shared by Arabic, which also expresses both concepts with the root [n, f, s]

			to having a transitive meaning.
mɛtɛnjat	bed.REFL.VN	going to bed	‘Bedding oneself’
mɛtɛnɛs:at	lift.REFL.VN	waking oneself up	‘Lifting oneself’

Marked Verb forms: Summary

A single Amharic root can be derived into multiple different verbs. The particular pattern into which the root consonants fit carry information regarding the resulting verb’s valency.

The pattern [mɛ12a3] or [mɛ12at] forms an active verb, the pattern [mɛ1ɛ2a3] or [mɛ1ɛ2at] forms a passive verb, the pattern [mast1a2a3] or [mast1a2at] forms a causative verb, and the pattern [mɛtɛ1ɛ2:ɛ3] or [mɛtɛ1ɛ2:at] forms a reflexive verb. To illustrate this model, Figure 35 compares all verb forms as being derived from the root [n, s].

Figure 35:

Root		Pattern		Derived word		
Lexical meaning	Consonants	Derivational meaning	Structure	Amharic	Gloss	English
lifting	n, s	VN	mɛ12at	mɛnsat	lift.VN	Picking something up
		PASS.VN	mɛ1ɛ2at	mɛnɛsat	lift.PASS.VN	Waking up/being lifted
		CAUS.VN	mast1a2at	mastanɛsat	lift.CAUS.VN	Waking someone up/causing someone to rise
		REFL.VN	mɛtɛ1ɛ2:at	mɛtɛnɛs:at	lift.REFL.VN	Waking oneself up/lifting oneself

Limitations and Challenges of Root-Pattern Analysis of Amharic

Although many details of root-pattern nonconcatenative morphology are shared between Amharic and Arabic, the system's relative subtlety in Amharic is a clear point of divergence between the two languages. Many grammatical processes that are primarily accomplished nonconcatenatively in Arabic, such as changes in valency, noun derivation, and plural formation, can be accomplished concatenatively in Amharic. Plural formation is the clearest of these differences, as demonstrated by the comparison of cognates in Figure 36. Most non-human Arabic plurals are formed by the application of the root to a plural pattern. In contrast to Arabic nonconcatenative plurals, Amharic has a consistent concatenative plural suffix.

Figure 36:

Singular		Plural		
Arabic	Amharic	Arabic	Amharic	English Meaning
be͡ɪt	be͡ɪt	buyuːt	be͡ɪtoʧ	house
nɛfs	nɛfs	nufuːs	nɛfsoʧ	soul
suːq	sːuk'	aswaːq	suːk'oʧ	market
raʔs	ras	ruʔuːs	rasoʧ	head

In addition, a typical[24] Semitic root consists of three consonants, but in Amharic, many two-letter roots also exist, as well as several verbal and nominal four to six consonant stems which generally elude root-pattern interpretation altogether. These 'long roots' aren't very frequent, so their presence might be explained by considering them long-nativized extrasemitic loanwords. Alternatively, a number of long roots show evidence of lexicalized reduplication, which suggests that they may have originated from shorter roots which fit the triconsonantal root system. (X-X) are examples of this potential reduplication. The repeating elements are underlined.

434. k'waŋk'wa

language

'language'

[24] Aramaic, Hebrew, or Arabic

435.	man	jɪ-	k’onap’ap’ɛs-	ɪl-	ɪŋ-	a-	l
	who	IMPERF.3SG.M-	hype-	INT-	1SG.OBJ-	3SG.M,SUB-	FUT
	‘Who will hype me?’						

While our consultant talked often of roots as the citation forms of different words, she didn’t seem to have a formal concept of the various patterns and forms into which these roots could fit, which further suggests a relative decentering of root-pattern morphology in the perceptions of speakers. Even where the root-pattern system remains strongly evident in Amharic, our limited research has been unable to thoroughly describe it beyond the above surface overview.

Diminutive/Augmentative -- Jane Whitley, Jeongyeob Hong, Hannah Kusserow

Diminutive

The diminutive can be formed in three ways in Amharic. One way of forming the diminutive is by adding the suffix *-wit*^{h} to the modified noun, as shown in 436-437. Preceding the noun with either of the adjectives *t*^{h}*ınıʃ* 'small' or *t*^{h}*init*^{h} 'tiny,' as shown in 438-439, is another common way of constructing the diminutive. Finally, a high tone present throughout the noun also marks the diminutive, as is shown in X.

436. [wɪʃawit^{h}]
wɪʃa-wit^{h}
dog-DIM
"Doggy"

437. [asamawit^{h}]
asama-wit^{h}
pig-DIM
"Piglet"

438. [t^{h}ınıʃ buna]
t^{h}ınıʃ buna
small coffee
"Small coffee"

439. [t^{h}init^{h} wulɛt^{h}a]
t^{h}init^{h} wulɛt^{h}a
tiny favor
"Small favor"

440. [t'abat͡ʃ̃] ɬ
t'abat͡ʃ̃ ɬ
HIGH\drop
"Droplet"

These three forms are not interchangeable. The diminutive suffix can only be used with animate nouns, as can be seen in its use in "doggy" and "piglet." Conversely, the adjectives can only be used with inanimate nouns such as "coffee" and "favor." Interestingly, the adjective *t*^{h}*init*^{h} cannot be used with liquids, as a liquid that small would be considered a drop and would

require being called as such. Finally, the high tone can only be used in verbal nouns such as "drop." Nominalized verbs cannot take either the diminutive suffix or the adjectives, only the high tone can be used to mark a diminutive form of a nominalized verb.

Eyerus noted that diminutive nouns, particularly animals, are assumed to be feminine. In examples like 436 and 437, doggy, [wɪʃawit^{h}], and piglet, [asamawit^{h}], the noun would be treated as feminine automatically. Their regular forms without the diminutive, dog, [wɪʃɑ], and pig, [asama], may be specified as masculine or feminine where relevant in a larger context. Conversely, augmented nouns, like "big dog" in 447, [wɪʃa͡ʊ] ɬ, are not necessarily assumed to be masculine.

This change of the gender with the diminutive suffix [-wit^{h}] is continued with human subjects as well. Due to phonological process, [-wit^{h}] sometimes becomes [-it^{h}]

441. lidʒ-it^{h}
child-DIM
'girl'

442. lidʒ
child
'Child'

Note that neutral or abstract nouns themselves usually represent male referrants. Similar to child, and female child relationship, 'person' can be diminutized to 'female person'

443. sɛw
person
'person'

444. sew-it^{h}-wa
person-DIM-DEF
'the woman (female person)'

445.	wɛnd-u	k^{h}ɛ-se-it^{h}-wa	bɛfit^{h}	bɛ-lla
	boy-DEF	POST-person-DIM-DEF	before	eat-3SG.PST

Augmentative

Similar to the diminutive, the augmentative can take multiple forms. A low tone is used with animate nouns, as is shown in 446-447. There is also an adjective, *t^{h}ɪdlɪk^{h}*, which is used with inanimate nouns, like in 448-449. The augmentative does not apply to verbal nouns. Instead

of marking it with either the low tone or the adjective, a verbal noun is swapped for another verbal noun entirely when its size is increased. This process can be seen in 450, in which the speaker opted for the noun “flow” instead of marking “drop” with the augmentative.

446. [dɪmɛtʰu] ɬ
dɪmɛtʰ-u ɬ
AUG\cat-DEM
“The big cat”

447. [wɪʃa͡ʊ] ɬ
wɪʃa-u ɬ
AUG\dog-DEM
“The big dog”

448. [tʰɪdlɪkʰu buna]
tʰɪdlɪkʰ-u buna
large-DEM coffee
“The large coffee”

449. [tʰɪdlɪkʰ zaf]
tʰɪdlɪkʰ zaf
large tree
“Big tree”

450. [fɛsaʃ]
fɛsaʃ
flow
“Flow”

Valency-Changing Processes - Jacky James, Lily Jenssen, Laura Rapp, Pat Vaidos

Passive - Pat Vaidos

Amharic constructs the passive voice by promoting the object of the phrase to the subject, and the verb agreement is adjusted for whether or not the subject in the active sentence is still mentioned in the passive. The verb form used for the passive undergoes the appropriate phonological change, and the word order is changed to promote the new subject in the passive to the beginning of the sentence. The verb in the active sentence is marked with a first person singular subject affix in the past tense, meanwhile in the passive sentence (452) the verb agrees with a third person singular subject, which in that instance would be the cake. In the passive example where the object is dropped, however, the verb ending is unique in that it's not used in any other tense/voice other than the passive. It's possible that it marks a third person singular object, as in to agree with the state of the cake being eaten.

451. ˈɛne͡i kʰe͡ikʰ-u bɛl -aʊ

1.sg cake -DEF eat.PASS -1.sg.subj.PST

'I ate the cake.'

452. kʰe͡iˈk-u ˈbɛ ˈɛne͡i tɛ- ˈbɛl -ɐ

cake -DEF by 1.sg IMPERF- eat.PASS -3.sg.M.subj.IMPERF

'The cake was eaten by me.'

453. kʰe͡iˈk-u tɛ- bɛlˈ -to ˈnɛbɛɾ

cake -DEF IMPERF- eat.PASS be.PST

'The cake was eaten.'

Causative - Jacky James, Lily Jenssen, and Laura Rapp

Causatives in Amharic are formed by adding different prefixes to a verb; these prefixes include /as-/ or /asatʰ-/ and a combination of /ɪndɪt-/ and /arɛk-/ or /arɛg/. In examples 454 and 455 below, the causative prefix /as-/ is shown on the verb, 'to wash', in both sentences. In example 456, the prefix is shown with a verb in the infinitive form. Example 456 shows how the initial infinitive prefix /m-/ is then followed by the causative prefix /as-/. Consequently, this verb literally translates to 'to make learn.'

454. mɛkin͡a-ʊ-n **as-** at^{h}ab-u- ut^{h}
car-DEF-ACC **CAUS**-wash-3PL-3SG.M.OBJ
'They had him wash the car'

455. enat^{h}-e lips- u- n **as-** at^{h}ab-etʃ- ɪn
mom-1POSS clothing-DEF-ACC **CAUS**-wash-3SG-1SG.OBJ
'My mom made me do laundry'

456. m- **ɐs-** tɛmɐr
INF-**CAUS**-learn
'To teach'

Meanwhile, periphrasis can also be employed. The verb, /arɛk/ meaning 'to make' or 'to cause', can also be used to indicate a causative action. The pronunciation of the word /arɛk/ changes based on the consonant that comes after the prefix. When it is placed before a voiceless consonant, [arɛk] with the voiceless velar stop is used, and when the prefix is placed before a voiced consonant the voiced velar stop is used, [arɛg]. This difference can be seen in the examples below.

When using the verb /arɛk/ in a general causative statement, the prefix /ɪndɪ/ must be used simultaneously. This prefix /ɪndɪ-/ is placed before the main verb in the underlying sentence. Then, the verb 'to make' is conjugated for the 'causer.' For example, in example 457, the prefix /ɪndɪ-/ is placed before the main verb in the underlying sentence 'to dance'. The verb 'to make' [arak] is followed by the suffix marking the person and number of the causer, in this case 'my female friend.' Finally, the suffix marking the causee is placed after the person/number suffix, in this case 'me.'

457. gwadɛŋa-eɪ **ɪndɪ**-danɪs **arɛg-** watʃ- eɪn
friend-1POSS **CAUS**-dance make- 3SG.F 1SG.OBJ
'My friend (female) made me dance'

458. mɛk^{h}in͡a-ʊ-n **ɪndj-** ɐtɛb **arɛk-**u- ut
car- DEF-ACC **CAUS**-wash make-3PL-3SG.M.OBJ
'They had him wash the car'

In the second version of the sentence, ‘They had him wash the car’, example 458 exhibits how the prefix /ındı-/ is added to the main verb, in this case ‘to wash.’ Then, on the verb ‘to make,’ the first suffix agrees in person and number with the third person plural causer ‘they’ while the second suffix agrees with the third person singular masculine causee ‘him’. The first example (at beginning) 454 compared with the example above (both car examples) demonstrate the two different ways causative sentences can be formed in Amharic.

Reflexives - Lily Jenssen, Laura Rapp, Jennifer Yang

Reflexives in Amharic are formed by adding slightly different affixes to show that the action is being done to the ‘self’. There is also an accusative ‘n’ marker in most of the examples. The construction is most easily seen in the last example, and in the examples ‘I wash myself’ and ‘They wash themselves’, the accusative marker is absent. Additionally, in ‘He washes himself’, the verb follows a different pattern.

Another cool thing is that reflexive pronouns are made from the word [ɛras] meaning ‘head’. The pronouns have inalienable possession suffixes on them which are basically the object pronouns. For example, ‘myself’ is [ɛrasɛɲ] which literally translates to ‘my head’.

459. ɛ-rasə-wa-n t'at^{h}b-all-ɛtʃ^{h}
she-REFL- -ACC wash-3SG.FEM
‘She washes herself’

460. ɛɲɲa -ɛˈrassat-ʃ^{h}ını-n ɛn-at'b-allɛn
we-REFL -ACC wash-3PL
‘We wash ourselves’

461. [ɛˈ-rassı-ʃı-n aˈt'ɛb-ʃ]
you- REFL- -ACC wash-2SG.F
‘You wash yourself (fem)’

462. ɛˈrası-hı-n aˈt'ɛb-k'ɻ
you-REFL- -ACC wash-2SG.M
‘You wash yourself (masc)’

463. ısu ɛˈras-u-n j-at'b-al
he-REFL- -ACC -wash-2IMPV-2SG.SUBJ

‘He washes himself’

464. t'ɛras-ɛŋa atʰb-al-lɛw

REFL-POSS wash-1MPV-1SG.SUBJ

‘I wash myself’

465. ɛras-atʃʼawiŋa at'b-allu

ɛras-atʃʼonŋa at'b-allu

REFL- POSS wash-3SG.SUBJ

‘They wash themselves’

466. ʃɛrɛritʰ-u ɛrasu-n bɛlla

bug-DEF REFL-ACC -eat-

‘The cricket bit itself’

Clefts - Shea Husband, Lily Jenssen, Rosita Ivanova

Clefts in Amharic, like in many languages, are used to focus particular pieces of information in a sentence. This focusing effect is achieved, on a general level, by shifting the focused item to the first position in the sentence, with a form of the verb 'to be' after, and then followed finally by the rest of the sentence in the form of a relative clause. Interestingly, it seems that many wh-questions appear to be clefted, showing that this movement of constituents to be focused is not a wholly uncommon occurrence. Clefts seem to follow three basic patterns, which will be demonstrated in the following examples:

467. tʰɪlantʰ nɛbɛr bahɛr-ga jɛ heid-kʰu-tʰ
yesterday was beach-DEF REL go-1SG.PERF-OBJ
'It was yesterday that I went to the beach'

468. tʰɪlantʰ jɛ heid-k'ᵚ-bɛtʰ bahɛr mɪ-hon-allɛbɛtʰ
yesterday REL go-1SG.PRF-must beach INF-to.be-must.have
'It must have been the beach that I went to yesterday.'

469. mɪndɪ-nɛw tʃɪggɛr-ɪʃ
what-3SG.MASC.to.be problem-2SG.FEM.POSS
'What's your problem?'

Each of the above examples exemplifies a common pattern of clefts. The first is the most general. In this example, and most others like it, the word that is being clefted, or emphasized, is moved to the first position of the sentence, followed by *nɛw* or *nɛbɛr*, the simple indicative forms of 'to be' in the present and past. The rest of the sentence then follows in the order that it would normally, with the addition of the relativizer *jɛ* before the verb. This relativizer signals that the clause is related to the one preceding it and not simply new information.

The second pattern is the one that occurs when the verb attached contains something other than the simple indicative form of ‘to be’. This is usually when expressing possibility and conjecture, like in example 468. In that example, The focused part is not moved to the front of the sentence, instead remaining where it is where it might be in a non-clefted sentence. It is followed by the verb, inflected for whatever you wish to inflect. In front of the focused part, however, is the relative clause with *jɛ*. This would show that the relative clause aspect of the cleft is quite flexible, being able to both precede and follow the main verb phrase, but as corroborated by the following example, it seems that when expressing conjecture or possibility, it goes before.

470.	jɛ	wɛdɛr-k'u-tʰ		kʰatɛrp'ilɛr	li-honn-itʃʰɛllal
	REL	like.PRF-1SG.SUB-3SG.M.OBJ		caterpillar	could<to.be>could
	‘It could have been the caterpillar that I liked.’				

The final pattern of clefts is wh-questions. While incredibly similar to the first pattern, they key difference between them lies in the inclusion of *jɛ*. This pattern, unlike the first, discludes them. Instead, the wh-question word is fronted to the first part of the sentence, followed immediately by the indicative form of ‘to be’ in either the present or the past (usually the present). The rest of the sentence then follows in the order it would normally. In the example 469 above, we just have a noun phrase, ‘your (fem) problem’ which comes after. Here is another example to show a longer sentence with this pattern.

471.	man-n-ɛw	kʰɛ-ʔɪhɪt-ʰɪʃ		ga	ɪ-mɪdɛnnɪ-saw
	who-to.be-3SG.M.PRES	from-sister-POSS.2SG.F		LOC	3SG-dance-3SG.M.PRF
	‘Who is dancing with your (fem) sister?’				

As this example shows, even with a longer sentence, the rest of the clause continues as if it were a normal clause, with no relativizer tying it to the original sentence. We would argue that

this is because the first clause is, in fact, a question, and that by adding more information, you are clarifying what you are talking about. In the general cleft pattern, because you made a statement, you would need some way to connect that back to your original statement, whereas here, because you've asked a simple question, the words that follow only serve to clarify your question.

Interrogatives (Rosita Ivanova, Vivian Bauer, Jennifer Yang)

Content Qs

Content questions follow the typical SOV structure of Amharic. The question words replace the phrase/answer that they stand for, therefore replacing the position of the object, and are located after the subject and before the verb, which maintains the SOV structure. Since the subject can be implied in Amharic because it is inflected on the verb, it can be omitted in content questions so that the word order is just OV.

Since the question words replace the answer that they stand for, the word order when answering questions also remains SOV, with the question word being replaced by the object in the sentence. A few examples of answers to questions have been provided with the questions below to exemplify this structure.

Below is a paradigm for the content question words:

Figure 37:

'who'	[man]
'what'	[mɪn]
'where'	[jɛtʰ]
'when'	[mɛʧe͡ɪ]
'why'	[ˈlɛmɪn]
'how'	[ɪnˈdeːtʰ]

The following example shows a question using the content question *jɛtʰ* 'where' that follows the standard SOV order, with the subject *waˈf-u* 'the bird' preceding the question word (which is replacing the object) *jɛtʰ* 'where', followed by the verb *na͡ʊ* 'to be'.

472. wɑˈf-u jɛtʰ na͡ʊ
bird-DEF where be-3.SG.M
'Where is the bird?'

The next example shows the structure of an answer to this question.

473. wɑˈf-u sɑˈma͡ɪ la͡ɪ na͡ʊ

bird-DEF sky POST be-3.SG.M

'The bird is in the sky'

The answer, 'in the sky' *saˈmaɪ laɪ͡*, takes the place of the question word, and is located after the subject *waˈʃ-u* 'the bird' and before the verb *naʊ͡*. The object is *saˈmaɪ͡* 'sky' and it is followed by the postposition *laɪ͡* , which follows the Amharic word order of subject, object, postposition, verb.

The following is an example of a content question with the word *man* 'who'. It once again follows the typical structure, with the question word being located after the subject *ɪˈswa* '3.F.SG' and before the verb *nɛʧ* 'be-3.SG.F'.

474. ɪˈswɑ man nɛʧ

3.F.SG who be-3.SG.F

'Who is she?'

The following is another example of the structure of an answer to a content question. The word *astaˈmari-wa* 'the teacher' replaces the question word *man* 'who' between the subject and the verb to maintain the order SOV.

475. ɪˈswɑ ɑstɑˈmari-wa nɛʧ

3.F.SG teacher-DEF be-3.SG.F

'She is the teacher.'

The following is an example of a content question with the question word *ɪnˈdeːtʰ* 'how'. It also follows the typical structure of SOV, with the question word following the subject *wɛldʒoˈʧi-ʃ* 'your parent'.

476. wɛldʒoˈʧɪ-ʃ ɪnˈdeːtʰ nɛ-ʧo

parent-2.SG.F how be-3.SG.F

'How is your parent?'

The following example shows a question using the content question *mɪn* 'what', where the subject is omitted as it is inflected as the second person singular masculine on the verb *jal-ɛkʰ* 'do-2SG.M', so the word order is OV.

477. mɪn jal-ɛkʰ n- aʊ͡?

what do-2SG.M be-PROG

'What are you doing?'

The following example shows a question using the content question *mɛʧe͡ɪ* 'when', the subject is *nɪdatɪ-ʃ* 'your birthday', the verb is missing so the word order is SO.

478. nɪdatɪ-ʃ mɛʧe͡ɪ?

birthday-2SG.F when

'When is your birthday?'

Polar Questions

In Amharic the word order for polar questions does not change from the equivalent declarative sentence, SOV. There is also no question marker, instead, "I am a doctor" and "Am I a doctor?" are said in the exact same way except the question version has a rising intonation during the last word.

479. ɛne͡ɪ hakʰim ne͡ɪn

[1.SG doctor be.1sg]

"I am a doctor"

480. ɛne͡ɪ hɐ'kʰim ne͡ɪn

[1.SG doctor be.1sg]

"Am I a doctor?"

This gives further context that the speaker is asking a question. Another interesting phenomenon with the polar question, "Am I with a doctor?" There is a /kʰɐ/ added before doctor and a /gɐ/ added after to express the word "with". The /ga/ clitic following the /kʰɐ/ 'with' is a locative marker

481. ɛne͡ɪ kʰɐ hɐ'kʰim gɐ ne͡ɪnˀ

[1.SG with doctor LOC be.1SG]

"Am I with a doctor?"

Purpose Clauses- Ethan Shaw

To express purpose of an action, Amharic speakers may mark the beginning of the clause with [wɛdɛ]- “to (a location).” The verb in this type of clause is expressed in the mɛ- form verbal noun.

482. wɛdɛ sɛɾɐlo mehed tɛnɛsɐlɛtʃ

She wakes up for work

Negation- Melia Gelinas, Jacky James

In terms of negation, Amharic has different words depending on the context they are being used in.

General Negation

The word for "no" in Amharic is [imbi], however based on the data gathered it seems that this form is not used in the same contexts that we might in English. To express the idea of "no", such as in not having something or not wanting something, it is more common to hear something more along the lines of "I don't want that", or "without that".

483.	mɪnɪm	bɪr	ɪalaɪɲ.ɛm	484.	jalɛɪ	apɛl
	none	birr (currency)	I have.NEG		without	apple
	I have no money				No apple	

The word "not" in Amharic seems to follow the thing it negates within a phrase, in terms of word order. Compare the below example of "mom not dad" and "not tomorrow morning" :

485.	nɛgat^{h}	ɛʊat^{h}	saɪhon	486.	abat^{h}	saɪhon	ɛnat^{h}
	Tomorrow	morning	not		Dad	not	mom
	Not tomorrow morning				Mom not dad		

In both these examples we see that "not" comes after the subject it is referring to.

Verbal negation

When the negation has to do with a state of being it is marked directly on the verb, typically with the prefix [al-], and the suffix of [-ɛm]. Compare the below examples:

487.	gabaɪn	488.	al.gəbaiɲ.ɛm
	I understand		NEG.understand.NEG
			I don't understand
489.	akˈalaʊ [25]	490.	al.aʊk.ɛm
	I know		NEG.know.NEG
			I don't know

[25] Note the underlying form /aʊkalaʊ/ of "I know" when comparing the derivation to the negated form.

491. ɛfɛlɛˈgallau
I want

492. al.fɛldɪg.um
NEG.want.NEG
I don't want

Note that each of the above examples is marked for negation both as a prefix and a suffix on the root. Amharic appears to have a prefix negation marker of [al-] as well as a suffix form of [-ɛm], such as in “I understand” [gabaɪn] vs. “I don't understand” [algəbaiɲɛm] which we see on verb forms.

When saying a negative command, the word [ɪndɐtʰ] is used which translates to “do not” in English. Additionally, in positive commands, the vowels jump to cardinal vowels, but in negative commands, the vowels that are in the root verbs, or in indicative sentences are used. These two points are illustrated in the examples below

493. ɾu-ʧ͡i
run-F.IMP
“Run!”

494. ɪndɐtʰ ɾo-ʧ͡i
do.not run-F.IMP
“Don’t run!”

The above examples show the use of [ɪndɐtʰ] before a negative command meaning ‘do not’ and also demonstrate the change in the vowels. In the first, positive example, the [u] vowel is used, but in the second, negative example the vowel [o] is used. The mid vowel [o] is the most frequent vowel used in other forms of the verb ‘to run.

Discourse and Pragmatics

A Recipe In Amharic: Shiro- Pat Vaidos, Vivian Bauer

To understand how recipes in Amharic are structured and told, we got our consultant to retell us a typical Ethiopian recipe in Amharic. It is important to mention that our consultant was told this recipe by her mom and told it to two female linguists which explains the female gendered verb endings. The title of the recipe is functions like an adjectival phrase where the first part of the phrase is modified by the last word /nɐgɐr/ which means “what things" or “thing(s).what”. The title also starts with the adjective /k’ond͡ʒo/ meaning beautiful as well as good to describe the stew.

Our consultant also mentioned that usually in the ingredients list for a recipe there aren’t exact measurements but instead everything is measured by taste. However, in the ingredients list, Eyerus used tablespoon and teaspoon by giving us an exact translation. For example teaspoon /ijɐ-ʃa͡imɐnkʰjɐ/, there is /ʃa͡ɪ/ which means tea and then /mɐnkʰjɐ/ which means table. Before these two words is a genitive case marker, which shows the attributive relationship between tea and spoon. The genitive case is also seen before the word full /jɛ-molɐ/, which is to denote the relationship between full and cup, meaning a cup full of water.

Ingredients List

Title: k’ond͡ʒo ʃəɾo lɛ-mɛsɾɐtʰ ɪmɐs-jɐlɪguʃ nɐgɐr
[beautiful shiro INF-make need-2SG.PROG.F thing(s).what]
“What you need to make good Shiro”

495. gɪmɐʃ k’a͡ɪ ʃɪnkʰurtʰ
[half red onion]
“half of a red onion”

496. nɛt͡ʃ’ʃɪnkʰurt
[garlic]
“some garlic”

497. hulɛtʰ jɛ-gɐβɐtʰɐmɐnkʰjɐ ze͡ɪtʰ
[two GEN-tablespoon oil]
“two tablespoons of oil”

498. sostʰ jɛ-gɐβɐtʰɐmɐnkʰjɐ ʃəɾo dukʰe͡ɪtʰ
[three GEN-tablespoons shiro powder]

“three tablespoons of chero powder”

499. sostʰ kubaɪ͡jɐ jɛ-molɐ muk’ (w)uhɐ
[three cup GEN-full warm water]
“three cups of warm water”

500. ɐnd ijɐ-ʃaɪ͡mɐnkʰjɐ tʃ͡ɛu
[one GEN-teaspoon salt]
“one teaspoon of salt”

With the directions for cooking shiro, our consultant did not list steps and rather explained the process of how to cook shiro. The ingredients list as well did not have a first ingredient, second, etc. The first ingredient mentioned in the directions has a unique second singular feminine possession suffix /-ɪʃɪ/ added to the end of the word for onion /ʃɪnkuɾtʰ/. Our consultant explained this as translating to “first you get your onions”. However, this possession suffix is not used for any other ingredient in the directions. Therefore, this possession marker sets precedent for the rest of the recipe. Since it is first stated that these are your ingredients, it doesn’t need to be restated later which shows an interesting discourse practice when retelling recipes in Amharic. The end of word /ʃɪnkuɾtʰ-ɪʃɪ-n/ there is also an accusative case marker /-n/ which is marked at the end of direct objects of transitive verbs in Amharic. The accusative case is also marked at the end of nouns in other examples like garlic /nɛʃɪnkurˈt-u-n/ which has the accusative case marker after the definite article /-u-/. In this line of the directions garlic is the direct object of the transitive verb “to add” which comes after the direct object, following the typical Amharic word order of SOV.

The verb tense used in the recipe is marked as a progressive tense, to indicate that the person acting out the recipe is in the process of making it, and the person telling the recipe is describing the process in the future. Eyerus described the tense as more in the future, but more a combination of future and present, “this is what you’re going to do” context. This can be seen in all of the verbs throughout the recipe, marked by the [tɐ-]/[tɪ-] imperfective prefix and the [-jɐlɪʃ] suffix. For example, in the first line of the recipe in example (501).

Due to the recipe describing the process of cooking as a whole rather than outlining specific steps, the transitions between verb phrases are marked by “then” ([kʰɐzɐ]) and “and” ([nɐ]) transition words, rather than in a numerical order. An exception is the first step of the

recipe, which is initialized with [mɛdʒɛmɛɾjɐ] meaning "first." Examples of [nɐ] and [kʰɐzɐ] are shown below in (503, 507, 508, 510) and (502, 505, 509).

The action of adding water little by little in the recipe is expressed with the use of reduplication, which we found very interesting. The phase is as follows: [bɛˈtɪnɪʧ ˈtɪnɪʧ] and comes after the object that is being added in the sentence and precedes the verb. The full gloss of the sentence is shown below.

Directions

501. mɛdʒɛmɛɾjɐ ʃinkuɾtʰ-ɪʃ-ɪn tɐ-kʼwi-jɐlɪʃ
[at.first onion-2SG.POSS.F-ACC IMPERF-saute-2SG.F.SBJ.PROG]
First, you saute your onions.

502. kʰɐzɐ ˈnɛʃɪnkurˈt-u-n ˈtɪ-ʧɐmri-jɐˈlɪʃ (one word)
[then garlic-DEF-ACC IMPERF-add-2SG.F.SBJ.PROG]
And then add garlic.

503. nɐ wəˈhɐj-u-n bɛ ˈtɪnɪʧ ˈtɪnɪʧ tɪ-ʧɐmɾi-nɐ tɪ-kɐlɐk-iwɐlɪʃ
[and water-DEF-ACC by little little IMPERF-add-an to.2SG.PROG-mix-2SG.F.SBJ.PROG]
and a little bit of water and mix those together

504. zeɪ͡tʰ nɐ dʒˈaʊ͡-n tɪ-ʧɐmri-jɐlɪʃ
oil and salt-DEF.ACC IMPERF-add-2SG.PROG.SBJ.FEM]
and then some salt and then you add the oil

505. kʰɐzɐ jɛʃəɾoʊ dukeɪ͡tʰ-u-n bɛ tɪnɪʃ tɪnɪʃ
[and.then GEN.shiro powder-DEF-ACC by little little

506. t-ɪʧ ɐmɾi-jɐlɪʃ
IMPERF-add-2SG.F.SBJ.PROG]
then you add a little bit of the chero powder at a time

507. nɐ jɐkʼɪɾɪ wuhaʊ͡-n ʧɐmɾ-ɪʃ tɐ-mɐsɾi-jɐlɪʃ
[and ????? water-DEF-ACC add-PROG.2SG.F IMPERF-cook-F.SBJ.PROG]

508. nɐ kɛdnɛʃ ɛnditekaktɛk tɐ-rig-jɐlɪʃ
[and close.it-SG.F.SBJ.PROG gurgle IMPERF-do-PROG.2SG.F]
and then you add a little bit of the water at a time until it's the consistency that you want

509. kʰɐzɐ kʼɐmsɐʃu ʧɛʊ͡ kɐs-fɛldɛgaʊ͡-sudɛn ʧɪsɐmɾi-jɐlɪʃ
[and.then taste?? salt need.SBJV add-2SG.F.SBJ.PROG]
"You let it cook, then you taste to see if you need a little bit more salt"

510. nɐ kɛdnɛʃu tɪnʧ ɪ-k’o͡i nɐ t-a͡ʊ ʧɪwɐl-ɪʃ
[and close.it little 3.SG-wait.IMP and IMPERF-take.off-2SG.F.SBJ.PROG]
“and cover it again and once it’s the right consistency and taste you take it off.”

Discourse Particles- Shea Husband, Pat Vaidos

Hesitation and Filler- Pat Vaidos

A common hesitation structure used when pondering one's next thought or utterance is Amharic is using an rising intonation towards the end of the utterance and ending with a high tone. Eyerus gave an example sentence, glossed below for tone in example 511.

511. L H H
suk' he͡ide͡i nɛbɛr (pause) nɐ
I went to the store (pause) and

One prominent discourse particle used in Amharic is the word [ɪnˈtɪn], which can be used in the same way as the filler word "like" in English.

Referential and Structural Markers- Shea Husband and Pat Vaidos

Referential markers are discourse particles that show sequence, coordination, and causality of events. In English, these are usually words like 'and', 'or', 'but', as well as 'because' and '(and) then'. These words often come up in longer strings of connected speech, and as such are important words to track when trying to break up larger streams of words into connected events with an order.

Coordination Markers

So far, we have elicited three coordination markers, the first and most prominent of which is 'and' or [ɪnna]. Similar to English, this marker is used to string multiple actions under one clause. This word can also be used to string nouns together as well. This is shown in the examples below:

512. ɪhɪtʰ **ɪnna** wɛndɪm
sister **and** brother
'Brother and sister'

513. pʰɛr awɛt'a **na** bäskʰeitʰ-u-stʰ arag-ɛ
pear pluck.3SG.M.PRF **and** basket-POSS.3SG.M-in put.PRF-3SG
'He plucked a pear and put it in his basket'

Interestingly, due to Amharic's word order, the order of coordinated noun phrases is often also flipped. Meaning, that while 'brother' comes before the 'and' in the English translation, it comes after in Amharic. This isn't an absolute, but it does happen often. In the second example, we see that both verbs are fully conjugated, with *na* separating them. In connected speech, the first vowel of *ɪnna* is often dropped, meaning most of the time, you will hear *na*, even in more careful speech. In addition, as mentioned above, 'and' is often used as filler or to hesitate.

The next coordination particle we want to discuss is 'or'. Similar to 'and', this particle coordinates two nouns in a noun phrase or two actions in a clause. While we don't have much clausal data, the use of the same word in both isolated noun phrases and embedded noun phrases would suggest that like in English, the same conjunction can be used in both cases. Here are some examples:

514. zarɛi **wɛjɛm** nɛgɛ
today **or** tomorrow
'Today or tomorrow'

515. p'agumɛ ammɪstʰ **wɛjɛm** sɪddɪstʰ k'ɛn-otʃʰ allɛw
P'agume five **or** six day-PL have.3SG.M.PROG
'P'agume has five or six days.'

While the order of the nouns with 'and' seems to occur opposite to that of English, *wɛjɛm* does not seem to follow this pattern.

The final coordination particle we wish to discuss is 'but'. Appearing as *gɪn*, this word coordinates phrases while showing that the two contrast or contradict each other in one way or another. In addition to performing it's usually function, [gɪn] can also be used as a filler word, shown in these examples from the Pear Story below:

516. pʰɛr-otʃʰ-u-n ajɛ **gɪn** mɪn-nɛm an-wosɛd-ɛm
pear-PL-DEF-OBJ see-3SG.PERF **but** what-NEG NEG<takɛ>NEG
'He looked at the pears but he didn't take any.'

517. kʰɛza **gɪn** (…)
and.then **but** PAUSE
'And then, but…'

Like with ‘and’, both verbs on either side of the coordinator are fully conjugated. In the second example, what’s interesting about the use of *gɪn* as a filler word is that it shows us that *gɪn*’s function as a shower of contrast or contradiction can be applied to your own thoughts as well. Our consultant mentioned that when she was saying that sentence, she had originally thought of one thing, contradicted it verbally with *gɪn*, and then proceeded to say her new thought.

Causality Markers

Causality markers are those that show a cause and effect relationship between two things. Unlike the coordination markers, which came between the two things it was coordinating, this structure appears as either a verbal prefix, or as a second verb. Let’s look at some examples:

518. bɪzu dɛmmɛna **sɪl**-allɛ ɛjɛzzɛnɛb-ɛ n-ɛw
many cloud **because**-exist to.rain-3SG.M.PRF to.be-3SG.M.PRES
‘It is raining because it is cloudy’

519. bɛ-wɪʃa-wu mɛ-**kʰŋatʰ** tʰɛ-(ɛ)nnɛs-u
by-dog-DEF INF-**because.of** PASS-wake.up-3PL.SUB.PERF
‘They woke up because of the dog’

In both examples, due to word order, the cause and effect appear in the opposite order as they do in English. In the first example, the prefix *sɪl-* is added to the fully conjugated verb of the cause, which was ‘being cloudy’. In the second example, the verbal noun [mɛkʰŋatʰ] is used. While this may seem unusual to speakers of European languages, this verb would be translated as ‘to be because of sth.’ In this example, the argument of the verb is marked with the instrumental *bɛ*, and the verbal noun is placed in front of ‘they woke up’ without any conjugation.

Structural Markers

Structural markers are words that show the hierarchy of phrases in a conversation. They often mark the phrases the speaker deems most important, and serve to give a conversation order and structure. Thus far, we have elicited two of these markers: [mɛdʒɛmɛrja] ‘first (of all)’ and [kʰɛza] ‘(and) then’. Due to the prominence and importance of [mɛdʒɛmɛrja] and [kʰɛza] to the structure of narratives, their uses will be explained in detail in the following section.

The Shiro recipe provides excellent examples of the use of referential and structural particles to describe the process of making the dish, shown below in examples (520) and (521).

520. kʰɐzɐ jɛʃəroʊ dukei̯tʰ-u-n bɛ tɪnɪʃ tɪnɪʃ
[and.then GEN.shiro powder-DEF-ACC by little little

521. nɐ kɛdnɛʃu tɪnʧ ɪ-k'oi̯ nɐ
[and close.it little 3.SG-wait.IMP and

t-aʊ̯ ʧɪwɐl-ɪʃ
IMPERF-take.off-2SG.F.SBJ.PROG]

Structure of Stories- Shea Husband

Over the course of this semester, we have been fortunate enough to elicit many longer-form stories in Amharic, including 'The Pear Story', 'The North Wind and the Sun' (both read and retold), a joke, as well as a recipe. In addition to all of the amazing phonological and morphosyntactic data these stories provided, they also showed a clear structure that they all seem to follow.

This structure begins with how you start a story. In every story that was told in Eyrus' own words, which excludes the joke and the official translation of 'The North Wind and the Sun', the first word was always the same: *mɛdʒɛmɛrja*. Meaning 'first' or 'at first', this word is the foundation the rest of the story is built off of. Let's look at the first lines of each story to see this in action:

522.	mɛʒɛmɛrɛja	jɛ	honn-ɛ	sɛwijɛ	zaf	laj	nɛbbɛr
	at.first	REL	to.be-3SG.M.PRF	man	tree	on	was.3SG
	'First, there was a man in a tree (from the 'Pear Story')'						

523.	mɛdʒɛmɛrja	ts'ɛhaj	ɪnna	nɛfas	ji-k^{h}arrak^{h}ɛr-u	nɛbbɛr
	at.first	sun	and	wind	3PL-argue-3PL.PRF	was.3SG
	'At first, the sun and the wind were arguing (from the 'retelling of NWAS[26]')'					

524.	mɛdʒɛmɛrja	ʃɛnk^{h}urt^{h}-ɪʃ-ɪn t^{h}-ak'wɛ-jallɛʃ
	at.first	onion-2SG.F.POSS-ACC 2SG-sautee-2SG.F.PROG
	'First, sautee your (fem) onions. (from the recipe instructions)'	

As we can see, this begins every story told from Eyerus' own words. This continued usage of the same word to begin stories suggests that having a clear narrative structure is an important in Amharic discourse.

Continuing on from *mɛdʒɛmɛrja*, the next most important thing is to introduce your primary actor. This seems to be done with the phrase [jɛ honnɛ], which translates roughly to 'this/that one (guy)'. In most cases, this phrase introduces either the first *person* to be spoken about, the main actor of the story, or the main receiver of the action. Let's take a look at the usage of this phrase across the stories:

[26] North Wind and the Sun

525. mɛʒɛmɛɾɛja jɛ honn-ɛ sɛwijɛ zaf laj nɛbbɛr
at.first REL to.be-3SG.M.PRF man tree on was.3SG
'First, there was a man in a tree (from first line of the 'Pear Story').'

526. ɪnna (...) jɛ honn-ɛ sɛwijei
and PAUSE REL to.be-3SG.M.PRF man
'And… this one guy (from the second line of the NWAS retelling)'

527. na k'-atʰɛgɛb-e jɛ honn-ɛ sawije nɛbbɛr[27]
and from-next.to-3SG.M.PRF REL to.be-3SG.M.PRF man was
'And there was this one guy next to him (from the first line of the joke).'

Each of these lines come from the first or second lines of the stories and each introduces a different kind of actor. In the Pear Story, this phrase introduces the man picking pears, who is arguably the main character of the film, as well as the first one to be discussed. In the retelling of the North Wind and the Sun, this phrase introduces the traveller, who is the receiver of all of the action in the story. And finally, in the joke, this phrase introduces the main character of the joke, or the man who tricks the greedy man into praying instead of getting the lost money. In these examples, this phrase is always used to introduce a male human. It would be interesting to see if it could also be used to introduce female people or others as well.

After the story is begun and your primary players are introduced, the events that unfold are sequenced through the use of the structural marker [kʰɛza] '(and) then' as well as [ɪnna] 'and'. While similar in meaning, the former seems to mark 'major events' or 'scenes' within the story. Within these larger scenes, actions are separated with 'and' or 'but'. Let's see a few examples of this:

528. kʰɛza bɛ-ʃaʃ-u aʃatʃʰ-o na mɛmɛs-at-ʃʰɛw.
and.then by-bandana-3SG.M.POSS wipe-pass and put.back-3SG.MASC.SUB-3PL.OBJ
'And then, he wiped them with his bandana and put them back (into the basket).'

529. kʰɛza gɪn and lidʒ-otʃʰ-u kʰofija-w ɛnɛss-a aj-u-nna tʰɛr-u-tʰ izaga[28]
and.then but one kid-PL-DEF hat-his drop-he.PRF see-3PL-and call-3PL-3SG over.there
'But (and) then, one of the kids saw that he dropped his hat and called him back.'

[27] Note, some glossing will not be done to its most complete degree for space's sake.
[28] Approximate glosses will be used for the sake of space.

In these examples, there are two actions within the same clause, divided by ‘and’. These sentences also both begin with *kʰɛza*, which also begins the sentences preceding and following these as well. Throughout most of the stories, the events unfold in this manner.

At this moment, there seems to be little in the way of structures to end spoken stories, but this is definitely something that would merit additional research. Another potential for research into stories and their structure would be a comparison of the structure of spoken stories and the more prescriptive, formal structures of storytelling.

Reduplication- Shea Husband

Reduplication in Amharic is a productive morphosyntactic feature that appears in many places and serves several functions. Including both partial and full reduplication, it seems that phonetic stems, verbs, adjectives, adverbs, as well as whole phrases can be reduplicated. Each of these reduplications has a different function, each of which will be described below.

Onomatopoeia

The reduplication in onomatopoetic phrases seems to be the most varied in purpose. For the most part, these fall into two categories: the natural (mostly full) reduplication of animal sounds or other concrete sounds and the duplication of certain stems to form iconic onomatopoeia. Almost every single animal sound we've found thus far in Amharic has come in pairs of two, save the dog and the cat. Here are some examples below:

530. kʰu kʰu
'Rooster sound'

531. bɛheʔɛ
'Sound of a sheep'

532. wɪwu wɪwu
'Sound of a siren wailing'

As these examples show, most sounds based on concrete sounds in the real world like a rooster cawing, a sheep baying, or a siren wailing, repeat in these repeating sets of two. This structure seems to occur frequently cross-linguistically, and makes sense, due to the sounds being based in nature. Interestingly, while most of the sounds reduplicate fully, the sheep sound in example 531 reduplicates the vowel three times, each time with a slightly different consonant sound.

The other way reduplication occurs in onomatopoeia is in the construction of iconic or mimetic onomatopoeia. These onomatopoeia are more abstract then their animal counterparts, and instead symbolize things like 'movement back and forth' or 'a relaxing day'. Let's take a look at some examples of this:

533. tʃʼatʃʼatʰa

‘Onomatopoeia for noise’

534. wɨrrɨwɨr

‘Onomatopoeia for lots of back and forth movement’

535. ʃɪrrɪʃr

‘Onomatopoeia for a relaxing day’

In these examples, we see a stem being fully reduplicated to create these iconic onomatopoeia that represent more abstract sounds in the world.

Verbal Reduplication

Verbal reduplication is one of the more interesting forms of reduplication we see in Amharic. In general, when a verb is reduplicated, the entire conjugated verb is duplicated two or three times. Let’s see some examples of this:

536. kʰɛza nɛfas nɛfas-u-n nɛfɛss-ɛ nɛfɛss-ɛ nɛfɛss-ɛ
and.then wind wind-DEF-ACC blow-3SG.PRF blow-3SG.PRF blow-3SG.PRF
‘And then the (North) wind blew and blew and blew…”

537. sɛwijɛ ajei ajei na pʰɛrotʃʰu lɛ mɛsrɛk’ tʰezzegadʒɛ.[29]
man look.look and pear-pl-def for to.steal got.ready
‘He kept looking at the man (in the tree) and then looked at the pears and started getting ready to steal them’

In these examples, the verbs are being duplicated two or three times to create a durative effect. And the more times the verb is duplicated, the more intense the effect seems to be.

Adjectival and Adverbial Reduplication

In addition to verbs and sounds, adjectives and adverbs, along with other descriptive words, seem to also be able to be reduplicated. While we have few examples of this, here are the ones we have:

538. kʰɛza jɛ-ʃɪro duk’eitʰ-u-n bɛ tʰɪmɪʃ tʰɪmɪʃ tʰ-ɪtʃʰameri-jallɛʃ
And.then GEN-shiro powder-DEF-ACC by small small 2-add-2SG.F.PROG
‘And then add the Shiro powder little by little’

[29] Glossing will be approximated for brevity’s sake.

539. and-and mɪgɪb
one-one food
'Some food'

In the first example, we see the adjective meaning 'small', [tʰɪnɪʃ], first turned into an adverb with the instrumental *bɛ*, and then reduplicated. This reduplication seems to have a distributive effect, creating this 'one at a time' or 'little by little' effect. More research into the productivity of reduplication in this regard would be incredibly helpful. In the second example, we see the numeral one being reduplicated and used as an adjective. In this case, the reduplication is creating a plural-like effect, turning 'one' into 'some'.

Phrasal Reduplication

In Amharic, in addition to individual words, entire phrases can be reduplicated. Let's take a look at this example from the retelling of 'The North Wind and the Sun':

540. ɪne n-ɛŋ t'ɛnkʰarra ɪne n-ɛŋ t'ɛnkʰarra bɛmid ji-kʰɪrakʰɛr-u nɛbbɛr[30]
1SG am stronger 1SG am stronger than 3-argue-3PL were
'(The North Wind and the Sun) were arguing who was stronger'

In this example, our consultant described this reduplication as trying to recreate the effect of arguing back and forth, saying that a good translation for this sentence might be, "And [they] were arguing saying 'I'm stronger!' 'No, I'm stronger." In addition to this, these phrases are also clefted, further emphasising the argument nature of the sentence.

[30] Glossing will be approximated for space.

Additional Observations

Onomatopoeia/Sound Symbolism- Melia Gelinas, Hannah Kusserow

Animal Sounds:

541.	Dog noise	[wuf]	545.	Sheep noise	[baʰaʰ]
542.	Cat noise	[miɛw]	546.	Horse gallop	[tʃɛ tʃɛ tʃɛ]
543.	Cow noise	[mu]	547.	Rooster call	[kʰukʰu]
544.	Small bird call	[twitwi]	548.	Owl call	[huhu]

Many of these animal noises are similar to what we might know or be familiar with in English, but they are modified in such a way as to better match within the phonetic inventory of Amharic. When speaking about a dog broadly the masculine form is used, femenine for cats, unless speaking about a specific one in which you know their actual gender. In terms of animals generally, Eyerus mentioned that typically animals are referred to with male pronouns, however small animals tend to get femenine pronouns.

Sound Symbolism: representations of the sense of a word by its sound

549. Sneeze sound	[ɛntis]
550. Pain exclamation	[tsss]
551. Laughter	[kiki]
552. What's so funny	[kiki bla]
533. *crash* (big things)	[tʃˈflik(k'k'k)]
544. *crash* (little things)	[sɪbɪr(rr)]
555. Impressed remark	[fwa]
556. For commentary:	[fwa bluwa]
557. *ring ring*	[tililili]
558. *ding*	[diŋg]
559. *boom*	[bu:f]
560. my heart dropped	[libeɪ wərɪd alɛ]
561. *drop*	[wərɪd]/[wərrrɪd]
562. Noise	[tʃˈatʃˈata]
563. Relaxing day/having fun	[ʃɛɾaʃɛɾ]
564. A lot/busy/all over	[wɛɾɛwɛɾ]
565. "cook until it pops"	[mantɛk'atɛk']

Interesting notes for this section: in crash there is an option reduplication of the ending. What is represented by this reduplication is emphasis on the crash noise, such that a repeated

[k'k'k'] at the end implies that the extent or noise of the crash was particularly large. The same occurs for the little things crashing, by holding out the word final rolled [r] in [sɪbɪr] for longer further emphasizes the action, as well as to emphasize the extent your heart dropped, in example 560 [libeɪ wərrrɪd alɛ] might be used for an especially intense roller coaster.

Eyerus noted that sound symbolism and onomatopoeia, particular the more adjectival descriptions of action like 563 [ʃɛraʃɛr] and 564 [wɛrɛwɛr] are almost uniformly reduplicated or doubled. Most bird sounds in onomatopoeia are doubled as well, as seen in 547 [kʰukʰu], the sound a small bird makes in 544, [twitwi], and the owl call 548, [huhu].

Both the sneeze sound and pain exclamation include the sibilant /s/, which may be among these words because it can be elongated. A longer /s/ in [tsss] or [ɛntis(ss)] may also serve to represent the extent of the action. The stop consonant /t/ also conveys the idea of a sudden or abrupt action.

Another interesting thing to note about Amharic is the way you would say "achoo" in a sentence. When using [ɛntis] in a sentence, such as to say that someone sneezed, you would say:

566. [ɛntis: alɛtʃ]
achoo she said
She said "achoo"

Different languages can have different representations of this construction, and based on this example Amharic appears to be a "quoted" system, where the doer of the action plays an active role in the action. Another fun demonstration of sound symbolism at work is in the verb for cooking something "until it pops" which is the word [mantɛk'atɛk']; those ejectives are a symbolic way of representing that idea of popping, bobbling, boiling food. The word itself gives an idea of the action you are expecting from the food!

<u>Tone</u>

Tone also plays a role in sound symbolism in Amharic. When expressing the size of a noun, such as dog, the tone of the word can change the impression. Higher tones indicate something smaller whereas lower tones indicate larger things.

567. Dog	[wɪ.ʃa͡ʊ.]	570. Kitty	[.dɪ.mɛ.tʷa.]
568. Big dog	[.wɪ.ʃa͡ʊ.] ↓	571. Big cat	[.dɪ.mɛ.tʉ.] ↓
569. Doggy	[.wɪ.ʃa͡ʊ.itʰ.]	572. Drop	[.t'a.ba͡tʃˇ.]

573. Droplet [.t’a.ba:t͡ʃ”.] ˥

For example, “dog” is [wɪ.ʃa͡ʊ.], but if you wanted to say that it was a big dog it would be said in a lower tone, [.wɪ.ʃa͡ʊ.] ˩. The diminutive for something smaller attaches [-it^{h}] to the end of the word, such as example X with doggy above. [i] is a vowel that has a higher frequency, which is another way of representing a higher tone. Compare as well X. “kitty” with X. “big cat”, the main difference between these two words is the final vowel. For “big cat” is ends with [ʉ] and is said in a lower tone. Both the vowel shift and lower tone carry meaning about the larger size of the animal.

Reading vs Speaking Amharic- Stephanie Konadu-Acheampong

To compare how Amharic sounds when read vs when spoken I elicited the Aesop fable *The North Wind and the Sun.* Our speaker read the following excerpt:

Figure 38:

ፀሐይና ከሰሜን በኩል የሚነፍሰው ነፋስ

ፀሐይና ከሰሜን በኩል የሚነፍሰው ነፋስ አኔ ነኝ ጠንካራ አኔ ነኝ ጠነካራ በሚል ይከራከሩ ነበር። በዚህ ጊዜ አንድ መንገደኛ የብርድ መከላከያ ልብስ ለብሶ ይጓዝ ነበር። ከዚያም መንገደኛው ለብርድ መከላከያ ለብሶት የሚሄደውን ልብስ ቀድሞ ያስወለቀ በጥንካሬ ይበልጣል በሚል ተስማሙ። በዚህመ መሠረትከሰሜን በኩል የሚነፍሰው ነፋሰ ባለበሌለው ጉልበት በሀይል ነፈሰ። ሆኖም ግን በሀይል በነፈሰ ቁጥር መንገደኛው የባሰውኑ በለበሰው ልብስ ይጀበን ጀመር። በመጨረሻም ከሰሜን በኩል የሚነፍሰው ነፋስ በገንዛ ፈቃድ አቀመ። ፀሐይም በተሬዋ ወጣችና ሙቀቷን ማውረድ ስትጀምር መንገደኛውምንም ሳይቀይ ወዲያውኑ የለበሰውነ ልብስ አወለቀ። በመጨረሻም ከሰሜን በኩል የሚነፍሰው ነፋስ ፀሐይ በጥንካሬ ከሱ የምትበልጥ መሆኗን ያለውድ በግድ አመነ።

Afterward, I asked Eyerus to recount the story from memory and summarize it in Amharic. In terms of speaking vs reading speed, the two accounts were fairly equal in tempo. Main differences between the two had to do with transition words and narrative structure, word correction, and different functions of reduplication.

Narrative Structure

When compared to the story, Eyerus used many more transitional words in her summary. In fact, every single sentence of her summary began with a transitional word of some sort. Eyerus starts off her summary with the word "first" as illustrated below:

574. **mɛdʒɛmɛrja** s'ɛhaɪ na... nɪfas jikʰarrakʰɛru nɛpɛr
First, sun and wind arguing were
First, the sun and the wind were arguing.

While Eyerus began her summary with this transition word, setting the stage for the rest of the narrative, this did not occur in the story. Rather, the story simply began-- no "first" necessary:

575. s'ɐhai nɑ kʰə-sɛmen bɛ-kul jɛminɛfsɑu nɛfas…
Sun and with?-south by/from that blows wind
The north wind and the sun…

In her summary, Eyerus also used transition words /kʰəˈzɐ/ and /kʰəzɑɾɛm/. The latter was used for all remaining sentences except one. This word, /kʰəˈzɐ/, translates roughly to "then" while /kʰəzɑɾɛm/ translates roughly to "and then." Likely, Eyerus used the latter construction as continuing to say the former was getting repetitive:

576.	kʰəˈzɑ	nɛˈfɑs...	nɛˈfɑsu(n) ˈ	nɛfɛsɛ	ˈnɛfɛsɛ	ˈnɛfɛsɛ,	
	Then	wind…	wind.DEF	blew	blew	blew	
	Then the wind blew and blew and blew.						
577.	kʰəzɑɾɛm	mu	s'ɐhɐi	ˈmɛtˈɑˈɡʰɪnɐ	muk'ɛswɐn		
	And then	?	sun	?	?		

On the other hand, in the story, there are few transitional words at all. The word /kʰɛzjɐm/--a variation on /kʰəˈzɐ/-- was only used once in the whole story.

578.	kʰɛzjɐm	meŋgɛreɲɐu...
	And then	traveler.DEF
	And then, the traveler…	

Potentially, the words /bɛzi/ and /bɛzigize/ could be transition words, but I was not able to elicit definitions of them to confirm this theory.

579.	bɛzigize	ɑnd	meŋgɛreɲɐ…			
	?	one	traveler			
580.	bɛzi	mɛsɐɾɛtʰ,	kʰɛ-sɛmin	bɛk'ul	jɛminɛfsɐu	nɛfɑs
	?	?	with?-south	by/from	that blows	wind

Word Correction

Another difference between the story and Eyerus' summary were word corrections and pauses. While reading the story, Eyerus didn't make any mistakes that required corrections and did not pause except for natural, narrative pauses like commas. In her summary, she paused to think about what parts of the story came next:

581.	mɛdʒɛmɛrja	s'ɛhaɪ	**na...**	nɪfas	jikʰarrakʰɛru	nɛpɛr	
	First,	sun	**and...**	wind	arguing	were	
	First, the sun ***and...*** *the wind were arguing.*						

Additionally, she paused to correct mistakes she made while she was recounting it. For example, Eyerus forgot to make definite the word for "wind" and corrected that mistake as seen here:

582. kʰəˈzɑ **nɛˈfɑs...** **nɛˈfɑsu(n)** ˈnɛfɛsɛ ˈnɛfɛsɛ ˈnɛfɛsɛ

Then **wind…** **wind.DEF** blew, blew, blew

*Then **wind… the wind** blew and blew and blew*

Reduplication

. One last thing that differed between the two story accounts were the functions of reduplication in each. In the story was a really interesting use of reduplication that helped further the narrative structure. The reduplication simulates the wind and the sun arguing by saying "I am stronger," "I am stronger":

583. ፀሐይና ከሰሜን በኩል የሚነፍሰው ነፋስ አኒ ነኝ ጠንካራ አኒ ነኝ ጠነካራ በሚል ይከራከሩ ነበር።

s'ɐhai	nɑ	kʰə-sɛmen	bɛ-kul	jiminɛfsɑu	nɛfas
sun	and	has-south	from which	that blows	wind
ɛne	**nent'ɛnkʰɐrɐ**	**ɛne**	**nent'ɛnkʰɐrɐ**	bɛmil	
I	am stronger	I	am stronger	than	
jikʰɐrɐkʰəru	nɛpɛɾ				
argue.3rd.pl.impf	was/past				

The sun and the wind that blew from the north used to argue: **"I'm stronger", "I'm stronger** [than you]."*

This reduplication verges on onomatopoeic as you can imagine the two parties' back and forth and overlapping competitive statements. This form of reduplication also seems extremely stylized and I could imagine that its use would be restricted to fables, poems, and similar mediums as a result.

On the other hand, the form of reduplication that Eyerus used in her summary of the story was different. She didn't describe the back and forth between the sun and the wind-- she simply stated that they were arguing. Instead, she stresses the wind's efforts to blow the coat off of the traveler by repeating the verb for "blew":

584. kʰəˈzɑ nɛˈfɑs... nɛˈfɑsu(n) ˈ **nɛfɛsɛ** ˈ**nɛfɛsɛ** ˈ**nɛfɛsɛ**,

Then wind… wind.DEF blew blew blew

*Then the wind **blew and blew and blew**.*

As seen above, when describing the wind's actions in attempting to blow the traveler's coat off of him, she uses reduplication with an augmentative function.

Numbers- Melia Gelinas and Thomas Sasdi

The most basic and simple forms of standard numbers are as follows below. There are unique forms for zero through nine, as well as each factor of ten, such as ten, twenty, thirty, forty, etc. yet you can still see the similarities with their singular digit counterparts, quite similar to English construction of “three” versus “thirty” or “seven” to “seventy” there is an essence of the root forms of 1-9 even as you go beyond. Typologically, these numbers follow the decimal system which is the most common type of numeral system.

585. 0 [zeɾo]
586. 1 [ɑnd]
587. 2 [hulɛtʰ]
588. 3 [sostʰ]
589. 4 [aɾatʰ]
590. 5 [ɑmˈɪstʰ]
591. 6 [sɪ.ˈdɪstʰ]
592. 7 [sabɑtʰ]
593. 8 [sɪmɪntʰ]
594. 9 [zɛtaɪn]
595. 10 [ˈa.sɛɾ]
596. 20 [haɪja]
597. 30 [sɛlasa]
598. 40 [aɾba]
599. 50 [hamsa]
600. 60 [sɪlsa]
601. 70 [saba]
602. 80 [samaŋa]
603. 90 [zɛtˈɛnɑ]
604. 100 [mɛto]
605. 1,000 [ˈɑndəʃi] / [ʃi] casually
606. 10,000 [asɪɾʃi]
607. 100,000 [mɛtʰoʃi]

The decimal system uses the defined 1-9 numbers to build just about every number that follows, without changing much in terms of new unique forms. These numbers provide the building blocks for more complex constructions, as you’ll see below. The following section will go into more detail towards the ways these numbers combine with one another to create others.

Complex Numbers:

Large numbers are built with a place system that is very similar to the one used in English, descending from thousands to hundreds, then tens and units, as seen in examples 608-617:

608. [asrə-ɑnd]
ten-one
11

609. [asrɑ-ulɛt]
ten-two
12

610. [haɪja-sɪmɪntʰ]
twenty-eight
28

611. [mɛto-ɑnd]
hundred-one
101

612. [hulɛtʰ-mɛtʰo arb-arɑtʰ]
two-hundred forty-four
244

613. [sostʰ-mɛtʰo asra-ulɛtʰ]
three-hundred ten-two
312

614. [arɑtʰ-mɛtʰo]
four-hundred
400

615. [amɪstʰ-mɛtʰo sɪmɪntʰ]
five-hundred eight
508

616. [hulɛtʰ-ʃi]
two-thousand
2000

617. [sostʰʃi and-metʰo asra-sɪdɪstʰ]
three-thousand one-hundred ten-six
3116

It is interesting to see how numbers shift from their basic forms when joined with one another, like 11, 12, and 16 (in example 617 in 3116). The underlying forms of these numbers are /a.sɛɾ ɑnd/ for 11, /a.sɛɾ hulɛtʰ/ for 12, and /a.sɛɾ sɪdɪstʰ/ for 16, but when spoken they are realized as [asrəɑnd], [asrɑulɛt] and [asra-sɪdɪstʰ] respectively. I believe this is an example of metathesis, which is a phonological occurrence where there is a reversal between two sounds. If this is the case, what is occurring here is that the tap at the end of the word for 10 seems to be switching locations so that it is occurring immediately after the /s/, and then the vowel gets assimilated depending on the environment of the following number. Metathesis is less typologically common, so another possibility of what's happening here is the deletion of the vowel between /s/ and /ɾ/. However, the reason that I'm leaning more towards metathesis is because of the vowel change in 11 from /a.sɛɾ ɑnd/ to [asrəɑnd]. If the vowel was just being deleted I would expect to see something more like [asrɑnd], but instead we still see evidence of a second vowel in the construction, which leads me to believe that the vowel is still there but it's form might be changing, due to its position next to the tap switching sides.

Numbers Modifying Nouns:

618. [ɑnd nɛʧ' dɪm:ɛtʰ]
1 white cat
1 white cat

619. [hulɛtʰ nɛʧ' dɪmɛt'.oʧʰ]
2 white cat.PL
2 white cats

620. [sostʰ tɪdlɪk' dɪm:ɛt'.oʧʰ]
3 big cat.PL
3 big cats

621. [ˈa.sɛɾ gɪbɪɾɑ nɛʤ' dɪm:ɛt'oʧʰ]
10 big white cat.PL
10 big white cats

Numbers occur before both the adjective and noun that they modify within simple phrases, and remain in their standard form.

Ordinal Numerals

In Amharic ordinal numerals are formed by combining the basic form of the numbers with the suffix [-aɪɲa]. According to Eyerus this construction is very regular, and can be applied to any number, even up to the triple digits (and beyond).

622. first	[ɑndãɲa]	625. fourth	[aratãɲa]
623. second	[hulɛtãɲa]	626. twentieth	[haɪãɲa]
624. third	[sostãɲa]	627. fortieth	[arbãɲa]

Listing Numbers

When reading a list of numbers, each number is spoken individually regardless of how the numbers may be grouped.

628. sabatʰ aɾatʰ and zeɾo amɪstʰ amɪstʰ zɛt'ɛjn hulɛtʰ zeɾo zeɾo aɾatʰ zeɾo sɪmɪntʰ sostʰ
seven four one zero five five nine seven zero zero four zero eight three
74105592004083

629. sostʰ and huletʰ sabatʰ sabatʰ sabatʰ simɪntʰ amistʰ and zɛt'ɛjn sɪdɪstʰ aɾatʰ
three one two seven seven seven eight five one nine six four
312 777 851 964

One exception to this is when providing phone numbers, in which case it is possible to read groups of numbers in a manner equivalent to providing their numerical value, such as in 630

630. amɪst^{h}-mɛt^{h}o sɪmɪnt^{h} hulɛt^{h} arb-aɾat^{h} hulɛt^{h} samaɲ-amɪst^{h} sabat^{h}
five-hundred eight two forty-four two eighty-five seven
508 244 2857

When two numbers in a group are separated by a zero, then it is preferable to read the group as if it were numerical rather than in chunks. However other groups can be broken down, and it appears that there is a pattern where the first number is always read on its own, followed by the next two numbers as numerical value (two forty-four for 244), and then the final number on it's own if it is a four digit number (two eighty-five seven for 2857.)

The other exception we know about is for providing years, which is discussed in the following Dates and Time Section.

Dates and Time in Amharic- Stephanie Konadu-Acheampong, Thomas Sasdi, Ethan Shaw

The Ethiopian Calendar Year

The Ethiopian calendar is a solar calendar that has roots in the Egyptian or Coptic Calendar as well as the Julian calendar-- a predecessor of the Western Gregorian calendar. The calendar has liturgical purposes, having ties with the Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church, but is also just generally used in Ethiopia today. There are thirteen months total in the calendar as listed in order below:

1. [mɛskʰɛrɛm]
2. [t’ɪk’ɪmtʰ]
3. [hɪdɑr]
4. [tʰɑˈhɑːsɑs]
5. [t’ɪr]
6. [jɛkʰɑtʰɪtʰ]
7. [mɛˈjɑzɑ]
8. [gɪnboːtʰ]
9. [sɐne]
10. [ˈhɑmle]
11. [nɑhɑːsɑs]
12. [mɛgɑːbitʰ]
13. [p’ɑgume]

Each month in the calendar has 30 days, save for the last month which has 5 or 6 depending on the year.

631. [mɛskʰɛrɛm sɛlɑsɑ k’ɛnuʧʰ ɐlɛu]
[mɛskʰɛrɛm] thirty day.PL has
[mɛskʰɛrɛm] has 30 days.*

*you could replace any of the other months of the year with this one to get the same message across.

632. [p'ɑgume ɑmɪstʰ wejɪm sɪdɪstʰ k’ɛnuʧʰ ɑlɛu]
[p'agume] five or six day.PL has
[p'agume] has five or six days.

In this way, the last month of the year functions similarly to February and its leap day. The first month of the Ethiopian calendar year begins on September 11th or September 12th in the Gregorian calendar, depending on if it is a leap year or not; Ethiopians typically celebrate new years during this time.

Additionally, the Ethiopian calendar is around 7-8 years behind the Gregorian calendar. As such, it is currently 2013 in Ethiopia today. This is due to differences in the estimation of the annunciation of Christ between the Gregorian and Ethiopian calendars, of which both calendars are based. The date of our Field Methods presentation was Saturday, May 8, 2021 in the Gregorian calendar, but was [mɛˈjɑzɑ] 30th, 2013 in the Ethiopian calendar.

Years are said much like they are in English, either as the equivalent to the year's numeric value, such as in example 633, or as two individual groups of numbers, as in example 634.

633. hulɛtʰ-ʃi asra-sostʰ
two-thousand ten-three
2013

634. asra-zɛtʼɛɲ zɛtʼɛna-sostʰ
ten-nine ninety-three
1993

Days of the Week

In Amharic, there are seven days of the week as follows:

1. Monday: [saɪ͡ŋo]
2. Tuesday: [mɑkʰsɐŋo]
3. Wednesday: [ɛrob]
4. Thursday: [hɑmus]
5. Friday: [ɐrb]
6. Saturday: [kˈədɐmi]
7. Sunday: [əhud]

While we know the names of each day of the week, we were not able to garner information about their significance or if they also have any liturgical importance or roots.

Telling Time

Telling time in Amharic is fairly simple. To do so, first list the number of the hour (e.g ɑsrɑ͡ulɛt -- *twelve*). Then, attach suffix /kʰə/ or /kʰ/ to the number of minutes that have passed in the hour. For example,

635. ɑsrɑ͡ulɛt kʰə-ʔɑmɪstʰ
twelve has-five
12:05

The prefix /kʰə/ has a possessive-like function where it denotes that the hour has a certain number of minutes. This strategy can be used for any other times of day as well. For example:

636. ɑnd kʰə-ʔɑrɑtʰ
one has-four
1:04

637. ɑsrɑ͡ulɛt kʰə-rub
twelve has-quarter
12:15

638. sostʰ kʰə sɛlɑsɑ
three has thirty
3:30

The one exception to this is when it is exactly the hour. In this case, the number can be followed by the word [saʔat] “time” or “hour.”

639. ɑsrɑ͡ulɛt saʔat
twelve hour
12:00

A reverse construction can be used to indicate time until the hour:

640. gɪmːaʃ kʰ-asɾaulɛtʰ
half has-twelve
half to twelve (11:30)

AM/PM Specification

When asked if there is a way to differentiate AM from PM times in Amharic, our speaker noted that everyone knows whether a given time falls during the day or during the night. This is because the Amharic day begins at 8 AM rather than at midnight. As such, 8 AM is hour 0, 9 AM is hour 1, and noon is hour 4, etc. As such, AM and PM specifications are largely unnecessary, but if someone did want to emphasize that a time fell during the day rather than at night, they could specify by saying the following:

641.	jɛ-k'ɛn	ɑnd	kʰ-ɑrɑtʰ
	POSS-day	one	has-four
	1:04 PM		

This phrase roughly translates to: "the day's one has four," and communicates that the one belongs to the day (rather than to the night). On the other hand, if you wanted to say that it was 1:04 AM (at night), then you could swap out day for night and say the following:

642.	jɛ-mɑtʰɑ	ɑnd	kʰ-ɑrɑtʰ
	POSS-night	one	has-four
	1:04 AM		

There are no words for noon or midnight, however there is a word [tʰakʰul] that can be used in place of [saʔatʰ] specifically for 12:00, and translates to something similar to "o'clock" (X). Then if someone wanted to specify between 12 during the day or 12 during the night they could add the respective word for determining day or night. I'm not entirely sure why there are no specific words for noon or midnight, however it may have to do with the fact that, as mentioned above, the Amharic day begins at 8:00. Thus, what would be noon or midnight outside of Ethiopia would simply be 4:00 in Ethiopia. It is then likely that specific words for important times of day would be centered more around dawn and dusk, rather than high-noon.

643. [ɑsrɑ͡ulɛt tʰakʰul]

twelve o'clock
12:00

Although there is no commonly used word for midnight, there is an emphatic expression [bɛtʃʾɛlɛma mɪdɪr] that can be used to indicate a general time late in the night, translating to something similar to "when the earth is all dark." This phrase can be used in an emphatic manner to express a time very late at night when everyone would ideally be asleep, much like the expression "middle of the night" can be used in English.

644. [bɛ-tʃʾɛlɛma mɪdɪr]
by-dark earth
Middle of the night

The word [mɪdɪr] meaning "earth" can be used in other phrases as well to provide as a sense of shocked emphasis.

Mealtimes

There seem to be four main, daily meals that take place and subsequently have names in Amharic. They are as follows:

- k'urs -- breakfast
- mɪsɑ -- lunch
- mɛk^{h}sɛs -- a late lunch
- ɛrat^{h} -- dinner

Eyerus mentioned that rather than referring to times of day (e.g. noon, etc), people would instead refer to the closest mealtime. Additionally, if you would like to call someone to breakfast, you could say the following:

645. k'urs derswɑl
breakfast has arrived
It's breakfast time.

Using this construction, you can swap out [k'urs] with any mealtime in this phrase to signify that it's time to eat.

Duration

We heard a couple sentences that featured descriptions of how long an action occurs. Eyerus would add the dative marker /lɛ/ to a measure of time to express "for *x* amount of time."

646. lɛ ɐmɪst tɛk'ɐ
DAT. five minutes
For five minutes

647. nɛgɛ lɛ ɐsɪɾ sɐʔɐtʰ sɛɾo ɛk'ojɐlɐʊ
Tomorrow DAT. ten hour work stay.1p.sg.IMPERF.
I'll spend ten hours at work tomorrow.

As the second example demonstrates, there doesn't appear to be a valency-changing operation that would promote "ten hours" to a patient, but remains part of the dative construction.

Language Ideologies- Anni Clark

Ethiopia is home to over 80 indigenous languages, many of which have a large community of speakers. Amharic is the lingua franca for much of the country, particularly urban areas, and is most commonly the second language for its speakers outside of the Amhara ethnic group. The languages with the second and third largest speaker base are Orominya and Tigrinya, respectively. Guraginya and Somali are also commonly spoken languages. These three languages are not mutually intelligible, but multilingualism between them is common. In fact, in cities multilingualism is more common than monolingualism and one might hear any number of languages on a daily basis. While Amharic might be the language easiest to use on the street or in the store, it is certainly not an overwhelming primary language.

The most widespread presentation of a prestige language ideology comes from the fact of Amharic as the most common language of instruction in Ethiopian schools. This leads to its perception as a more sophisticated language and its speakers more highly educated. In turn, this breeds feelings of illegitimacy among speakers of other languages who are made to learn Amharic in school. There is, however, a rural-urban divide among language instruction in schools. In many urban schools, like the one Eyerus went to, there will be second language classes. However, the languages chosen for these classes are almost never other Ethiopian languages, and they focus instead on languages like English, French, or Arabic. Rural schools, on the other hand, are much more likely to teach, or instruct in, Ethiopian languages other than Amharic. This, of course, nurtures and feeds a pride in one's own ethnic language and makes education more accessible to those whose families might not speak Amharic at home. The problem here then becomes that rural areas often do not have many schools or enough resources to seat all school-aged children in the area. These educational access issues then mean that children either do not go to school or may be sent to a city where they will do school taught in Amharic. Either way, these children may then internalize the notion that their ethnic language is not good enough to be taught in school, and that Amharic is superior.

Issues of language prestige are not linear or sweeping across Ethiopia. Cross-linguistically, prestige connotations between languages come about from historical tensions between groups of speakers. This holds true among Ethiopian languages but due to the large number of ethnic languages, these tensions might exist in some regions of the country and not others. Thus, prestige among languages often remains a more localized issue than national.

However, in such cases when these conversations do come up, people use the phrase [jɐwɛf kwɐŋkwɐ] “language of the birds” to demean another language. This equation of language to animalistic communication feeds into the educational infrastructure issues that imply some languages are more scholarly than others. In the end, we see a cooperation between educational access issues and a desire for a national language creating prestige behind a single language and laying the groundwork for the denigration of others.

Tongue Twisters- Maggie Kohl, Hannah Staats

We asked our consultant to repeat some tongue-twisters that she has learned or heard of in her native language. She gave the two examples as follows:

648.	aβɛβɛ	βeso	βɛla
	[name]	breakfast	eat.3rd.PST
	John Doe ate breakfast.		

The phrase "John Doe ate breakfast" contains repetitions of the marked /β/ sound in rapid succession. In Amharic the /β/ sound is an allophone of /b/. Therefore it is less common than the plosive /b/. The bilabial fricative is marked in Amharic thus a phrase like example (649) would rarely occur in regular speech.

649.	tʃʾala	tʃʾubɛ	tʃʾɛbɛta
	[Name]	pocket knife	hold.3rd.PST
	Tʃʾala held the pocket knife.		

The phrase "tʃʾala held the pocket knife" contains multiple repetitions of word-initial ejective /tʃʾ/ sounds. This phrase is seen as a "tongue-twister", because the ejective /tʃʾ/ sound is marked in Amharic and cross-linguistically. It requires more effort than normal speech due to the mouth tensing and the breath being pushed out.

The consultant later remembered another tongue twister, shown in (650). She mentioned that it includes some less common words, some of which are like onomatopoeia. A gloss is shown in (651-652).

650. [ɾasɛɲ bɛɾase afɛɲ bɛmalase kʰalakʾolapʾapʾɛskut man jɪkʾolapʾapʾɛsɪlɛɲal]
Loose translation: 'If I don't hype myself up, who will?'

651.	ɾas-ɛɲ	bɛ-ɾas-e	af-ɛɲ	bɛ-malas-e
	head-1S.POSS	with-head-1S.POSS	mouth-1S.POSS	with-tongue-1S.POSS
	'me by myself and my mouth with my tongue'			

652. kʰ-al-a-k’olap’ap’ɛs-kut man jɪ-k’onap’ap’ɛs-ɪl-ɛɲ-al
with-NEG-1S.SBJ-hype-3S.M.OBJ who 3S.M.SBJ.IMPERF-hype-?-1S.OBJ-FUT.3S
‘if I don't hype myself up, who will hype me up?’

The consultant said she considered this tongue twister to be tricky for several reasons, including its length and the repetition between the verbs *kʰalakʰolap’ap’ɛskut* and *jɪk’onap’ap’ɛsɪlɛɲal*. There may also be some reduplication within both instances of the verb ‘hype:’ [ap’ap’]. It is likely that these verbs are even more morphologically complex than what is glossed here. For example, it is unclear what [-ɪl], which is absent from the first verb, conveys in *jɪk’onap’ap’ɛsɪlɛɲal*. One difference that is not accounted for between the two verbs is the interrogative nature of the second verb, so it is possible [-ɪl] contributes to this meaning. There is also an alternation between [l] to [n] in the verbs. It is possible the [n] in *jɪk’onap’ap’ɛsɪlɛɲal* is assimilating to the [n] in the preceding *man*.

The consultant also shared the Amharic name for tongue twisters, or ‘mouth-mixers,’ shown in (653).

653. [af ɪmjɛntʰabatʰɪb]
af ɪmjɛn-tʰabatʰɪb
mouth what-mix
‘tongue-twister’
literally: ‘mouth-mixer’ or ‘what mixes up a mouth’

Reported Speech - Lily Jenssen

Reported Speech in Amharic is interesting in that it's similar to English in that the speech being reported takes no special form simply due to it being reported. For instance, if you removed the '[person] said' the sentence would still work. It would make sense for there to be a kind of complementizer attached, for example 'and' but there wasn't. Either way it was still cool.

654. [ɛmmalak'aw sɛwije t'ɛftʰɛ-ʃal all-eɲ]
stranger lost-2SG.F IMPV- 1SG.SUBJ
[ɛmmalak'aw sɛwije t'æftʰɛ-hal all-eɲ]
stranger lost-2SG.M IMPV- 1SG.SUBJ
'The stranger asked me, 'Are you lost'?'

655. [spʰaniʃ-eɲa mawuratʰ tʰɪtʃʰɛlal-lɛw all-ɛtʃʰ]
Spanish-3SG.F to talk could-IMPV-3SG.SUBJ IMPV-3SG.F
'She said that she could speak Spanish'

656. [tʰamrɛjallɛ-ʃ al-lɛtʃʰ-ɪŋ]
say-3SG.F IMPV-3SG.SBJ-ACC
'She said I looked good'

657. [ɪnnatʰatʃʰ-ɪn ɛ-nmɛsal-lɛn al-lun]
3PL- -ACC look-IMPV-1PL.SUBJ IMPV-3PL.SUBJ
'They said we looked like our mom'

658. [ɛ-wɛdɪʃal-lɛw al-lɛtʃʰ jɛ seitʰ gwadɛɲawa]
love-1PFV-1SG.SUBJ IMPV-3SG.SUBJ of her girlfriend
'I love you, said her girlfriend'

Jokes and Humor- Daphne Iskos

According to Eyerus, Amharic humor largely relies on sarcasm and irony, with the most common types of jokes being short situational quips woven into conversation, or longer-form narrative style jokes ending with a twist and punchline. In Amharic, these jokes are known as ['jɐɾɐdɐ 'k'wan'k'wa]. A ['jɐɾɐdɐ] is a sly, usually younger, person who likes to mess with others. ['k'wan'k'wa] means language. Despite the association of a ['jɐɾɐdɐ] being a younger person, it seems that this style of joke is more popular amongst older generations. Eyerus relayed one such joke, and her English translation (edited slightly for clarity) can be found below:

> "There was a guy in a taxi and he called somebody that had apparently sat next to him in the taxi, and he said 'I think you forgot $50,000, do you want me to return it to you?'. And the person [on the other end of the line] was like 'oh, I don't think that belongs to me!' so then the guy calling said 'oh! okay, I'll just ask the other person who was sitting next to me', and upon saying that the person on the phone was like 'oh, wait! Actually, I think I did lose $50,000!'. So then the guy calling was like, 'Okay, I'll meet you at this place to return it.' So the person he was on the phone with went to the meeting place and called the guy, saying: "I'm here, where are you?". And the guy responded, 'Oh, actually I'm at mikail'. Mikail is like...the name of a church. And so the caller says 'actually I'm over there, so could you meet me here instead?'. So the other person went [to Mikail] and then called him again, asking,"Okay, I'm here. Where are you?" And he's like, "okay, good. Now that you're there, go pray and ask God to forgive you for lying."

I decided not to transcribe and gloss the original Amharic joke simply because there is no special linguistic format or syntactic structure utilized in the telling of ['jɐɾɐdɐ 'k'wan'k'wa]. However, anyone interested in experiencing Eyerus' full rendition of the original joke in Amharic can click here to hear the audio from the elicitation session.

Eyerus also gave a great example of the brand of situational humor that is commonly incorporated in Amharic conversations, retelling an episode from her mother's youth:

> "My mom was telling me about what she and her friends would do when they were younger, when there was an older person that was nagging them. They'd basically pretend like the nagging was music. And she [Eyerus' mom] said that anytime the person stopped

nagging, they'd be like 'oh, what happened to the music? Could you please turn it back on!' Or like, 'did the record break?' or things like that."

Slang- Vivian Bauer

Similarly to jokes in Amharic, everyday slang words also are highly dependent on tone and context. For example, the second person singular pronoun can be said with an upspeak tone at the end and with higher pitch to disrespect another person. Our consultant talked about how she will use this sometimes to make fun of her sister and never use it around her mom or older respected people. Another slang word that is very present in our consultants family is /'weɪ͡gu:d/ which is used in everyday conversation to either mock someone or express shock. The tone is similar to /ɐn'ʧi/ where there is a higher pitch and upspeak at the end and the meaning of the word is highly dependent on the context.

659. ɐn'ʧi
[2SG.F]
you (with disrespect)

660. 'weɪ͡gu:d
[my god]
Oh my goodness!

Below are two other common everyday expressions that Eyerus used primarily with her sister or other people her age.

661. mɪndɪ'no͡u ʧɪgɪɾ-ɪʃ
[what problem-2.SG.F]
what's your problem

662. ɛhe͡ɪ nɐgɐr βɪnɐgr-ɪʃ ɐtʰɐmiɲəm
[1.SG what.thing tell.PROG-2SG.F believe.2.SG]
You are not gonna believe what I'm aboutta tell you!

Memes- Anni Clark

Internet humor and memes are popular among Amharic speakers, and are particularly important for the Amharic-speaking diaspora around the world. For this community, the sharing of memes constitutes a touchstone that connects them to each other and to their culture. Memes generally come in the format of video compilations wherein clips on serious topics are interrupted by people laughing or dancing to make the serious discussion seem ironic. The jokes work best on video because, as we have seen, irony and situational humor play important roles in Amharic jokes. This carries onto memes, which are often contingent on understanding a specific historical or cultural reference. Amharic memes are dynamic and not just a simple joke. Eyerus described one popular meme includes a video of someone dancing then cuts to laughter and another person repeating [weɪ͡zɛn dəɾo], meaning "oh this era" to make the audience laugh about what silly things people are doing these days. Because of the dynamism of Amharic memes, they will often borrow meme formats or pieces of unrelated jokes but put their own spin on them. Much of this spin comes in the form of cultural reference, whether that be large scale events or those specific to where the person grew up. Despite this use of the hyper-specific, there will also be frequent overlap within memes between Amharic, Orominya and Tigrinya which further establishes a strong and unified Ethiopian humor.

In the context of the diaspora, memes and internet humor are important for cultivating and maintaining a sense of unity and closeness across great distances. Eyerus describes the prevalence of Snapchat accounts called boonaa (coffee) time which shared Amharic-language memes largely for an audience largely in Europe, the United States, and Australia. The memes on these accounts usually look different than those made by people inside of Ethiopia are, because these accounts are often run by second generation immigrants. Because they grew up in different places, they cannot rely on specific cultural references and might not know exact details of historical events that some memes might joke about. Eyerus says that she sometimes has to ask her mom to explain the joke behind the memes she sees online. Thus, meme-makers in the diaspora have to find new things to joke about and often land on their parents. Because many Ethiopian parents are very strict, people will make jokes about their parents and turn them into memes. Eyerus described one popular video:

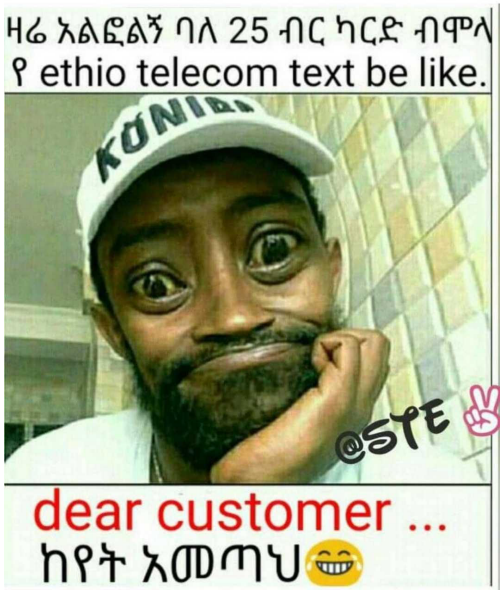
> "Somebody got a piercing and they filmed surprising their mom about the piercing. The mom had the most dramatic reaction. She literally fell on the ground

with her hand on her forehead and just collapsed and acted like it was the worst thing ever. And yeah they just make fun of their parents. Pranking their parents I think is the go-to humor."

Here are two examples of Amharic memes. The first one shows Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed and it says "When Abichoo gets bored at the government house." The suffix -choo is used to indicate endearment, so here we see not only mocking the hobbies of the Prime Minister, but also the irony of speaking about him like a casual friend. The second meme says "when things work out for me and I buy a $25 card (a phone card used to make texts and calls overseas) the ethio telecom text be like, dear customer...where did you get this money?" With this, we see the use of an English-language meme format, and even the retention of some English, but made to be distinctively Ethiopian.

Figure 39:





Nicknames- Pat Vaidos and Daphne Iskos

Nicknames in Amharic have several morphological components involved in their construction. Generic construction of nicknames involve adding a [-jɛi] suffix to the end of someone's name, similar to [-i] being suffixed to shorter names in English. The [-jɛi] makes the name possessive, changing it to "my Eyerus." Many names call for an additional [ɪ] before the [-jɛi], except if the original name already ends with [-jɛi].

For example, Eyerus' nickname in Amharic is as follows:

663. ejerʊsi-jɛi
Eyerus -1SG.POSS

Nicknames for family members, specifically parents, are used as terms of endearment. Eyerus mentioned that the nickname for her mother and several other mothers is [ɐβɐˈbɐ], which translated to "flower" in Amharic. For siblings, on the other hand, nicknames tend to be more playful, hinting towards Amharic humor's proclivity to sarcasm and irony in the way that nicknames are chosen for specific people. Nicknames for siblings that are intended to be humorous play off of whatever quality that person has, and gives them an ironic nickname. Eyerus gave the example of the word "baby" [be͡ibi], an English loan word, being used to describe someone who is actually mature, to play on that idea with irony.

Eyerus also brought up the term [ˈɐbi] which her family used for her brother. The term is used to refer to "a male child running around in the neighborhood and you didn't know his name, you'd refer to him as [ˈɐbi]."

Certain nicknames can also take on a jokingly derogatory nuance, as with ['dɛɸɐr]. Eyerus described a ['dɛɸɐr] as "someone who's very brave." She went on to explain that you would say it to confront someone who is "trying to be sly with you and get their way". For example, if a friend pretended to forget their wallet so in an attempt to get you to pay for their lunch, you could say "do you know what this 'dɛɸɐr did to me?" (to someone else) or "you're such a 'dɛɸɐr!" (directly to the friend). Also, when calling someone a ['dɛɸɐr] to their face, the tone used is important:

664. H L
['dɛ ɸɐr]
"brave person" (make sure to drag out the ɸɐr!)

665. L H H L
['ɐnʧi 'dɛ ɸɐr]
"you brave person"

Terms of Endearment- Daphne Iskos, Hannah Kusserow

Terms of endearment come in many shapes and sizes in Amharic. One interesting category is English words that have been repurposed. As mentioned previously in the nicknames section, ['be͡ibi] ("baby") can be used in an ironic sense. However, it can also be used as it is in English, as an unironic term of endearment for a feminine or masculine partner. Another nickname taken from English is [ʧikʰ], which came from the English word "chick". People use [ʧikʰ] as a form of endearment for a feminine partner, akin to how people can directly call their partner "babe" in English. Interestingly, while someone might call their girlfriend their "chick" to someone else, no one would use it as a term of endearment directly to the girlfriend in question, so clearly the word changed semantically when it travelled into Amharic.

Certain terms of endearment can also be used amongst friends. For instance, young men often refer to each other as ['sɐnʧo], a word that translates to "macho". ['sɐnʧo] is used directly to someone's face, so an English equivalent of its usage would be something along the lines of: "Hey, Macho!" It is possible that this word is also usable as an adjective (though probably in a different context), but unfortunately we do not have concrete data to support this theory. Future research could seek to investigate this possibility, and referential terms between younger Amharic speakers in general. However, as great as ['be͡ibi] and [ʧikʰ], ['sɐnʧo] are, these words very much reside in the vernacular of younger generations of Amharic speakers.

Older speakers would not use these Amharic-ified English terms of endearment, and instead opt for more traditional words. A typical term of endearment heard in older circles used towards individuals of any gender is ['wɪdei], which translates to "my dear beloved". ['ɪməbeitʰei] also falls into this category. Eyerus wasn't able to give a direct translation for this word, but she was able to elaborate that it has a "higher up, almost holy" connotation associated with divine femininity. It is used exclusively on female partners.

Besides nicknames, Amharic also uses various animal nicknames to describe a person's character. This ranges from terms of endearment to insult. For example, young children are often greeted or referred to as monkeys, as seen in the phrase book examples 4-5. While generally endearing and cheeky, referring to someone as a monkey, [tʰotʰɐ], implies that they are sly and mischievous. Another less flattering example can be seen in calling a person a donkey, [aheya], which, as in many languages, is to call a person stupid.

Loanwords- Maggie Kohl

Loanwords in Amharic mainly come from technology, transportation, education, and other miscellaneous categories that originated from western cultures. These words were passed onto the Amharic language through interactions with different languages and cultures mainly through migration, colonialism, and increasing technology and media presence. Loanwords in Amharic usually contain phonemes that are slightly different from how they are pronounced in the languages they originate from. Our Amharic consultant would substitute vowels and consonants in loanwords with sounds that are more common in Amharic. For example, “nurse” is pronounced ners. “Veranda” is pronounced as bɛɾɛnda. The /v/ sound is changed to a /b/ sound most likely, because the word-initial /b/ is more common than a word-initial /v/.

Some transportation related loanwords are as follows:

Taxi	taksi
Truck	tɾak
Airplane	eɾoplan
Pilot	paɪ͡lotʰ
Bus	bas
Bicycle	biskʰəlɛtʰ
Passport	pʰasportʰ
Seatbelt	sitʰbeltʰ

Some technology related loanwords are as follows:

Television	televɪʃˁn
Laptop	laptop
Facebook	feɪ͡sbuk
Viber	vaɪ͡ver
Twitter	tʰwitʰer
To like	laɪ͡kargeɪ͡ (direct translation is “I did a like”)

Some education-related loanwords are as follows:

Biology	baɪ͡ʔolodʒi
Mathematics	matematiks
Negative	negativ
Positive	posetiv

Some miscellaneous loanwords are as follows:

Veranda	bɛɾɛnda
Pasta	pʰasta
Box/carton	kartʰun
Police officer	pʰolis
Nurse	ners
Oven	oven
Ice	a͡ɪs
Mushroom	mʌʃrum
Snack	sᵊnak
Sports	spʰortʰ
Apple	apʰɛl
Purple	perpɛl
Kangaroo	kʰaŋgaɾo
Kazoo	kəzu
Cowboy	ka͡ʊbo͡ɪ
Piano	piano͡ʊ
Baseball	be͡ɪsbol
Lacrosse	lacros

It is interesting to note that the two most common sports among Amharic speakers are soccer and running. These two words are not loanwords, because they are more common than other sports from around the world. Soccer has two translations, one that is a loanword from the european culture and the other which originates in Amharic. The two translations are shown below.

Running	ruts’a
Soccer	ɛgerkwas or futbol

Ge'ez- Ethan Shaw

Ge'ez is the classical language that preceded Amharic in Ethiopia. Also a Semitic language, it branched out into Amharic and the further-north Tigrinya. Until a time unknown to our consultant, Ge'ez was a spoken language, but persisted in literature for even longer. Nowadays, it occupies a similar linguistic niche as Coptic does for Egyptian Orthodox Christians, namely that of a liturgical language. Therefore, as Eyerus mentioned, Ge'ez is often isolated to churches and seminaries, or [jɛk'ɛnetʰ tʰɪmɪɾtʰɪbetʰ], with the latter in more rural areas.

Our consultant mentioned that some sound shifts had occurred between Ge'ez and Amharic. These included the loss of some phonemes and the simplification of words through the deletion of glottal stops, such as that which is apparent in [betʰɐʔɐ] becoming [betʰ]. She had also mentioned that Tigrinya had retained many more of the dropped sounds, including in the name [mɐʔɐzɐ], a Tigrinya woman's name. While realized by Eyerus with a glottal stop, she spoke about it in such a way that I suspect it might be a pharyngeal fricative, due to its presence in other Semitic languages.

Arabic-Amharic Cognates- Matthew Wilkinson, Ethan Shaw, Hannah Kusserow, Hannah Staats

Amharic has a wide range of words that share the same form and meaning as Arabic words. Some of these are surface borrowings from mature Arabic into mature Amharic as a result of cultural and religious contact between the Horn of Africa and the Arab world. These words tend to have restricted meanings and do not fit into Amharic derivational morphology. For example, [saˈlam], the Arabic word for 'Peace,' is used as a greeting in both languages and pronounced the same way. However, no other words exist in Amharic that come from the same root, which in Arabic is [s, l, m]. As opposed to surface borrowings, Figure 40 lists some examples of true historical cognates inherited from Proto-Semitic into both Arabic and Amharic. These words tend to be versatile in Amharic, with many associated words sharing the same cognate root. Others are included in this list because they belong to semantic domains that are cross-linguistically resistant to borrowing. While parallels are prevalent between the languages' pronouns, adpositions, and other function words and particles, only words with lexical meanings are included here.

Figure 40:

Amharic Transcription	English Translation	Arabic Transcription	English Translation
[be͡ɪt]	House	[be͡ɪt]	House
[suk']	Shop	[suq]	Market
[sost]	Three	[θɛlaθɛ(tʰ)[31]]	three
[ɐrɐtʰ]	Four	[arbʕa(tʰ)]	Four
[amɪst]	Five	[xamsa(tʰ)]	Five
[sɪdɪstʰ]	Six	[sitta(tʰ)], [sadis][32]	Six
[sabɑtʰ]	Seven	[sɛbʕa(tʰ)]	Seven
[sɪmɪntʰ[33]]	Eight	[ˈθmania(tʰ)]	Eight

[31] Parenthesized "T's" not always pronounced in Arabic, included for comparison
[32] Means the ordinal "sixth," but reveals shared consonantal root so I thought to include it
[33] The numerals meaning one, two, and nine do not seem to be cognate with their Arabic counterparts

[asɨr]	Ten	[ʕaʃɪra(tʰ)]	Ten
[k’ədus]	Blessed, holy	[qɑdis]	Blessed, holy
[baraka]	Blessing	[baraka]	Blessing
[nɛfs]	Spirit, ego, soul	[nɛfs]	Spirit, ego, soul
[aman]	believe	[ʔɪman]	Faith, belief
[bahɛɾ]	ocean/sea	[baħɾ]	ocean/sea
[sɛma͡ɪ]	sky	[samaːʔ]	sky
[mɪʔɪɾab]	west	[maɣɾɪb]	west
[bunni]	brown	[bunni]	brown
[amɛt]	year	[ʕaːm]	year
[saʔat]	time	[saːʕa(t)]	time
[dɛm]	blood	[dam]	blood
[hulum]	all	[kullahum]	all
bɛɾɛd	cold	b-ɾ-d	cold
[man]	who	[man]	who
[mɛbɾɛk’]	lightning	[baɾq]	lightning
[ras]	head	[raʔs]	head
[sɛt]	Woman	[sɛt]	Woman, lady
[bɪɾtʰuˈkʰɑn]	orange	[buɾtʰuˈqal]	orange
[tawahɪdo]	Christianity	[tawħid]	Monotheism
[hun]	Be! (IMP)	[kun]	Be! (IMP)

[s’ɛgur]	Hair	[ʃaʕɾ]	Hair
[hul:aʧum]	All.2pl (all of you)	[kul:akum]	All.2pl (all of you)
[.mɛɾ.'kɛ̪.]	boat	[.mɛɾ.'kɛ̪]	boat
[manbɛb]	To read	[jɛtɛnnɛbaʔ]	To prophesize, read the future
[k'ulf]	key	[qufl]	lock
[ɛgɛɾ]	leg	[ɪʒɾ][34]	leg
[zɛitʰ]	oil	[zɛitʰ]	oil
[wɛladʒ]	parents	[walidaɪ̯n]	parents
[kh^ok^ob]	Star	[kɑʊkɪb]	Star
[hakim]	Doctor	[hakim]	Ruler, wise one
[dɛk’ik’a]	Minute	[daqiqa]	Minute
[mɛɾeitʰ]	ground	[aɾd]	ground
[fɛɾes]	horse	[faɾasa]	horse
[k’was]	Ball	[qaws]	Curve, twist, bow
[mɛt’ɛb]	Wash, clean	[tˁɪb]	Medicine, to treat medically
[mɛskʰɛrɛm]	New month	kʰɛɾi:m	Generous, fortunate[35]
[k’urs]	Phase of the moon	[qurs]	Disk shaped object
[malɛt]	To say	[qala]	To say
[lɪbsotʃ]	clothes	[mulɛbɪs]	clothes

[34] More common in Syrian Arabic than Classical Arabic

[35] Often used in greetings for the beginnings of months. For example, one says [ɾamadˁan kʰɛɾi:m], ‘generous Ramadan,’ at the start of the month of Ramadan

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